

Power and Conflict: the 15 poems

Everything you need for the Power and Conflict poetry question: what each poem means, the quotations to learn, the context, the best poems to compare, and model answers that show you how to reach the top marks.

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A What Q26 asks you to do

Read this first. It explains the question in plain English.

On the exam paper, one of the 15 poems is printed in full. The question asks you to compare how poets present an idea (a theme) in that poem and in **one other poem that you choose** from the 15 Power and Conflict poems. The second poem is **not** printed, so you write about it from memory.

The question always looks like this:

Compare how poets present [a theme, for example “ideas about power”] **in** [the printed poem] **and in one other poem from ‘Power and conflict’.** [30 marks]

YOU MUST WRITE ABOUT TWO POEMS

If you only write about the printed poem, AQA's mark scheme says your answer can be “capped” at the top of Level 2. That means a **maximum of 10 out of 30**, however good it is. So always choose a second poem and write about both.

TIME AND MARKS

Section B is worth **30 of the 96 marks** on Paper 2. AQA doesn't set a time for each section; about **45 minutes** is a sensible guide (5 minutes planning, 40 minutes writing). **timing is advice, not an AQA rule**

WHICH POEMS COULD COME UP?

All 15 are listed on the exam paper, and any of them can be the printed poem. AQA's specification says students “should study all 15 poems in their chosen cluster and be prepared to write about any of them in the examination.” The paper also lists two other clusters (Love and relationships, and Worlds and lives): you only answer the Power and conflict question.

B Where the 30 marks come from

AQA's mark scheme splits the marks into three "assessment objectives" (AOs).

AO1 · IDEAS AND ARGUMENT

12

A clear argument that answers the question, compares the two poems, and uses well-chosen references.

AO2 · HOW THE POETS WRITE

12

Analysis of the poets' words, structure and form, and the *effect* of their choices.

AO3 · CONTEXT

6

The ideas, times and situations behind the poems, linked to the question.

WHAT THE TOP LEVEL (26–30 MARKS) LOOKS LIKE, IN AQA'S WORDS

"a critical, exploratory, well-structured argument. It takes a conceptualised approach to the full task supported by a range of judicious references to the text. There will be a fine-grained and insightful analysis of methods supported by judicious use of subject terminology. Convincing exploration of themes/ideas/perspectives/contextual factors/interpretations." AQA mark scheme, June 2025

In plain English: have one big idea that answers the question and keep proving it; choose short, precise quotations; zoom in on individual words and explain their effect; use technical terms only where they help; and link context to the poems' ideas.

Good news: AQA says examiners should "reward any valid interpretations". The readings in this guide are strong options, not the only right answers.

HOW TO GET THE AO2 MARKS (LANGUAGE, STRUCTURE, FORM)

- **Explain effects, don't just name techniques.** AQA's 2022 report: spotting techniques “will not achieve above Level 2 AO2 if it is not tied to meaning.”
- **Zoom in on single words.** “You don't need to label parts of speech in order to do well. If you want to talk about the effect of a particular word choice, just use the word ‘word!’” (2023 report)
- **For structure, use openings, endings and turning points.** AQA's 2023 report says helpful structure points are “openings/endings, plot development, changes of pace / scene”.
- **You don't have to cover everything.** The mark scheme rewards “language and/or structure and/or form”, and the 2023 report says structure is not “a requirement”.
- **Avoid** listing rhyme schemes (“the observation of a rhyme scheme [ABAB] is best avoided”, 2022) and empty form comments such as “sonnets are love poems”.
- **A realistic target:** 3–4 short quotations analysed closely from each poem, plus one or two structure or form points linked to meaning. **our advice**

c The theme map: every question is about a theme

Every Q26 asks how poets present a theme. So far, every question has been about **power** or about **conflict and its effects**.

Exam	Printed poem	The question asked how poets present...	Theme
June 2025	Exposure	"ideas about conflict"	Conflict
June 2024	Kamikaze	"the ways people are affected by conflict"	Effects of conflict
June 2023	My Last Duchess	"the effects of power"	Power
June 2022	Bayonet Charge	"ideas about conflict"	Conflict
Nov 2021	London	"ideas about power and control"	Power
Nov 2020	Remains	"the ways people are affected by difficult experiences"	Difficult experiences
June 2019	War Photographer	"the ways that people are affected by war"	Effects of war
June 2018	Ozymandias	"ideas about power"	Power
June 2017	Bayonet Charge	"the effects of war"	Effects of war
Specimen	Ozymandias	"ideas about power"	Power

Source: AQA question papers. There were no exams in summer 2020 or 2021; Nov 2021 and June 2022 used a separate Covid-era poetry paper.

Which poems fit each theme?

Theme	Poems AQA links to it (mark schemes, questions, reports)	Best anchor
Power	Ozymandias, London, My Last Duchess, Extract from The Prelude, Storm on the Island, The Charge of the Light Brigade, Exposure, Bayonet Charge, Remains, Kamikaze, Checking Out Me History, The Emigrée (and weakly Tissue, Poppies)	Ozymandias

Tyranny (abuse of power)	Ozymandias, London, My Last Duchess	Ozymandias
Conflict and war	Bayonet Charge, Exposure, Kamikaze, Remains, War Photographer, The Charge of the Light Brigade, Poppies, The Emigrée, London, Checking Out Me History, Tissue, Storm on the Island	Remains
Effects of conflict / difficult experiences	Remains, War Photographer, Kamikaze, Bayonet Charge, Exposure, Poppies, The Emigrée, Tissue, The Charge of the Light Brigade, Checking Out Me History, London	Remains
Nature (and its power)	Storm on the Island, Extract from The Prelude, Exposure, Bayonet Charge, Kamikaze, Poppies	Storm on the Island
Time	Ozymandias, Storm on the Island, Extract from The Prelude	Ozymandias
Identity, place and home	Checking Out Me History, The Emigrée, Tissue	(no anchor; learn one of these if you have time)
Patriotism and duty	Bayonet Charge (our reading also fits The Charge of the Light Brigade, Exposure and Kamikaze)	Remains

Themes AQA hasn't named (our readings): memory, loss, guilt, fear, isolation and childhood also run through many poems, for example memory and guilt in Remains, and loss in Poppies. They appear on the poem pages as dashed tags. They are still good ideas to write about if a question touches on them.

Source: our analysis of AQA's mark-scheme "indicative content" and examiners' reports, specimen to 2025.

HOW TO READ THE THEME TAGS ON EACH POEM PAGE

Power · AQA question 2018

A **solid** tag means an AQA question, mark scheme or examiners' report links the poem to this theme. The source is shown.

Tyranny · our reading

A **dashed** tag is a sensible reading of the poem that AQA hasn't named. You can still use it.

D Which poem do I use? Your three anchor poems

Learn three poems really well, and you will always have a strong partner for whichever poem is printed.

★ OZYMANDIAS

Your **power** poem: a proud king whose power has crumbled to dust.

★ REMAINS

Your **conflict** poem: a soldier haunted by guilt after he comes home.

★ STORM ON THE ISLAND

Your **nature** poem, and your partner when Ozymandias or Remains is the printed poem.

If this is printed...	Write about	Why it works	Backed by AQA?
Ozymandias	Storm on the Island	Human power is temporary; nature is stronger	Yes: specimen and 2018 mark schemes
London	Ozymandias	Two poets attack those in power	Yes: “an excellent choice” (2021 report)
Extract from The Prelude	Storm on the Island	Nature terrifies a confident human	Yes: 2018 and 2023 mark schemes
My Last Duchess	Ozymandias	Two arrogant rulers, exposed by their own words	Yes: one of the two most popular choices in 2023
The Charge of the Light Brigade	Remains	Soldiers following orders: glory, or guilt?	Yes: 2017 and 2024 mark schemes
Exposure	Storm on the Island	Conflict with nature: the weather as the enemy	Yes: 2025 mark scheme (see model answer 3)
Storm on the Island	Ozymandias	Nature's power against human power	Yes: specimen and 2018 mark schemes
Bayonet Charge	Remains	One soldier's terror, during and after	Yes: 2017 mark scheme; “worked well” (2022 report)
Remains	Storm on the Island	A difficult experience, and fear that stays	Yes: 2020 mark scheme
Poppies	Remains	How war affects people long after	Partly: both named in the 2017 mark scheme
War Photographer	Remains	Men haunted by what they saw	Yes: 2019 mark scheme

Tissue	Ozymandias	Human power and buildings are fragile	Partly: specimen mark scheme (one method bullet)
The Emigrée	Remains	A memory of conflict that will not leave	Yes: Nov 2020 mark scheme (Remains question)
Checking Out Me History	Ozymandias	Who holds power, and who is remembered	Partly: specimen mark scheme (one method bullet)
Kamikaze	Remains	How conflict affects people afterwards	Yes: 2024 mark scheme

Check the question first. A **power** question → usually Ozymandias. A **conflict** question → usually Remains. A **nature** question → Storm on the Island. AQA's examiners say: choose the poem that fits the question "rather than simply choosing one you know well". Each poem page also suggests up to three partners.

E What examiners say

Copied word for word from AQA's examiners' reports (Nov 2020, Nov 2021, June 2022, June 2023).

DO THIS

- **Start with a thesis.** "Students who began their answer with a thesis statement that they could develop / explain / illustrate during their response, and perhaps return to at the end, tended to be more successful with AO1." (2020)
- **Simple structure is fine.** "You can get just as many marks by offering an introduction that shows your understanding of the connection between the named poem and the one you have chosen to use, then dealing with each poem separately, then perhaps drawing the two poems together at the end of your response." (2023)
- **Short quotations.** "A well-selected word or phrase from the text is often much more effective than a long direct quotation." (2023)
- **Context = the question's ideas.** "The focus for AO3 will be in the question – just talk about that. Know the what, the how and the why." (2023)
- **Think wider than the story.** "some of the best responses took a wider approach to the task focus" (2020).

AVOID THIS

- **Only writing about the printed poem.** In 2020 some students "only responded to the named poem".
- **Formula paragraphs.** They "tended to become self-contained 'mini-essays'" and "encourage bolted-on context" (2020).
- **Bolted-on history.** "paragraphs about, for example, Owen's war experiences, Hughes' father as a soldier or extraneous information about Guardsman Tromans were not useful if they meant the student lost sight of the poem." (2022)
- **Misreading My Last Duchess.** Some thought the Duke "is grieving the loss of his first wife, which means they missed the point of the poem entirely." (2023)

Reassurance: "Don't worry if you can't remember exact quotations. It's fine to pinpoint parts of a poem and it's also understandable if you slightly misquote because the examiner will get the idea." (AQA examiners' report, 2022)

Ozymandias

Percy Bysshe Shelley (1792–1822) · published 1818

01

★ ANCHOR POEM: learn this one first

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Power · AQA questions (specimen, 2018)

Pride · AQA mark scheme 2018 (Ozymandias question)

Nature · our reading

Time · AQA examiners' report 2023; mark scheme 2018

Tyranny · AQA examiners' report 2023

Art outlasts power · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Sonnet (14 lines)

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: specimen and June 2018

BEST PARTNER

Storm on the Island

THE STORY IN SHORT

A traveller describes a giant statue of an ancient king, now broken and lying in the empty desert.

THE MESSAGE

However powerful people think they are, their power doesn't last. Time and nature outlive everyone.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Shelley was a radical (someone who wants big changes to society) who rejected kings and the powerful. This poem quietly mocks a tyrant.

THE TITLE

"Ozymandias" is the Greek name for the Egyptian pharaoh Ramesses II. By naming the poem after a real, famous king, Shelley makes it about all-powerful rulers, not just one statue. (University of Toronto; Britannica)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The poet tells us what a traveller told him about a trip to an “antique land” (an ancient country). So we hear the story second-hand.

Lines 1–3

In the desert stand two huge stone legs. The rest of the statue's body has gone.

Lines 4–5

Nearby, the statue's broken face lies half-buried in the sand. It still has a frown and a cruel “sneer of cold command”.

Lines 6–8

The sculptor understood exactly what this king was like and carved his arrogance into the stone. The king is long dead, but the carving still shows his character.

Lines 9–11

Words on the base boast that he is “king of kings”. They tell other powerful rulers to look at his achievements and “despair”, because they'll never match him.

Lines 12–14

But there are no achievements left to see. Only empty sand, stretching as far as the eye can see.

The turning point: The killer moment (line 12): “Nothing beside remains.” Straight after the boast, three blunt words show it was empty. **How it ends:** On the desert, not the king. Nature and time get the last word. **The tone:** Calm and quietly mocking. Shelley doesn't need to attack the king; the ruins do it for him.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam.

THE POEM

I met a traveller from an antique land
Who said: Two vast and trunkless legs of
stone
Stand in the desert. Near them on the sand,

Half sunk, a shatter'd visage lies, whose
frown
And wrinkled lip and sneer of cold command

Tell that its sculptor well those passions read
Which yet survive, stamp'd on these lifeless
things,
The hand that mock'd them and the heart that
fed;

And on the pedestal these words appear:
'My name is Ozymandias, king of kings:
Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!'

Nothing beside remains. Round the decay
Of that colossal wreck, boundless and bare,
The lone and level sands stretch far away.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Someone tells the poet about a trip to an ancient country. All that's left of a giant statue is two legs. **"trunkless"** = the body (trunk) has gone.

Near the legs, the broken face (**"visage"** = face) is half-buried. It still shows a cruel, bossy sneer. This king looked down on everyone.

The sculptor "read" the king's feelings well and carved them in stone. **"mock'd"** means copied, and also made fun of. The art has lasted; the king hasn't.

The king's boast, carved on the base, tells other rulers to look at what he built and give up, because they can never match him. **Irony:** there's nothing left to look at.

Just empty desert all around the huge ("colossal") ruin. Time and nature have beaten the "king of kings".

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"I met a traveller from an antique land"

Means: the story is second-hand and very old.

Why it matters: the king is pushed far into the past.

LINE 2

"Two vast and trunkless legs of stone"

Means: huge, but broken. **Why it matters:** his ambition is now just fragments.

LINE 4

"Half sunk, a shatter'd visage lies"

Means: his face is sinking into the sand. **Why it matters:** words like "sunk" and "shatter'd" show collapse.

LINE 5

"sneer of cold command"

Means: he was a cruel, bossy ruler. **Technique:** alliteration; the hard "c" sounds feel harsh.

LINE 8

"The hand that mock'd them and the heart that fed"

Means: the artist copied, and mocked, the king.
Why it matters: art judges the tyrant.

LINE 10

"My name is Ozymandias, king of kings:"

Means: he thought he was the greatest ruler ever.
Technique: a boastful title, full of pride.

LINE 11

"Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!"

Means: give up: you'll never beat me. **Technique:** a command (imperative), now ironic.

LINES 12 AND 14

"Nothing beside remains." / "The lone and level sands stretch far away."

Means: nothing is left but desert. **Technique:** a short blunt sentence, then alliteration.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: what a sonnet is, and what Shelley does with it

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **14-line poem**, usually in **iambic pentameter**: about ten syllables a line, in a da-DUM, da-DUM rhythm.
- It began in Italy and was perfected by the poet **Petrarch** in the 14th century. *Britannica; EBSCO*
- Traditionally used for **love poems**, but later poets used it for other subjects, including politics. *Britannica; EBSCO* **politics: one source**
- **Why poets use it**: it is built like an argument. It sets up a problem, then a **volta** (Italian for “turn”) changes direction to answer it. *Britannica; poets.org; Poetry Archive*
- **Petrarchan (Italian)**: 8 lines (octave) + 6 lines (sestet); rhyme ABBAABBA, then CDECDE or similar; the turn comes between lines 8 and 9: the octave sets up a problem, the sestet answers it. *Britannica; poets.org; EBSCO*
- **Shakespearean (English)**: three 4-line quatrains + a 2-line couplet; rhyme ABAB CDCD EFEF GG; the final couplet often sums up or twists the argument. *Britannica; poets.org; Poetry Archive*

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **So which type is Ozymandias? Neither**: Shelley breaks the rules.
- It has **14 lines of iambic pentameter**, the traditional elements. *Gale, Poetry for Students*
- But its rhyme scheme is **ABABACDCEDEFEF**, which matches neither type: “Rather than adhere to the English or Petrarchan rhyme schemes, Shelley does something different”. *Gale; University of Toronto*
- There is **no neat rhyming couplet** at the end, so the poem refuses a tidy ending.
- Its **sense** splits like a Petrarchan sonnet, 8 lines then 6, but the rhymes run across the split (“things” in line 7 rhymes with “kings” in line 10). *EBSCO; our check*
- **Why it matters**: one critic suggests the rhyme scheme “gradually changes over time, just as the subject matter (Ozymandias's statue) does.” *Gale* A broken, shifting form for a broken, crumbling statue.
- **The turn**: the octave describes the ruined statue; line 9, “And on the pedestal these words appear:”, turns to the king's own boast, and the sestet shows how hollow it is.
our reading AQA's specimen mark scheme invites comments on the “use / effect of volta”.

A sentence you could use: Shelley writes a sonnet, a tightly controlled form, but breaks its rules: the rhyme scheme fits neither the Petrarchan nor the Shakespearean pattern, and there is no closing couplet. Like the statue, the form itself is half-ruined, so even the shape of the poem shows that power cannot hold together.

Three voices, one inside another

The poet, then the traveller, then the king's words on the stone. Each layer pushes the king further into the past.

Frame narrative: a story told inside another story.

Irony

The boast “*Look on my works*” is followed straight away by “*Nothing beside remains.*” The poem itself proves the boast wrong.

Irony: when the result is the opposite of what someone meant or expected.

Ending on the sand

The last image is the desert, not the king. AQA's 2018 mark scheme suggests writing about the sand as a “metaphor for the passing of time and impermanence of human constructions” (impermanence = not lasting).

Metaphor: describing one thing as if it were another.

A sudden stop

Line 12 breaks off after “*Nothing beside remains.*” The full stop in the middle of the line is a sudden silence straight after the king's shouting.

Caesura: a pause or break in the middle of a line of poetry.

Examiners warn: don't write “he uses a sonnet because sonnets are love poems”. AQA's 2023 report says this argument goes nowhere. Link the form to the poem's meaning instead.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO SHELLEY WAS

Born in 1792 into a rich Sussex family; his father was an MP. Went to Eton, then Oxford.

Britannica

Britannica calls him the “most politically radical” of the Romantic poets: “He rejected the monarchy, religion, war, and commerce.”

Britannica **power · tyranny**

Oxford expelled him in 1811 for refusing to say whether he wrote a pamphlet called *The Necessity of Atheism*. Britannica; University College

Oxford **power · rebellion**

He believed poets could change society. In a later essay (published 1840) he wrote: “Poets are the unacknowledged legislators of the world.” Britannica **art outlasts power**

He married Mary Godwin, who wrote *Frankenstein* (1818). He drowned off Italy in 1822, aged 29. Britannica

BRITAIN WHEN HE WROTE IT

King George III had been declared insane in 1811, so his unpopular son ruled as Prince Regent. Britannica **power · rulers**

Criticising the ruler was dangerous: the editors of *The Examiner*, the paper that printed Ozymandias, were jailed in 1813 for attacking the Prince Regent. Britannica; University of Iowa

tyranny

Napoleon, whose army had invaded Egypt in 1798, was finally defeated at Waterloo in 1815.

Britannica **power doesn't last** **link is our reading**

After the poem: at Peterloo (1819), soldiers attacked a peaceful protest in Manchester, killing about 11 people. Shelley answered with *The Mask of Anarchy*. Britannica; University of

Manchester **power vs the people**

THE REAL KING AND THE REAL STATUE

“Ozymandias” is the Greek name for Ramesses II, a pharaoh of Egypt in the 13th century BC.

University of Toronto; Britannica **pride · power**

An ancient Greek historian, Diodorus, recorded the statue's boast: “King of Kings am I, Osymandyas. If anyone would know how great I am and where I lie, let him surpass one of my works.” Shelley's line 10 echoes it. Diodorus

(University of Chicago); University of Toronto **pride**

Members of Napoleon's expedition to Egypt are said to have tried and failed to remove a huge stone bust of Ramesses; a hole in it is said to be theirs. Belzoni removed it in 1816 and it reached the British Museum in 1818, after the poem was published. British Museum (via Google

Arts & Culture); Britannica **power · empire**

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT

Shelley wrote it in a friendly competition with his friend Horace Smith; both wrote a sonnet called “Ozymandias”. Britannica; University of Toronto

It appeared in *The Examiner*, a radical newspaper, on 11 January 1818, under the made-up name “Glirastes”. Britannica; University of Toronto **tyranny**

Shelley was a second-generation Romantic, with Keats and Byron. The Romantics valued imagination, feeling and nature. Britannica

nature · time

AQA's 2023 examiners' report praised essays that saw the Romantics “as disrupters / advocates for social change”. AQA 2023 examiners' report **power**

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Shelley published the poem in January 1818, when Britain was ruled by an unpopular Prince Regent and newspaper editors could be jailed for criticising him. By showing a king who called himself “*king of kings*” reduced to a broken statue, he suggests that every ruler's power will fade too.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

A

Ozymandias + Storm on the Island

Use for: **Nature** **Power** · AQA: specimen and 2018 mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both show human power is weaker than nature: the king's empire is now “*lone and level sands*”; the islanders are helpless as the wind “*strafes invisibly*.”
- Both show confidence that turns out to be hollow: “*king of kings*” and “*We are prepared:*”

DIFFERENT

- Speed:** in Ozymandias nature wins slowly, over thousands of years. In Storm it attacks right now: “*Space is a salvo,*”
- Voice:** Ozymandias is told second-hand by a traveller, so it feels distant. Storm is spoken by a “we” living through it, so it feels close and frightening.
- Ending:** Shelley ends calmly mocking (“*Nothing beside remains.*”); Heaney ends in fear (“*a huge nothing that we fear.*”)

B

Ozymandias + My Last Duchess

Use for: **Power** **Pride** · AQA: specimen mark scheme (“despotism”); one of the two most popular partners in 2023, with London (examiners' report)

SIMILAR

- Both show an arrogant ruler, proud of his status: “*king of kings*” and “*My gift of a nine-hundred-years-old name*”
- Both rulers are judged through a work of art: a statue and a portrait.
- Both rulers give themselves away through their own words.

DIFFERENT

- Whose power:** Ozymandias ruled a kingdom; the Duke controls one woman, and brought about her death: “*I gave commands; / Then all smiles stopped together.*”
- Does the power last?** Ozymandias's power has crumbled to nothing. The Duke's power is still alive: he is arranging his next marriage.
- Form:** a short sonnet told second-hand, against a long dramatic monologue in the Duke's own voice.



Ozymandias + London

Use for: **Power** · AQA: 2018 mark scheme; "an excellent choice" (2021 examiners' report)

SIMILAR

- Both poets attack those in power: a tyrant king, and the Church and palace.
- Both show the marks power leaves behind: the "sneer of cold command" carved in stone, and "Marks of weakness, marks of woe" on people's faces.

DIFFERENT

- **Who suffers:** Shelley focuses on the ruler; Blake focuses on the ordinary people who suffer: "Runs in blood down palace walls."
- **Does the power last?** Shelley shows power fading. Blake shows it everywhere and still crushing people: "The mind-forged manacles I hear"
- **Voice:** second-hand and distant, against Blake's first-person "I", walking the streets now.

7 In the exam

Compare how poets present ideas about power in 'Ozymandias' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (AQA, June 2018)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Shelley and Heaney show that human power is weaker than it looks, but Shelley shows it fading slowly over time, while Heaney shows nature attacking it head-on.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present human power as fragile when set against nature. Shelley's ruler calls himself "king of kings", yet the poem replies with the blunt sentence "Nothing beside remains." His empire has become "lone and level sands": nature has defeated him slowly, over thousands of years. Heaney's islanders also begin confidently, claiming "We are prepared", but the storm attacks them right now. The wind "strafes invisibly" and "Space is a salvo", military words that make nature an army they cannot fight. Where Shelley ends calmly mocking the tyrant's pride, Heaney ends in fear of "a huge nothing". Together they suggest that human power, whether a king's or a community's, is weaker than it looks.

Why it scores:

- Opens with a clear point that answers the question about power
- Short quotations from both poems, each one explained
- Compares all the way through ("also", "Where...") and names methods

London

William Blake (1757–1827) · published 1794

02

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Power · AQA question Nov 2021

Tyranny · AQA examiners' report 2023

Conflict · AQA mark schemes 2019 and 2022

Difficult experiences · AQA mark scheme Nov 2020

Childhood · our reading

Place and home · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

**Four quatrains (16 lines),
ABAB rhyme**

IN THE EXAM?

**Yes: November 2021 (printed
poem)**

BEST PARTNER

Ozymandias

THE STORY IN SHORT

A man walks through the streets of London. Everywhere he looks and listens, he finds people who are suffering.

THE MESSAGE

The people with power (the Church, the king and the rich) are crushing ordinary people, and people's own minds keep them trapped.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Blake was a Londoner and a radical (someone who wants big changes to society) who opposed the monarchy. He wrote this in the years of the French Revolution, when questioning power was dangerous **our reading**.

poets.org; Tate; British Library

THE TITLE

Just one word: the name of Britain's capital, where Blake was born and died. By naming a real city, Blake makes the poem a direct attack on his own society, not a made-up place. Britannica calls the poem “a critical commentary on the social and political conditions of London during Blake's time.” (Britannica; poets.org)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker ("I") walks through London's streets. He tells us what he sees, and then, more and more, what he hears.

Lines 1–4

He wanders through streets, and near a river, that are "chartered": owned and controlled. In every face he meets he sees signs of weakness and sadness.

Lines 5–8

He hears the same misery in every cry, from grown men to frightened babies. Behind it all he hears "*mind-forged manacles*": chains made by the mind.

Lines 9–10

He hears the cry of child chimney sweeps. The soot-blackened churches should be horrified by it, but they do nothing.

Lines 11–12

He hears the sigh of an unlucky soldier, and pictures it as blood running down the walls of the royal palace.

Lines 13–16

Worst of all, at midnight he hears a young prostitute cursing. Her curse (and her disease) harms new-born babies and turns marriage into a funeral.

The turning point (line 13): "*But most*". The poem has built up from faces to cries, and now Blake tells us the very worst sound of all comes at night. **How it ends:** On death and disease spreading into marriage and new life. The poem ends with no hope and no way out. **The tone:** Angry and bitter, but tightly controlled. The steady, song-like rhythm makes the horror feel endless.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam.

THE POEM

I wander through each chartered street,
Near where the chartered Thames does flow,
And mark in every face I meet
Marks of weakness, marks of woe.

In every cry of every man,
In every infant's cry of fear,
In every voice, in every ban,
The mind-forged manacles I hear:

How the chimney-sweeper's cry
Every black'ning church appalls,
And the hapless soldier's sigh
Runs in blood down palace walls.

But most through midnight streets I hear
How the youthful harlot's curse
Blasts the new-born infant's tear,
And blights with plagues the marriage hearse.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

"chartered" = mapped out and owned by someone, given rights by a legal document called a charter. Even the river is controlled.
"mark" = notice; **"Marks"** = scars or signs. Suffering is written on everyone's face.

"ban" = a curse, or an official order forbidding something. **"manacles"** = handcuffs or chains. They are "mind-forged": people are trapped by their own fear and acceptance, not only by metal.

Child chimney sweeps cry. **"appalls"** = horrifies, and also makes pale; the church is turning black with soot (and guilt) instead.
"hapless" = unlucky. The soldier suffers and dies for the king, so his blood is on the palace walls.

"harlot" = prostitute, here a young girl. Her curse, and the disease she passes on, harms babies and married couples. **"blights"** = ruins, infects. A **"hearse"** carries a coffin, so "marriage hearse" joins a wedding and a funeral.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINES 1-2

*"I wander through each chartered street, /
Near where the chartered Thames does flow,"*

Means: everything, even the river, is owned and controlled. **Why it matters:** the repeated "chartered" shows power reaching every corner of the city.

LINE 4

"Marks of weakness, marks of woe."

Means: pain and sadness show on every face.

Technique: repetition and alliteration; a pun on "mark" (notice) and "marks" (signs or scars).

LINES 5–6

“In every cry of every man, / In every infant’s cry of fear,”

Means: everyone suffers, from adults to babies.

Technique: repetition: “every” comes seven times in the poem.

LINE 8

“The mind-forged manacles I hear:”

Means: people are chained by their own minds.

Technique: metaphor; the repeated “m” sounds feel heavy, like chains.

LINES 9–10

“How the chimney-sweeper’s cry / Every black’ning church appalls,”

Means: the Church ignores child workers. **Why it**

matters: the church is “black’ning”: dirty with soot and with guilt.

LINES 11–12

“And the hapless soldier’s sigh / Runs in blood down palace walls.”

Means: soldiers die for the king. **Technique:**

metaphor: a sigh turns into blood, so the palace is guilty.

LINE 16

“And blights with plagues the marriage hearse.”

Means: disease and death spread even into

marriage. **Technique:** oxymoron: a wedding joined to a funeral.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a simple song with a terrible message

ABOUT THE FORM

- London has **four quatrains** (4-line stanzas) with an **ABAB** rhyme scheme: *street / flow / meet / woe*. [our count](#)
- One critic calls them “**ballad quatrains**”: the plain, regular stanza of songs and ballads. [Cash, English Association](#) [one source](#)
- The rhythm is mostly **iambic tetrameter**: four beats a line, da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM da-DUM. [Cash, English Association](#) [one source](#)
- It comes from **Songs of Innocence and of Experience**. Blake modelled the songs on simple moral songs written for children, like Isaac Watts's *Divine Songs* (1715), then turned them upside down. [British Library](#)

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Why use a nursery-song shape for horror?** The neat, regular form clashes with what it describes. Cash (“sardonic” means grimly mocking) calls it a “sardonic conflict between the alternate rhymes of his ballad quatrains and the grotesque experience which they describe.” [Cash](#) [one source](#)
- **The beat is like walking.** The steady four-beat lines match the speaker's footsteps, and the misery never stops. [our reading](#) The Poetry Archive introduction praises its “pounding rhythm”. [Poetry Archive](#)
- **The rhythm breaks in stanzas 3–4.** Lines like “*How the chimney-sweeper's cry*” have only seven syllables and start on a strong beat, so they hit harder. [our count](#)
- **No escape in the structure.** Each stanza moves to a darker place: faces, cries, Church and palace, then midnight. The last line ends on a “hearse”. [our reading](#)
- **Seeing, then hearing.** The poem starts with “mark” (seeing) but switches to “*I hear*” (lines 8 and 13). Cash notes that the experience of the city is “auditory”. [Cash; our check](#) [one source](#)

A sentence you could use: Blake uses regular ABAB quatrains, the simple shape of a children's song, to describe child labour, war and disease; the clash between the neat form and the ugly content makes the suffering more shocking, and the steady beat suggests it never ends.

Relentless repetition

“every” comes seven times, and “cry” three times. Blake piles them up so the suffering seems to be everywhere and to affect everyone. AQA's 2021 mark scheme rewards comments on “repetition”.

Repetition: using the same word or phrase again and again for effect.

A mind in chains

“*mind-forged manacles*” is the poem's most famous image. Do people accept their misery because they have been taught to? AQA's 2021 report noted students “offering different interpretations of what Blake might have been saying”.

Metaphor: describing one thing as if it were another.

Blaming the powerful

Blake names the institutions: the “*church*” and the “*palace*”. The suffering of the weak (a child sweep, a soldier) is pinned on them, as dirt and blood on their walls.

Symbolism: when an object stands for a bigger idea (the palace stands for the king and the state).

A shocking final image

“*marriage hearse*” joins a wedding and a funeral. Cash says this “powerful oxymoron ‘marriage hearse’ suggests that nobody is immune” Cash, English Association **one source**. Even new life and love are poisoned.

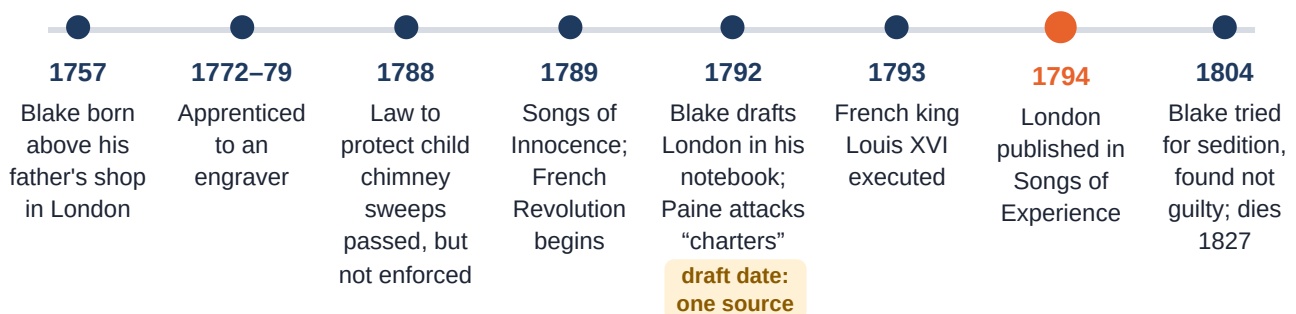
Oxymoron: two opposite ideas placed side by side.

Examiners warn: in 2023, answers that discussed the “responsibilities / abuse of power” did much better than those “who stayed within the particulars of the poems in ‘My Last Duchess’, ‘Ozymandias’ or ‘London’”. Don't just retell the street scenes: say what Blake is arguing about power.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO BLAKE WAS

Born in 1757 above his father's hosiery (stocking) shop in Soho, London. He died in London too, though he lived by the sea at Felpham, Sussex, from 1800 to 1803. Britannica; poets.org **place**

Apprenticed to an engraver at 14 for seven years. Britannica calls him an “engraver, artist, poet, and visionary”. As a child he said he saw “a tree filled with angels”. Britannica; poets.org

He printed and hand-coloured his own books with his wife Catherine. She could not write when they married (she signed with an X), so he taught her to read and write. Britannica; Tate; poets.org

Little known in his lifetime, he was “generally neglected or (unjustly) dismissed as mad”, and spent his last years “in great poverty”. Britannica; poets.org **powerlessness**

BLAKE THE RADICAL

He “associated with some of the leading radical thinkers of his day, including Thomas Paine and Mary Wollstonecraft.” poets.org **power · rebellion**

one source

His poems of the early 1790s “express his opposition to the English monarchy, and to eighteenth-century political and social tyranny in general.” poets.org; Britannica (“daringly political”)

tyranny · palace

He attacked religion run by the state, calling it “The Abomination that maketh desolate”. A friend said he did not go to church for his last forty years. Britannica **the Church** **one source**

In 1803 soldiers accused him of having “Damned the King of England”. He was tried for sedition (stirring up rebellion) and found not guilty in 1804. Britannica **power · control**

one source

Britannica calls him “the earliest and most original of the Romantic poets”. AQA's mark scheme links London to “Romantic ideas about power”. Britannica; AQA specimen mark scheme **power**

LONDON IN THE 1790S

The French Revolution broke out in 1789; the French king was executed in 1793. Tate says the “mind-forg’d manacles” may be the “deeply ingrained respect for tradition and institutions that stopped the people of London from following the example of revolutionary Paris.”

Tate; Britannica **power · control**

the manacles reading: one source

Poor parents “often sold their children as ‘climbing boys’ to a master sweep at around the age of five.” Some suffocated in chimneys; the soot could cause cancer. Tate; London Museum

childhood · powerlessness

A law in 1788 tried to control the use of child sweeps, “But it wasn’t enforced.” One teacher’s article says there was “no effective legislation” to protect them until 1834. London Museum; Cash,

English Association **abuse of power**

1834: one source

“**Chartered**”: a charter is a legal document giving rights to a town, company or group. In 1792 Thomas Paine wrote: “It is a perversion of terms to say that a charter gives rights. It operates by a contrary effect--that of taking rights away.” One critic, Peter Cash, quotes this passage to explain Blake’s word “chartered”.

Paine, Rights of Man Part II; Cash, English Association

power and control **one source**

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT

“William Blake composed his poem ‘London’ in the summer of 1792.” His handwritten draft survives in his notebook, now in the British Library. British Library **one source**

In the draft, Blake changed “dirty” to “chartered”, and “German-forged” to “mind-forged”. The king, George III, came from a German (Hanoverian) family, so Cash suggests the first version blamed the royal family. Cash,

English Association **power · control** **one source**

Published in *Songs of Innocence and of Experience* (1794), subtitled “the two contrary states of the human soul”. Experience poems “centre on threatened, unprotected souls in despair.” Britannica; Tate; poets.org

childhood · powerlessness

Tate and Cash date it 1793; “threatened, unprotected souls”: one source (Britannica)

The British Library calls the poem’s ending a “howl of outrage” at “the abuse of children”.

British Library **abuse of power** **one source**

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Blake wrote London in 1792–94, when the French Revolution had overthrown a king and British radicals like Paine were attacking charters that took people’s rights away. By blaming the “church” and “palace” for the suffering of child sweeps and soldiers, Blake argues that those in power have abused it, and by calling the chains “mind-forged” he challenges ordinary people to stop accepting it.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

London + Ozymandias

A

Use for: **Power** **Tyranny** · AQA: "an excellent choice" (Nov 2021 examiners' report); paired in the 2018 mark scheme

SIMILAR

- Both poets attack those in power: Blake blames the "church" and "palace"; Shelley mocks a tyrant who called himself "king of kings".
- Both show power leaving marks on people: "Marks of weakness, marks of woe" on Londoners' faces, and the "sneer of cold command" carved in stone.

DIFFERENT

- **Who we see:** Blake shows the victims (sweeps, soldiers, babies); Shelley shows only the ruler, and the people he ruled are missing.
- **Does the power last?** Shelley's tyrant has crumbled: "Nothing beside remains." In London, power is alive now and everywhere: "The mind-forged manacles I hear."
- **Voice:** Blake's "I" walks the streets in the present tense, so it feels urgent. Shelley's story comes second-hand from a traveller, so it feels distant and calm.

London + Checking Out Me History

B

Use for: **Power** **Identity** · AQA: "worked very well" (Nov 2021 examiners' report); paired in the 2023 and 2025 mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both show power controlling people's minds: Blake's "mind-forged manacles" and Agard's "Bandage up me eye with me own history".
- Both speakers protest against the institutions that hold power: Church and palace in London; the education system ("Dem") in Agard.

DIFFERENT

- **Escape:** Agard's speaker breaks free: "I carving out me identity". Blake's Londoners stay trapped, and the poem ends on a "hearse".
- **Voice:** Blake watches others suffer; Agard speaks for himself, in his own Caribbean voice, against what "Dem tell me".
- **Form:** Blake keeps strict ABAB quatrains; Agard breaks the rules with free, changing stanzas, which suits his rebellion.

London + My Last Duchess

C

Use for: **Power** **Control** · AQA: Nov 2021 mark scheme ("political power with personal power used to repress"); "worked very well" (2021 report)

SIMILAR

- Both show power used to crush the less powerful: the Duke silences his wife, *"I gave commands;"*, and London's rulers ignore the *"chimney-sweeper's cry"*.
- Both hint at death caused by power without showing it directly: blood on *"palace walls"*, and *"Then all smiles stopped together."*

DIFFERENT

- **Scale:** AQA's 2021 report praised students who compared power "at a state and an individual level": Blake shows a whole city; Browning shows one man and one woman.
- **Voice:** Blake speaks against the powerful; Browning lets the powerful man speak, so the Duke condemns himself: *"I choose / Never to stoop."*
- **Form:** short song-like quatrains against a long dramatic monologue in rhyming couplets.

7 In the exam

Compare how poets present ideas about power and control in 'London' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (AQA, November 2021)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Blake and Shelley condemn people who abuse power, but while Shelley shows a tyrant's power crumbling away over time, Blake shows power still alive in every street, controlling people's bodies and even their minds.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present power as something that leaves its mark on people. Blake sees *"Marks of weakness, marks of woe"* on every face, and the repetition of "marks" suggests the damage is written on the whole city. Shelley also shows power marking its subjects, but only through the ruler's *"sneer of cold command"*, carved in stone. However, Shelley's tyrant has lost his control: *"Nothing beside remains."* In contrast, Blake's rulers are still in charge, and he hears *"The mind-forged manacles"* in every voice. This metaphor suggests that Londoners are chained by their own fear and acceptance. Writing in the 1790s, when the French Revolution had overthrown a king, Blake seems to challenge his readers to break those chains, while Shelley reassures them that tyrants always fall.

Why it scores:

- Opens with a clear comparative point about power and control
- Short quotations from both poems, each one analysed (repetition, metaphor)
- Uses context (the French Revolution) to explain Blake's purpose, not just as an add-on fact

My Last Duchess

Robert Browning (1812–1889) · published 1842

03

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Power · AQA question 2023

Tyranny · AQA specimen mark scheme ("despotism")

Pride · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Dramatic monologue (56 lines, rhyming couplets)

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: June 2023

BEST PARTNER

Ozymandias

THE STORY IN SHORT

A rich Italian Duke shows a visitor a painting of his dead wife. Bit by bit he hints that he had her killed because she smiled at everyone, not just him.

THE MESSAGE

Power without limits turns into cruelty. The Duke treats women as possessions, and he is about to marry again.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Browning was a Victorian poet famous for the dramatic monologue: he lets a powerful man condemn himself in his own words. Britannica; Baylor University

THE TITLE

“**last**” means most recent, and it hints there will be another: as one editor notes, the Duke “is now negotiating for his next Duchess.” The subtitle “**Ferrara**” names a real city in northern Italy, ruled by dukes in the Renaissance. editor's note: one source (RPO (University of Toronto); Victorian Web)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The whole poem is the Duke talking. His listener is an envoy (a messenger) sent by a Count to arrange the Duke's next marriage. The listener never speaks.

Lines 1–4

The Duke points to a painting of his “last Duchess”. She looks “as if she were alive”, so we know she is dead.

Lines 5–13

He asks the visitor to sit and look. Only he opens the curtain over the painting. Visitors always wonder about her expression.

Lines 14–21

He says her blush (that “spot / Of joy”) did not come only from him. Perhaps even the painter's compliments made her blush, he suggests.

Lines 22–34

She was “Too easily impressed”: sunsets, cherries and her mule pleased her as much as his “nine-hundred-years-old name”. This insults his pride.

Lines 35–43

He would not lower himself to tell her what annoyed him: “I choose / Never to stoop.”

Lines 44–47

She smiled at everyone. “I gave commands; / Then all smiles stopped together.” He had her silenced: probably killed, though Browning once added that she might have been shut in a convent. Then he calmly asks the visitor to stand.

Lines 48–56

Business: he expects a large dowry from the Count, though the daughter is his “object”. Walking downstairs, he shows off a bronze statue of Neptune “Taming a sea-horse”.

The turning point (lines 45–46): “I gave commands; / Then all smiles stopped together.” Six short words hide a murder, and he carries on talking as if nothing happened. **How it ends:** On another possession, a statue made “for me!” He moves from his dead wife to his next bride to his art collection without a pause. **The tone:** Polite, proud and chillingly calm. He is not grieving; he is showing off. The politeness makes the cruelty worse.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam.

THE POEM

That's **my last Duchess** painted on the wall,
Looking as if she were alive. I call
That piece a wonder, now: Frà Pandolf's hands
Worked busily a day, and there she stands.

Will't please you sit and look at her? I said
'Frà Pandolf' by design, for never read
Strangers like you that pictured countenance,
The depth and passion of its earnest glance,
But to myself they turned (since none puts by
The curtain I have drawn for you, but I)
And seemed as they would ask me, if they
durst,
How such a glance came there; so, not the first
Are you to turn and ask thus. Sir, 'twas not

Her husband's presence only, called **that spot**
Of joy into the Duchess' cheek: perhaps
Frà Pandolf chanced to say 'Her mantle laps
Over my lady's wrist too much,' or 'Paint
Must never hope to reproduce the faint
Half-flush that dies along her throat': such
stuff
Was courtesy, she thought, and cause enough
For calling up that spot of joy. She had

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The Duke shows a visitor a painting of his dead wife. **"my"** and **"last"** sound like he owns her, and like she is one in a series. He praises the painting as **"a wonder"**; he never mentions loving her.

He tells the visitor to sit (polite words, but an order). The painting hangs behind a curtain and **only he** may open it. Visitors always want to ask about her look, if they **"durst"** (dared).

The Duke says her blush (the **"spot / Of joy"**) wasn't only for her husband. Even a polite compliment from the painter, a friar (**"Frà"**), could make her blush. He is jealous of everyone.

A heart – how shall I say? – too soon made
glad,

Too easily impressed; she liked whate'er

She looked on, and her looks went
everywhere.

Sir, 'twas all one! My favour at her breast,
The dropping of the daylight in the West,
The bough of cherries some officious fool
Broke in the orchard for her, the white mule
She rode with round the terrace – all and each
Would draw from her alike the approving
speech,

Or blush, at least. She thanked men, – good!
but thanked

Somehow – I know not how – as if she ranked

My gift of a nine-hundred-years-old name

With anybody's gift. Who'd stoop to blame

This sort of trifling? Even had you skill

In speech – (which I have not) – to make your
will

Quite clear to such an one, and say, 'Just this

Or that in you disgusts me; here you miss,

Or there exceed the mark' – and if she let

Herself be lessoned so, nor plainly set

Her wits to yours, forsooth, and made excuse,

– E'en then would be some stooping; and I
choose

Never to stoop. Oh sir, she smiled, no doubt,

His complaint: she was too easily pleased. A
sunset, a gift of cherries, her white mule: all
made her as happy as his gifts did. The dash
and "how shall I say?" show him struggling
to stay smooth.

She thanked people "Somehow" as if his
ancient family name were no better than
anyone else's gift. That is what really angers
him: his pride.

He says he could never tell her off, because
even explaining would be "stooping"
(lowering himself). He claims he lacks "skill /
In speech" while giving a skilful speech.

Whene'er I passed her; but who passed without
Much the same smile? **This grew; I gave**
commands;

Then all smiles stopped together. There she
stands

As if alive. Will't please you rise? We'll meet

The company below, then. I repeat,
The Count your master's known munificence
Is ample warrant that **no just pretence**
Of mine for dowry will be disallowed;
Though his fair daughter's self, as I avowed
At starting, **is my object.** Nay, we'll go

Together down, sir. **Notice Neptune, though,**
Taming a sea-horse, thought a rarity,
Which Claus of Innsbruck cast in bronze **for**
me!

The key moment. She smiled at everyone;
"This grew"; he **"gave commands"** and her
smiles stopped. He means he had her killed
(Browning himself said so, then added that
she might have been shut in a convent).
Then, coolly, he asks the visitor to stand.

Back to business. The visitor works for a
Count whose daughter the Duke plans to
marry. He expects a big dowry (money paid
by the bride's family), though he says the
daughter herself is his **"object"**. She will be
his next Duchess.

On the way out, he points to another
treasure: a bronze statue of the sea-god
Neptune **"Taming"** a sea-horse, made **"for**
me!" The last word is about himself.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"That's my last Duchess painted on the wall,"

Means: my (latest) wife, now just a painting.

Technique: possessive "my": she is something he owns.

LINES 9–10

*"since none puts by / The curtain I have drawn
for you, but I"*

Means: only I decide who sees her. **Why it**

matters: he controls her even after her death.

LINES 23–24

*"she liked whate'er / She looked on, and her
looks went everywhere."*

Means: she enjoyed everything and smiled at everyone. **Why it matters:** what he calls a fault is really kindness; his jealousy is the problem.

LINE 33

"My gift of a nine-hundred-years-old name"

Means: my ancient family name was my gift to her.

Technique: a long hyphenated adjective that puffs up his pride.

LINES 42-43

“and I choose / Never to stoop.”

Means: I refuse to lower myself by talking to her.

Why it matters: pride matters more to him than his marriage.

LINES 45-46

“I gave commands; / Then all smiles stopped together.”

Means: I had her killed (or shut away).

Technique: understatement and a heavy pause (caesura).

LINES 54-55

“Notice Neptune, though, / Taming a sea-horse,”

Means: look at my statue of a god taming a sea-horse. **Why it matters:** a symbol of the Duke taming his wife, and a warning to the next one.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: what a dramatic monologue is, and what Browning does with it

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **dramatic monologue** is a poem spoken by one character who is **not the poet**, “in a specific situation at a critical moment.” Baylor University (M. H. Abrams)
- Someone is listening, but “we know of the auditors’ presence, and what they say or do, only from clues in the discourse of the single speaker.” (Auditors = listeners; discourse = speech.) Baylor University (M. H. Abrams)
- **Why poets use it:** to reveal the speaker’s character, often more than the speaker means to. So we have to read between the lines. Baylor University (M. H. Abrams)
- The form had its “heyday in the Victorian Period”, and Browning is “considered to be the perfecter” of it. Baylor University; Britannica
- A **heroic couplet** is a pair of rhyming lines in **iambic pentameter** (about ten syllables, da-DUM da-DUM). Britannica

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **One voice only:** the Duke talks for all 56 lines. The Duchess is dead and the envoy never speaks. We hear only his side.
our reading
- We learn the listener is there only through the Duke’s words: “*Will’t please you sit and look at her?*” and “*Will’t please you rise?*” He decides when the visitor sits and stands, just as he controlled his wife. **our reading**
- **Rhyming couplets**, 56 lines in one unbroken block. Britannica; our count The lines are **iambic pentameter**, so these are heroic couplets. EBSCO; Britannica
pentameter: one source + our count
- But **enjambment** (a sentence running on past the end of a line) hides the rhymes, so it sounds like casual chat. EBSCO Example: “*I call / That piece a wonder*”.
- **Why it matters:** under the relaxed, chatty surface is a tight, controlled rhyme pattern, like the Duke: charming on top, controlling underneath. **our reading**
- **Openings and endings** (AQA’s 2023 report suggests writing about these rather than rhyme labels): it opens on a dead wife turned into a painting and ends on a statue of “Taming”, made “*for me!*” Both are possessions. AQA praised essays on “the curtain”, Neptune and the dramatic monologue “to depict megalomania” (a hunger for power).

AQA 2023 examiners’ report

A sentence you could use: Browning uses a dramatic monologue so that the Duke condemns himself in his own words; the silent envoy, like the dead Duchess, is never allowed to speak, so the form itself shows how completely the Duke controls everyone around him.

Letting him give himself away

The Duke thinks he is showing off his art and his family name. Instead he reveals his jealousy and cruelty. We judge him by what he lets slip.

Dramatic irony: when the audience understands more than the speaker does.

Murder in polite words

He never says he killed her. *"I gave commands; / Then all smiles stopped together."* The calm, short phrasing is more frightening than a confession.

Euphemism: a mild phrase used instead of a harsh or shocking one.

The curtain and the painting

Alive, she smiled at everyone. As a painting behind *"The curtain I have drawn"*, she smiles only when he allows it. Death has finally given him total control.

Symbol: an object that stands for a bigger idea.

Cracks in the polish

Dashes and asides like *"how shall I say?"* and *"I know not how"* break his smooth speech when he talks about her. His anger and jealousy leak through.

Caesura: a pause in the middle of a line, often marked by punctuation.

Examiners warn: in 2023 "a significant minority of students" thought the Duke "is grieving the loss of his first wife, which means they missed the point of the poem entirely." He is not sad. He is proud, jealous and controlling, and he is already arranging his next marriage. *AQA 2023 examiners' report*

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO BROWNING WAS

A “Major English poet of the Victorian age, noted for his mastery of dramatic monologue and psychological portraiture.” Born in London in 1812. [Britannica](#); [poets.org](#) **power · form**

He had little formal schooling. He learned from his father, whose library held over 6,000 books in six languages, including Italian. [Britannica](#); [poets.org](#)

Before this poem he wrote verse plays. Dramatic Lyrics (1842) appeared in his pamphlet series *Bells and Pomegranates*.

[Britannica](#) **form** **one source**

He made short visits to Italy in 1838 and 1844, and lived there from 1846 to 1861. [Britannica](#)

setting **1838 visit: one source**

In 1846 he secretly married the poet Elizabeth Barrett, whose father [Britannica](#) calls “despotic”; he never forgave her. This was after the poem was written. [Britannica](#); [poets.org](#) **control**

any link to the Duke is our reading

THE REAL DUKE AND DUCHESS

The Duke is most likely Alfonso II, fifth Duke of Ferrara (ruled 1559–97). AQA's 2023 report also refers to “the Duke of Ferrara and Lucrezia”. [RPO](#); [Victorian Web](#); [EBSCO](#); [AQA](#) **power**

In 1558 Lucrezia de' Medici's family arranged for her to marry him. She was 14. [RPO](#); [North Carolina Museum of Art](#) **women as possessions**

She died in 1561, aged 16 or 17. Probably of tuberculosis, says one museum; one editor says she died “in what some thought suspicious circumstances”. [North Carolina Museum of Art](#); [RPO](#)

power **sources differ on age and cause**

The Duke's family (the Este) was ancient; Lucrezia's family, the Medici, came from merchants. This may explain his sneer at her treating his name like “anybody's gift”. [RPO](#)

pride **one source**

Alfonso married three times but had no children. In 1598 Ferrara was taken over by the Pope. His proud “name” ended with him. [Britannica](#)

pride · power doesn't last **link is our reading**

RENAISSANCE ITALY

The poem is set in the ducal palace of Ferrara, in the Renaissance (the 1500s). [Victorian Web](#); EBSCO

The Renaissance began in Italy in the 14th century. Rich families, “chief among whom were the Medici”, paid for palaces and art. [Britannica](#)

power · status

Ferrara was “a powerful principality and cultural centre” (a principality is a state ruled by a prince or duke); its dukes supported famous poets and artists. [Britannica](#)

power · status

The painter “Frà Pandolf” and the sculptor “Claus of Innsbruck” are invented. “Frà” means a member of a religious order, so the Duke is jealous even of a friar. [RPO](#)

jealousy · control

one source

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT, AND VICTORIAN READERS

First published in *Dramatic Lyrics* (1842) under the title “Italy and France. I. -- Italy”; renamed *My Last Duchess* in 1849. [Britannica](#); [RPO](#)

Asked what “I gave commands” meant, Browning said: “I meant that the commands were that she should be put to death”, then added: “Or he might have had her shut up in a convent.” [RPO](#); [PMLA](#) (both quoting Hiram Corson)

power · tyranny

Under “coverture”, an old idea in English and American common law, a married woman's legal identity was merged with her husband's: husband and wife were treated as “a single entity: the husband.” [Britannica](#)

women as possessions

[link to the poem is our reading](#)

Before 1858, a full divorce needed an Act of Parliament: of about 320 granted between 1700 and 1857, “only four were granted to women”.

[National Archives](#)

power · control

[link to the poem is our reading](#)

AQA's 2023 report praised reading the poem as “a critique of those who wield their power in an immoral manner and/or for personal gain”. [AQA 2023 examiners' report](#)

power

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Browning, a Victorian, sets his poem in Renaissance Italy, where a duke could have a wife silenced with a word. When the law still treated husband and wife as “a single entity: the husband”, the Duke's treatment of his wife as a possession can be read as a warning to Victorian readers about what happens when power has no limits. [our reading](#) Keep the history short: AQA rewards ideas about the abuse of power, not the story of the real Duke.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

A My Last Duchess + Ozymandias

A

Use for: **Power** **Tyranny** · AQA: specimen and 2023 mark schemes; one of the two most popular choices in 2023

SIMILAR

- Both show proud, cruel rulers: the Duke's *"nine-hundred-years-old name"* and the king's *"sneer of cold command"*.
- Both poems centre on a work of art: a statue and a painting. Shelley's sculptor captures the king's cruelty; Browning's painter captures the Duchess's joy, which the Duke could not control while she lived.
- Both rulers give themselves away in their own words: *"I choose / Never to stoop"* and *"Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!"*

DIFFERENT

- **Does the power last?** Ozymandias's empire is now *"lone and level sands"*. The Duke's power is alive: he is arranging his next marriage.
- **Whose power:** Ozymandias ruled a kingdom; the Duke uses his power on one woman: *"I gave commands; / Then all smiles stopped together."*
- **Voice:** Ozymandias is told second-hand, so the king feels distant. The Duke speaks directly to us, which feels closer and more chilling.

B My Last Duchess + London

B

Use for: **Power** · AQA: 2018, 2021 and 2023 mark schemes; a top choice in 2023

SIMILAR

- Both show people crushed by those with power: the silenced Duchess, and Londoners with *"Marks of weakness, marks of woe"*.
- Both show power controlling people's lives completely, even their feelings: the Duke stops her smiles; Blake hears *"mind-forged manacles"*.

DIFFERENT

- **Whose voice:** the Duke is the powerful one speaking; Blake's speaker is an ordinary man walking the streets, on the side of the victims.
- **Scale:** the Duke's power is personal, over one wife; Blake attacks the whole system, Church and palace: *"Runs in blood down palace walls."*
- **Attitude:** Browning lets the Duke condemn himself without comment; Blake's anger is open.

My Last Duchess + Checking Out Me History

C

Use for: **Power** · AQA: 2023 mark scheme ("effects of power to control and repress"); named as one of the "really interesting other selections" in the 2023 report

SIMILAR

- Both show power silencing people: the Duchess cannot speak at all, and Agard's speaker was told only "*wha dem want to tell me*".
- Both show the powerful controlling what others see: the Duke draws the curtain; the people in charge "*Bandage up me eye*".

DIFFERENT

- **Who speaks:** Browning gives the voice to the oppressor; Agard gives it to the person who was oppressed, and he fights back.
- **Ending:** the Duchess stays silenced and the Duke moves on. Agard's speaker breaks free: "*I carving out me identity*".
- **Form:** tight, polished couplets for a controlling aristocrat; dialect and free, broken lines for a voice rejecting control.

7 In the exam

Compare how poets present the effects of power in 'My Last Duchess' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (AQA, June 2023)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Browning and Shelley show that unchecked power makes rulers arrogant and cruel, but while Shelley shows that power crumbling to dust, Browning's Duke is still powerful and dangerous at the end.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present powerful men whose pride destroys others. Browning's Duke is proud of his "*nine-hundred-years-old name*" and refuses to "*stoop*" to speak to his wife. Instead, "*I gave commands; / Then all smiles stopped together.*" The calm euphemism shows how easily he ends a life, and the dramatic monologue lets him condemn himself without realising it. Shelley's king is similarly arrogant, with a "*sneer of cold command*". However, Shelley shows that such power cannot last: after the boast "*Look on my works*" comes the blunt "*Nothing beside remains.*" Where Ozymandias is mocked by time, the Duke ends the poem still in control, already bargaining for his next wife. Browning's warning is perhaps darker: tyranny does not always fall by itself.

Why it scores:

- Thesis answers the question about the effects of power in one sentence
- Short quotations from both poems, with methods named (euphemism, dramatic monologue)
- Compares throughout ("similarly", "However", "Where...") and ends with a thoughtful, tentative judgement ("perhaps")

Tissue

Imtiaz Dharker (born 1954) · published 2006

04

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Identity · AQA mark schemes June 2022 and June 2024

Effects of conflict · AQA mark schemes 2017, 2020 and 2024

Conflict · AQA mark scheme June 2022

Place and home · AQA mark scheme Nov 2021

Power · AQA specimen mark scheme (a method bullet under a power question: a weak link)

Pride · our reading

Memory · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Free verse: nine four-line stanzas + one final line (37 lines)

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet the printed poem; named in AQA mark schemes (2017, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2024)

BEST PARTNER

Ozymandias (your anchor); The Emigrée also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

The speaker looks at thin paper that light shines through: old family records, maps, shop receipts. She imagines building with paper instead of brick, and ends with human skin.

THE MESSAGE

The things people fight over, like borders, buildings and power, are less solid than they look. Human life is fragile but it is what really matters.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Dharker was born in Pakistan and grew up in Glasgow, and calls herself a “cultural mongrel”. The poem comes from a 2006 book that her publisher says shows “a world stricken by fundamentalism” (extreme, rigid religious belief). Poetry Archive; Big Issue North; Bloodaxe

THE TITLE

“Tissue” has two main meanings: very thin, soft paper, and the cells that make up a living body. The whole poem slides between the two, until the paper becomes “*your skin*”. A tissue can also mean a web or network, as in “a tissue of lies”, which fits a poem about how lives are woven together. (Merriam-Webster; our reading of the poem)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

There is no story and no named place. A first-person speaker (“I”) thinks aloud about thin paper, and lets one idea lead to the next. The poem never says who the speaker is; these notes say “she” for short.

Lines 1–4

The speaker starts with paper so thin that light shines through it, and claims this kind of paper *“could alter things”*. It has been worn thin by age and by people touching it.

Lines 5–12

Her example: the back pages of an old family Koran, where someone has handwritten the family's history. Births, heights, weights, deaths and dates are all recorded. The pages have been handled so lovingly that they have gone see-through.

Lines 13–16

She imagines buildings made of paper. Then she would feel them move, and see how easily they could fall, with just a sigh or a change in the wind.

Lines 17–20

Maps are like this too. Hold one up and the sun shines through its borders, and the lines of rivers, roads, railways and mountains.

Lines 21–24

Even little shop receipts, recording what we bought and paid by card, might lift our lives up like kites.

Lines 25–32

An architect could build with all this paper, layering writing, numbers and lines. They would give up brick and block, and let daylight break through capital cities, giant stones and *“the shapes that pride can make”*.

Lines 33–37

The new design would be made of living tissue: a structure never meant to last, paper smoothed and thinned until it is see-through. In the last line it becomes *“your skin”*.

The turning points: at line 25 (*“An architect could use all this,”*) she stops looking at paper and starts imagining a new way to build. Then the final line turns the paper into human skin.

How it ends: On one short line, set apart: *“turned into your skin.”* The poem speaks straight to the reader, so the fragile thing is now you. **The tone:** Thoughtful, gentle and hopeful. The speaker is exploring an idea, not lecturing. The words “If”, “might” and “could” keep it a daydream rather than an argument.

2 The poem, section by section

Tissue is still in copyright, so the full poem is not printed here. Read it in your anthology alongside these notes. Highlighted words are the short phrases worth learning for the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–4

Paper that lets the light ... is what could alter things.

LINES 5–12

the back of the Koran ... who was born to whom ... transparent with attention.

LINES 13–16

If buildings were paper ... they fall away on a sigh

LINES 17–20

Maps too. The sun shines through / their borderlines

LINES 21–24

might fly our lives like paper kites.

LINES 25–32

An architect could use all this ... let the daylight break ... the shapes that pride can make

LINES 33–37

living tissue ... never meant to last ... turned into your skin.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

Thin paper that light shines through. Oddly, the speaker says this weak-looking paper could change the world. Light becomes a sign of hope and truth all through the poem.

The family record written in the back of the holy book: names, births, heights, weights, deaths. Holding the pages so often has worn them see-through. What matters most is family life, kept on the thinnest paper.

"If" starts a daydream. Buildings feel permanent, but if they were paper she could see how easily they could fall. Buildings can stand for power and pride (our reading).

Hold a map to the light and the borders between countries look thin and see-through. One reading: lines that people fight over are just marks on paper. The natural features (rivers, mountains) are listed alongside the human ones (roads, railways).

Even shop receipts, the record of our everyday spending, could lift our lives up. A kite is light, free and playful, the opposite of heavy brick.

A new kind of builder would layer all this paper together and stop building with brick. Daylight would break through "capitals" (capital cities, perhaps money too) and "monoliths" (huge single stones). Proud, solid structures are opened up to light.

The plan is to build with living tissue, something deliberately fragile and not meant to last forever. The paper image finally becomes human skin, and the poem speaks straight to "you".

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINES 1–2

“Paper that lets the light / shine through”

Means: thin paper you can see light through. **Why it matters:** light is the poem's sign of hope and truth: it gets through barriers.

LINE 3

“is what could alter things.”

Means: fragile things, not strong ones, could change the world. **Technique:** a paradox: weakness is the real strength.

LINES 11–12

“pages smoothed and stroked and turned / transparent with attention”

Means: the family record has been read and touched so often it is see-through. **Technique:** alliteration and repeated “and”: gentle, loving handling.

LINES 17–18

“The sun shines through / their borderlines”

Means: borders on a map look flimsy when held to the light. **Why it matters:** one reading: borders that cause conflict are only man-made marks.

LINE 31

“through the shapes that pride can make”

Means: grand buildings and monuments are made by human pride. **Why it matters:** links power and pride to solid, grand structures.

LINES 33–34

“living tissue, raise a structure / never meant to last”

Means: build with something alive and fragile, on purpose. **Technique:** a pun on “tissue”: paper and the human body.

LINE 37

“turned into your skin.”

Means: the paper becomes human skin; the poem now means you. **Technique:** a one-line final stanza and direct address (“your”).

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: free verse, held in loose four-line stanzas

ABOUT THE FORM

- **Free verse** is “poetry organized to the cadences of speech and image patterns rather than according to a regular metrical scheme.” In plain English: no fixed rhythm and no rhyme pattern. *Britannica; poets.org*
- Poets use it to sound like natural speech or thought, and to follow ideas and images wherever they lead. *Britannica; poets.org*
- **Enjambment** is “the continuation of the sense of a phrase beyond the end of a line of verse.”
Britannica

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Shape:** nine four-line stanzas (quatrains), then one last line on its own: 37 lines. No regular metre and no rhyme scheme, though a few words chime (“break”, “make”). **our count**
- **Loose, not rigid:** the stanzas look neat, but sentences run on across lines and even across stanza gaps (lines 4–5, 8–9, 28–29, 32–33). The structure is there, but light gets through the gaps, like the paper she describes. **our reading**
- **One long sentence:** lines 25–37 are a single sentence that keeps building, layer over layer, like the architect’s paper. **our count**
- **The last line stands alone:** after all that building, “*turned into your skin.*” is set apart, so the reader stops and feels the point land on them.

A sentence you could use: Dharker writes in free verse, but keeps it in loose four-line stanzas that run into each other; the form is a structure with gaps in it, just like the paper “that lets the light / shine through”, so the shape of the poem matches its message that rigid structures should give way.

Paper as an extended metaphor

Paper stands for many things in turn: family records, buildings, maps, money, and finally skin. AQA's mark schemes name “use of metaphor to present effects of war in ‘Tissue’”.

Extended metaphor: one comparison kept going and developed through a whole poem.

Light breaking through

Light shines through paper (“*lets the light / shine through*”), through maps, and finally “*let the daylight break*” through great buildings. Light suggests truth, hope and openness winning over solid barriers.

Imagery: words that create a picture in the reader's mind.

Fragile against solid

Soft words (smoothed, stroked, thinned, sigh, kites) are set against hard ones (brick, block, monoliths). The poem seems to prefer the fragile side, which turns the usual idea of strength upside down.

Juxtaposition: placing two contrasting things side by side to show the difference.

A speaker who wonders, then turns to “you”

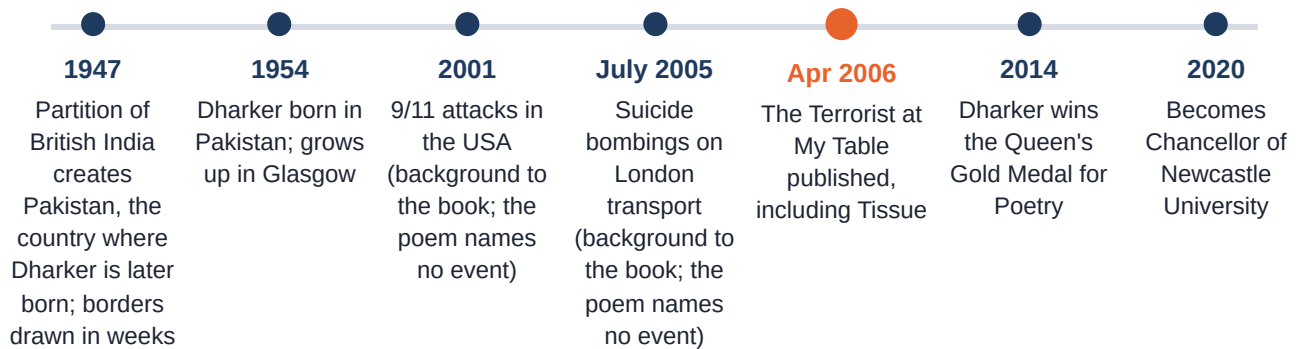
The “I” speaks in “If”, “might” and “could”, testing an idea rather than giving orders. The last word turns to “*your skin*”. AQA's specimen mark scheme names “Use of speaker to explore ideas in ... ‘Tissue’”.

Direct address: speaking straight to the reader as “you”.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO DHARKER IS

Born in Pakistan in 1954 and brought up in Glasgow. She later worked for many years in India, and has lived in Wales and London.

royal.uk; Poetry Archive; Scottish Poetry Library

identity · place and home

She calls herself a “Scottish Calvinist Muslim adopted by India and married into Wales”, and says: “don’t try to put easy labels on me or stick me in a box. I’m a cultural mongrel”. Big Issue

North interview (2017); Bloodaxe identity

“cultural mongrel”: one source

A poet, artist and documentary film-maker who illustrates all her own books with drawings.

Poetry Archive; royal.uk; Bloodaxe paper · line · maps

The Poetry Archive says her poems deal with “geographical and cultural displacement, conflict and gender politics”, questioning “received ideas about home, freedom and faith.” (Received ideas = ideas people accept without questioning.) Poetry Archive; Bloodaxe

identity · conflict · place

She won the Queen's Gold Medal for Poetry for 2014, a top national honour for poets. royal.uk;

Bloodaxe; Scottish Poetry Library

THE BOOK TISSUE COMES FROM

Tissue was published in *The Terrorist at My Table* (Bloodaxe, April 2006). Bloodaxe; Poetry Archive

Her publisher says the book shows “a world stricken by fundamentalism” and asks how we live now: “working, travelling, eating, listening to the news, preparing for attack.” Bloodaxe

effects of conflict · fear

one source

The Poetry Archive says the book “revels in blurring the public and personal.” Tissue does this: a private family record sits next to maps and national borders. Poetry Archive

identity · conflict

link to Tissue is our reading

The book came out after the 9/11 attacks (2001) and the London bombings of 7 July 2005, which killed 52 people. Tissue itself names no event, so linking it to these attacks is only our reading.

Britannica (dates and facts); the link to the poem is ours

effects of conflict

our reading: the poem names no event

BORDERS AND MAPS

Pakistan was created in 1947, when British India was split into India and Pakistan (Partition). Dharker was born there just seven years later. Britannica; National Archives

place · identity

dates are fact; any link to the poem is our reading

The border was drawn in a hurry: officials “were given just nine weeks”, and the line was announced two days after independence.

National Archives; Britannica

power · conflict

Over 15 million people are thought to have crossed the new borders. Britannica says as many as 2 million were killed, though estimates vary widely. National Archives; Britannica

effects of conflict

The poem names no country, border or war, so this is only our reading. A reader who knows about Partition might think of it when the sun “*shines through / their borderlines*”: lines on a map, which can cause great suffering, look like thin marks people made. our reading (not stated by Dharker)

conflict · power

our reading

FAITH, FAMILY AND PAPER

The Qur'an (Koran) is “the sacred scripture of Islam”, believed by Muslims to be the word of God. Britannica

identity · faith

In the poem, the most precious paper is not a law or a treaty but a family record in the back of a holy book: who was born, who died. the poem

identity · memory

Faith here is shown as something gentle and private, cared for over generations, not as a cause of fighting. our reading

conflict · identity

our reading

Carol Ann Duffy, then Poet Laureate, said that whatever Dharker writes about, “exile, childhood, politics or grief”, her attention brings it “dazzlingly into focus”. royal.uk

one source

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Dharker was born in Pakistan, a country created in 1947 by a hastily drawn border, and grew up in Glasgow. Tissue came out in 2006, and her publisher describes the book as showing “a world stricken by fundamentalism”. The poem names no place or event, so present any link to Partition or to terror attacks as a reading (“perhaps”, “could suggest”), not as Dharker’s stated aim. Safely: the poem suggests that the solid things people fight over, like borders, monuments and power, are as thin as paper, and that fragile human life matters more.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Tissue + The Emigrée

A

Use for: **Identity** **Place and home** **Effects of conflict** · AQA: Nov 2021 mark scheme ("use of places as representation of people") and June 2024 ("sense of identity")

SIMILAR

- Both use paper and light for a place or a life: Rumens's city is "docile as paper" and her memory is "sunlight-clear"; Dharker's paper "lets the light / shine through".
- Both show borders shaping who people are: "the frontiers rise between us" and "their borderlines".

DIFFERENT

- **Borders:** Rumens's speaker is trapped by them ("I have no passport"); Dharker imagines light shining straight through them.
- **Ending:** The Emigrée ends with hostility around her ("They mutter death"), though her "sunlight" survives; Tissue ends gently and hopefully with "your skin."
- **Voice:** both use "I", but Rumens's speaker tells her own painful story; Dharker's speaker thinks about everyone, then turns to "you".

Tissue + Ozymandias

B

Use for: **Power** **Pride** · AQA: specimen mark scheme lists Tissue for the Ozymandias power question ("Use of speaker")

SIMILAR

- Both show proud, solid structures as less permanent than they look: a "colossal wreck" and buildings that "fall away on a sigh".
- Both link power to pride in building: "Look on my works, ye Mighty" and "the shapes that pride can make".

DIFFERENT

- **Attitude:** Shelley mocks a king whose works crumbled against his will. Dharker wants to build "a structure / never meant to last" on purpose.
- **Materials:** the sculptor's stone survives ("stamp'd on these lifeless things"); Dharker chooses "living tissue" over brick.
- **Voice:** Ozymandias is told second-hand and feels distant; Tissue is a thinking "I" who speaks straight to "you".

Tissue + Checking Out Me History

C

Use for: **Identity** **Power** · AQA: specimen mark scheme ("Use of speaker ... 'Checking Out Me History' or 'Tissue'") and June 2022 ("ideology/identity")

SIMILAR

- Both are about who writes the record of people's lives. Agard's official history was chosen by others: *"Wha dem want to tell me"*. Dharker's family Koran records *"who was born to whom"*.
- Both find identity in records: *"the names and histories"* and *"me own history"*.

DIFFERENT

- Tone:** Agard is angry and defiant, with the chant-like repetition of *"Dem tell me"*. Dharker is calm and reflective.
- Ending:** Agard ends strong and hard: *"I carving out me identity"*, like carving stone. Dharker ends soft: *"turned into your skin."*
- Language and form:** Agard uses Caribbean dialect, rhyme and refrains; Dharker uses standard English free verse in loose quatrains.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present the ways people are affected by conflict in 'Tissue' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (AQA's June 2024 wording, with 'Tissue' in place of the printed poem, 'Kamikaze')

A strong opening (thesis): Both Dharker and Rumens show that conflict shapes people's identity through borders, but Rumens's speaker is trapped by them while Dharker imagines them dissolving in the light.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present borders as a force that shapes people's lives, but they react to them very differently. Dharker imagines maps held up to the light, so that *"The sun shines through / their borderlines"*. The lines that divide nations look thin and see-through, as if they could be undone, and her conditional "If" and "could" make this a hopeful thought experiment. Rumens's speaker cannot see through borders; she is shut out by them, as *"the frontiers rise between us, close like waves."* The simile makes borders a force she cannot stop, and *"I have no passport"* shows the state controlling who she can be. Both poets use paper to show fragile identity: Rumens's city is *"docile as paper"*, while Dharker's paper becomes *"your skin"*. Where Rumens shows identity threatened, Dharker hopes fragility can unite people.

Why it scores:

- Opens with a clear comparative point that answers the question about conflict
- Short, exact quotations from both poems, each explained, with methods named (conditional, simile)
- Keeps comparing all the way through ("Both", "Where...") and ends on a judgement

Checking Out Me History

John Agard (born 1949) · collected 2004 (in print by 1993)

05

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Power · AQA mark schemes Nov 2021, 2023, 2025; Nov 2021 report

Identity · AQA mark scheme June 2022

Conflict · AQA mark schemes June 2022, 2025

Difficult experiences · AQA mark scheme Nov 2020 ("the experience of education")

Pride · our reading

Childhood · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Free-form poem in Caribbean dialect (53 lines)

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet the printed poem; named in AQA mark schemes 2020–2025

BEST PARTNER

Ozymandias (your anchor); London also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A Caribbean speaker remembers the British history he was taught at school, then tells us the Black heroes he was never taught about.

THE MESSAGE

Whoever controls what you learn controls who you think you are. The speaker takes that power back and finds his own history.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Agard grew up in British Guiana, a British colony until 1966. He remembers that his school history book began West Indian history with the arrival of Columbus. [Encyclopedia.com](#); [Britannica](#); Prospect interview, 2016

THE TITLE

"Checking out" is casual, modern slang for looking into something. "Me" instead of "my" is Caribbean dialect. So the title itself shows the speaker exploring history in his own voice, not the official one. The same words come back in the last lines, where he finally does it. (our reading; words checked against the AQA anthology)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The speaker talks straight to us, in the Creole of the Caribbean. He is angry about his education. A mysterious “dem” (them) decided what he was allowed to learn.

Lines 1–5

He repeats that “dem” told him only what they wanted to tell him. He says they covered his eye with a bandage, blinding him to his own identity.

Lines 6–21

They taught him about 1066 and the story of Dick Whittington’s cat, but never about Toussaint L’Ouverture. An indented section tells us who Toussaint was: an enslaved man who beat Napoleon’s soldiers and led the Haitian Revolution.

Lines 22–31

They taught him nursery rhymes, like the cow jumping over the moon, but never about Nanny of the Maroons. A short section praises her as a fighter who led her people towards freedom.

Lines 32–35

They taught him about Lord Nelson, Waterloo and Columbus. But never about Shaka, the great Zulu leader, or what happened to the Caribs and Arawaks, the Caribbean’s first peoples.

Lines 36–49

They taught him about Florence Nightingale, Robin Hood and Old King Cole, but never about Mary Seacole. Her section tells how she travelled from Jamaica to the Crimean War, even when the British said no, to care for the wounded.

Lines 50–53

The refrain “Dem tell me” returns. But now he is checking out his own history and carving out his own identity.

The turning point (line 52): “But now”. After fifty-one lines of being told, the speaker becomes the one who acts. “Dem tell me” becomes “I checking out me own history”. **How it ends:** On the word “identity”, the same word as line 5. At the start it was blinded; at the end he is carving it out for himself. **The tone:** Angry and mocking in the “Dem tell me” stanzas; proud and admiring in the hero sections; defiant and confident at the end.

2 The poem, section by section

This poem is still in copyright, so only short key phrases are shown here. Read the full poem in your anthology. Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the full text in

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–5

Bandage up me eye with me own history

LINES 6–9

*Dem tell me bout 1066 and all dat ... no dem
never tell me bout dat*

LINES 10–21

a slave ... lick back ... Toussaint de beacon

LINES 22–25

*de cow who jump over de moon ... Nanny de
maroon*

LINES 26–31

see-far woman ... fire-woman struggle

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The speaker says “Dem tell me” twice, then “Wha dem want to tell me”, like a chant. “Dem” (them) is never named: it means the people in charge of his education. They covered his eye with his own history, so he couldn’t see who he really was. “**Blind me to me own identity**” finishes the idea.

He was taught the Battle of Hastings (1066) and the folk tale of Dick Whittington and his cat. “And all dat” sounds bored and dismissive. But they never told him about Toussaint L’Ouverture, a hero of Black history.

The first indented hero section, in short lines. Toussaint was enslaved but had “vision”. He beat back (“lick back”) Napoleon’s army, and helped the first Black republic to be born. He was a “thorn” to the French and a “beacon” (a guiding light) of the Haitian Revolution.

Now the things he was taught are nursery rhymes and nonsense: a balloon, a cow jumping over the moon, a dish running away with a spoon. By putting real history next to nursery rhymes, Agard mocks what he was taught. Again: no one told him about Nanny of the Maroons.

Nanny’s section is a chain of images. She could see far ahead, she had a “mountain dream”, she fought with fire, and her hope flowed like a stream “to freedom river”. Nature imagery makes her almost a force of nature.

LINES 32–35

*Shaka de great Zulu ... what happen to de Caribs
and de Arawaks too*

British war heroes (Nelson, Waterloo) are set against Shaka, the Zulu leader. Then Columbus and 1492, set against the peoples who already lived in the Caribbean. The question “what happen to” hints at something terrible that was hidden.

LINES 36–39

*Florence Nightingale and she lamp ... Mary
Seacole*

Florence Nightingale, the famous British nurse, then Robin Hood and Old King Cole. The last name is Mary Seacole, the Jamaican nurse he was never taught about.

LINES 40–49

even when de British said no ... a yellow sunrise

The longest hero section. Seacole travelled from Jamaica to the Crimean War. The British said no, but she went anyway and faced the Russian snow. She was “a healing star” to the wounded and “a yellow sunrise” to the dying: images of light and hope.

LINES 50–53

*I checking out me own history ... I carving out
me identity*

The chant returns, then the change: “But now”. The speaker stops being told and starts finding out. “Carving” suggests hard work, making something lasting, like carving in stone or wood.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 4

“Bandage up me eye with me own history”

Means: his education stopped him seeing the truth about his own past. **Why it matters:** a bandage is for a wound: colonial schooling has injured him.

Technique: metaphor

LINE 5

“Blind me to me own identity”

Means: not knowing his history means not knowing who he is. **Why it matters:** history and identity are tied together; this is the poem’s big idea.

LINE 20

“Toussaint de beacon”

Means: Toussaint was a guiding light for the revolution. **Why it matters:** light imagery for the hidden heroes; the opposite of the blindness at the start. **Technique:** metaphor

LINE 23

“and de cow who jump over de moon”

Means: he was taught nursery rhymes as if they were history. **Why it matters:** mocks the curriculum: British nonsense was taught; Black heroes were not. **Technique:** juxtaposition (putting two things side by side to compare them)

LINE 35

“but what happen to de Caribs and de Arawaks too”

Means: what happened to the people who lived there before Columbus? **Why it matters:** a question that exposes a silence in the history books. **Technique:** rhetorical question

LINE 48

“a yellow sunrise”

Means: Seacole brought hope and comfort to dying soldiers. **Why it matters:** warm, glowing imagery gives her the praise history denied her. **Technique:** metaphor; colour imagery

LINE 53

“I carving out me identity”

Means: he is now building his own sense of who he is. **Why it matters:** the passive “Dem tell me” becomes the active “I”: he takes the power back. **Technique:** metaphor; first person

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: dialect, two voices and a refrain

ABOUT THE FORM

- **Dialect** is the way a language is spoken in one place or community, with its own words, spellings and grammar. Agard is known for using Caribbean dialect and Creole in his poems. Poetry Archive; Books for Keeps
- **Creole** here means the language of the Caribbean that mixes English with other influences. Agard said his love of “the language, Creole, and the rich culture of Guyana” grew after he moved away. Books for Keeps, 1993 [one source](#)
- A **refrain** is a line or phrase that keeps coming back, like the chorus of a song.
- The Children's Poetry Archive lists the poem's key devices as “Dialect, Half Rhyme, Pace”. Children's Poetry Archive [one source](#)

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Phonetic spelling:** words are spelled as they sound: “dem”, “dat”, “de”, “bout”. Verbs lose their endings (“she travel”, “I checking”). The poem is written in the speaker's own voice, not the standard English of the schoolbooks. [our reading](#)
- **No punctuation:** there are no full stops or commas in the whole poem. It reads like speech or performance, and it ignores the rules of standard written English, just as it ignores the official history. [our check and reading](#)
- **Two kinds of section:** the “Dem tell me” stanzas have long lines and rhyme like nursery rhymes (balloon / moon / spoon / maroon). The hero sections are indented, in very short lines, and in italics in the anthology. The layout separates the two histories. [our check](#)
- **The rhyme links the two histories:** in most “Dem tell me” stanzas a hero is rhymed with the British list: “Waterloo” with “Zulu”, “soul” with “Seacole”. The hero is placed where the rhyme lands, so we hear them clearly. [our reading](#)
- **The refrain:** “Dem tell me” opens the poem and returns at the end. It sounds like a chant or rote learning. At the end it is answered by “But now I”, showing that he has broken the pattern. [our reading](#)

A sentence you could use: Agard writes in Caribbean dialect with no punctuation at all, so the poem itself refuses the standard English of the colonial classroom; by setting the heroes apart in short, indented sections, he gives them the space that his history lessons never did.

Repetition: “Dem tell me”

The phrase comes back again and again, like rote learning in a classroom. “Dem” is never named, which makes the power faceless and everywhere.

Refrain: a line or phrase repeated through a poem, like a chorus.

Mockery by juxtaposition

Real British heroes sit next to nursery rhymes: “*Dem tell me bout 1066 and all dat*” then Dick Whittington’s cat. This suggests the history he was taught was as useless to him as a children’s rhyme.

Juxtaposition: placing two things side by side so we compare them.

Light and nature imagery for the heroes

Toussaint is a “*beacon*”, Seacole “*a healing star*” and “*a yellow sunrise*”, Nanny a “*hopeful stream*”. Light answers the blindness of line 5.

Imagery: descriptive language that creates a picture in the reader’s mind.

Passive to active

For most of the poem things are done to the speaker (“*Dem tell me*”). In the last two lines he does things himself: “*I checking out*”, “*I carving out*”. He takes back control.

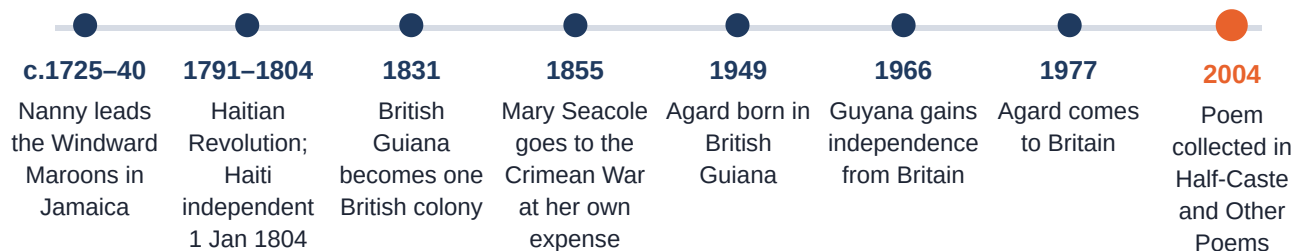
Volta: a turning point where a poem changes direction.

Examiners warn: “a mere observation of the techniques or even a vague comment about ‘flow’ and ‘pace’ will not achieve above Level 2 AO2 if it is not tied to meaning.” (AQA June 2022 report). So don’t just say “there’s no punctuation so it flows”; say what that choice shows about power and identity.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem’s ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO AGARD IS

Born in Guyana (then British Guiana) in 1949. He went to a Roman Catholic school there.

Poetry Archive; Encyclopedia.com; Prospect **identity**

He worked as a journalist in Guyana, then came to Britain in 1977. Children's Poetry Archive

(journalist); Bloodaxe Books; Encyclopedia.com (1977)

identity · place

In Britain he worked for the Commonwealth Institute, touring schools to promote understanding of Caribbean culture. Books for

Keeps; Encyclopedia.com **identity · education**

He is known for performing his poems and for humour. He has said: "Humour breaks down boundaries, it topples our self-importance".

Poetry Archive (humour); Children's Poetry Archive (quote)

tone · power **quote: one source**

He won the Queen's Gold Medal for Poetry in 2012. Poetry Archive; Bloodaxe Books

GROWING UP IN A BRITISH COLONY

British Guiana became one British colony in 1831. Enslaved West Africans had been brought there to grow sugar cane; full emancipation (freedom from slavery) came in 1838. Britannica **power · identity** **one source**

Guyana gained its independence from Britain in 1966, when Agard was about 17. So he went to school under British rule. Britannica

power · control **one source**

Agard said the first line of his history book was "something like 'West Indian history begins in 1492 with the arrival of Columbus'". Prospect

interview, 2016 **power · identity**

one source (Agard's own words)

Looking back, he called it "a very arrogant sentence, as if history only begins with the arrival of a European." Prospect interview, 2016

power · conflict **one source**

His aim: "those who weren't given a voice, their story can be told". Prospect interview, 2016

identity · voices **one source**

THE HIDDEN HEROES

Toussaint Louverture was born into slavery in Saint-Domingue (now Haiti) and led its independence movement. Napoleon sent an army in 1802; Toussaint died in a French prison in 1803. Haiti became independent in 1804, “the first country to be founded by former slaves.”

Britannica (two articles)

power · conflict

Nanny, born in present-day Ghana, led the Windward Maroons of Jamaica (people who had escaped slavery) from about 1725 to 1740. She organised guerrilla warfare (surprise attacks by small, mobile groups) against British troops from the Blue Mountains. She is a National Hero of Jamaica. Britannica; Jamaica

Information Service

power · conflict

Mary Seacole, born in Jamaica in 1805, offered to nurse in the Crimean War and was refused; she believed this was racial prejudice. She went at her own expense in 1855 and set up the British Hotel. She was largely forgotten for a century after her death. Britannica; EBSCO; National

Army Museum

identity · power

Shaka ruled the Zulu empire in southern Africa from 1816 to 1828 and changed how its armies fought. Britannica

power

one source

The Arawaks (Taino) were the first people Columbus met. They were destroyed by disease and by Spanish “violence, brutality, and oppression (including enslavement)”. **The Caribs** lived in the islands and the Guianas; the Caribbean Sea is named after them. Britannica

(two articles)

power · conflict

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT

It was collected in *Half-Caste and Other Poems* (Hodder Children's Books, 2004), a book for young readers. Poetry Archive; Internet Archive

It is older than that: a 1993 magazine quotes lines from it “in *Life Doesn't Frighten Me At All*”, an anthology Agard edited (Heinemann, 1989).

Books for Keeps, Sept 1993; Encyclopedia.com (editor,

1989)

one source that the poem is in that anthology

The British heroes in the poem are the ones schoolchildren were taught: Nelson is a British “national hero”; Nightingale became famous as the “Lady with the Lamp”. Britannica

power · patriotism

one source

The 1066 link: Britannica says King Harold was “struck in the eye by an arrow” at Hastings. Line 4 also hurts the speaker's eye. Possibly a sly echo. Britannica

power

our reading

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Agard grew up in British Guiana, a British colony until 1966, and his history book said West Indian history began with Columbus. The poem shows that power is not just armies and kings: it is also control over what children are taught, and so over who they believe they are.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Checking Out Me History + London

A

Use for: **Power** **Conflict** · AQA: Nov 2021 report ("worked very well") and mark scheme; mark schemes 2023 and 2025

SIMILAR

- Both show power controlling people's minds, not just their bodies: Agard's speaker is "Blind" to his identity; Blake hears "The mind-forged manacles".
- Both attack institutions: the schools and history books of an empire, and the Church and palace ("Every black'ning church appalls").
- Both use repetition like a chant: "Dem tell me" and "In every cry of every man".

DIFFERENT

- **Hope:** Blake sees no way out; even the newborn is cursed. Agard's speaker breaks free: "But now I checking out me own history".
- **Voice:** Blake's "I" is a watcher who observes suffering. Agard's "I" is the victim who fights back, in his own dialect.
- **Form:** Blake uses strict quatrains with a regular rhyme scheme, like the controlled city. Agard has no punctuation and breaks into free, indented sections.

Checking Out Me History + Ozymandias

B

Use for: **Power** · AQA: specimen mark scheme for the Ozymandias power question ("Use of speaker to explore ideas in 'Checking Out Me History' or 'Tissue'")

SIMILAR

- Both show that the powerful try to control what is remembered. The king's words are carved for ever: "Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!" Agard's teachers choose the story: "Wha dem want to tell me".
- Both show an artist mocking the powerful. Shelley's sculptor is "The hand that mock'd them"; Agard mocks the history he was taught by mixing it with nursery rhymes: "de cow who jump over de moon".
- Both use carving. The king's pride is "stamp'd on these lifeless things" in stone; Agard's speaker ends "I carving out me identity".

DIFFERENT

- **Who speaks:** in Ozymandias the powerful man's voice survives only on a broken statue, reported second-hand. Agard gives the voice to the person without power, speaking for himself.
- **Ending:** Shelley's ending shows power vanishing: "Nothing beside remains." Agard's ending shows a new identity being built: "But now I checking out me own history".
- **Form:** Shelley uses a tight sonnet in standard English. Agard uses Caribbean dialect, no punctuation and a chant-like refrain: "Dem tell me".

Checking Out Me History + The Emigrée

C

Use for: **Identity** **Place and home** · AQA: Nov 2020 mark scheme (pairs “the experience of education in ‘Checking Out Me History’” with “a change in circumstances in ‘The Emigrée’”)

SIMILAR

- Both speakers hold on to an identity that those in power try to take away: Agard’s heroes were left out; Rumens’ city is “*banned by the state*”.
- Both link identity to language: Agard writes in dialect; Rumens’ speaker says of her childhood language, “*I can’t get it off my tongue.*”
- Both use light imagery for what they love: “*a yellow sunrise*” and “*an impression of sunlight*”.

DIFFERENT

- **Ending:** Agard ends in triumph and control; Rumens’s speaker is still under threat at the end, “*They accuse me of being dark in their free city.*”, though she holds on to her “*sunlight*”
- **Specific vs vague:** Agard names real people and dates; Rumens never names her country, so it could be anywhere.
- **Tone:** Agard is angry and mocking; Rumens is tender and nostalgic.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present ideas about power and control in ‘Checking Out Me History’ and in one other poem from ‘Power and conflict’. (Focus wording from AQA, Nov 2021)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Agard and Blake show that the most dangerous power controls people’s minds, but while Blake’s Londoners stay trapped, Agard’s speaker breaks free by finding his own history.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present power as something that controls the mind. Agard’s speaker says his education “*Blind me to me own identity*”, as if the schoolbooks were a “*Bandage*” over a wound. Blake’s Londoners are also trapped mentally by “*The mind-forged manacles*”, chains made by thinking. In both poems, repetition shows how complete this control is: “*Dem tell me*” beats like a classroom chant, while “*every*” is repeated through Blake’s second stanza. However, the poems end very differently. Blake offers no escape, even for the newborn infant. Agard’s speaker turns from passive to active: “*I carving out me identity*”. Writing in his own dialect, he takes back the power that colonial schooling took from him.

Why it scores:

- The opening sentence answers the question about power and control straight away
- Short quotations from both poems, each one explained, plus methods named (metaphor, repetition)
- Compares all the way through (“also”, “In both”, “However”) and ends with a clear difference

Storm on the Island

Seamus Heaney (1939–2013) · first published December 1964

06

★ ANCHOR POEM: learn this one first

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Nature · AQA mark schemes: specimen, 2017, 2018, 2021, 2023, 2024, 2025

Power · AQA specimen and 2018 mark schemes

Conflict · AQA mark schemes 2019, 2022, 2025

War · AQA mark schemes 2021, 2023 (“imagery of war”)

Time · AQA specimen mark scheme

Fear · our reading

Isolation · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Blank verse (one 19-line stanza)

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet the printed poem, but named in many AQA mark schemes

BEST PARTNER

Ozymandias

THE STORY IN SHORT

An islander, speaking for the whole community (“we”), explains how they prepare for storms. Then a storm hits, and they can only sit and wait.

THE MESSAGE

However well people prepare, nature is stronger. The most frightening enemy is one you cannot see or fight.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Heaney grew up on a farm in Northern Ireland. In his early poems, nature is “violent as well as bounteous” (generous).

Heaney estate; The Conversation (Oxford Brookes University)

THE TITLE

The title is plain: a storm, and an island. But it says “**the Island**”, not a real place name. The poem never tells us which island, so it could be any exposed place, cut off from help. Some readers link it to the Aran Islands off the west of Ireland, but only a revision guide says so, and we could not confirm it. **Aran link: unconfirmed** (AQA anthology (our check of the text))

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

One islander speaks for everyone ("we"). The speaker talks to a listener ("you") in a calm, chatty way, explaining how island life works.

Lines 1–2

They are ready. They build low, solid ("squat") houses, sink the walls into rock and use strong slate roofs.

Lines 3–5

The land is poor and dried up ("wizened"). It grows no hay, so there are no haystacks or bundles of crops to lose.

Lines 5–11

There are no trees either. Trees might seem like company in a gale, because their noise lets you hear what you fear. But that noise would distract you while the storm "pummels" your house. In any case, there is "no natural shelter".

Lines 12–16

You might think the sea is friendly, crashing "comfortably" on the cliffs. "But no": in a storm the spray hits the windows and "spits" like a pet cat that has suddenly turned wild.

Lines 16–18

The people just "sit tight". The wind dives and attacks like a fighter plane. The empty air itself feels like gunfire, and they are "bombarded".

Line 19

The speaker finds it strange: what they fear is "a huge nothing", the invisible air.

The turning point (line 14): "*But no:*" The calm explaining stops. The sea, which seemed friendly, attacks, and the language becomes violent and military. **How it ends:** on a paradox. A "*huge nothing*" sounds impossible, but it is exactly right: wind is invisible, yet it can wreck a house. **The tone:** starts confident and practical, like someone giving a tour. By the end it is uneasy and afraid. The certainty of line 1 has gone.

2 The poem, section by section

This poem is still in copyright, so only short key phrases are shown here. Read the full poem in your anthology alongside this guide. Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so

read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key words to quote.

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–2

We are prepared: ... we build our houses squat,

LINES 3–5

This wizened earth ... there are no stacks

LINES 5–11

Can raise a tragic chorus in a gale ... no natural shelter.

LINES 12–16

Exploding comfortably down on the cliffs ... spits like a tame cat / Turned savage.

LINES 16–18

wind dives / And strafes invisibly. ... Space is a salvo,

LINES 19

Strange, it is a huge nothing that we fear.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

A confident start. The islanders build low, heavy houses with walls sunk into rock and good slate roofs. They sound ready for anything, as if preparing for an attack.

The word “wizened” means shrivelled and old, like an old face. The soil is too poor for hay, so there are no haystacks or “stooks” (bundles of crops) for the wind to blow away. Having nothing is a strange kind of safety.

No trees either. Trees would make a loud, sad noise in a storm, like a “chorus” in a tragic play. That might feel like company, but it would distract you while the storm “pummels” (punches) your house. There is nowhere to hide.

You might think the sea is friendly. “But no”: in a storm the spray hits the windows. The simile of a pet cat turning wild shows something familiar suddenly becoming dangerous.

The people can only “sit tight”. The wind is described like a fighter plane: to “strafe” is to attack with gunfire from a low-flying aircraft, and a “salvo” is a burst of gunfire. They are “bombarded by the empty air”.

The last line admits the truth: they are afraid of something they cannot see. The confident “We are prepared” has turned into “we fear”.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"We are prepared: we build our houses squat,"

Means: the islanders are confident and ready; their houses are low and solid. **Why it matters:** can sound like people getting ready for an attack, hinting at conflict from the very first line.

Technique: declarative sentence (a statement of fact)

LINE 3

"This wizened earth"

Means: the land is old, dried up and poor. **Why it matters:** a harsh place: nature here is not pretty or generous. **Technique:** personification (the earth is like a shrivelled old face)

LINE 8

"Can raise a tragic chorus in a gale"

Means: trees would make a loud, sad noise in a storm. **Why it matters:** the trees' noise would be like the chorus in a tragic play, giving the fear a voice. Here there are no trees, so there is not even that company. **Technique:** metaphor from drama

LINE 13

"Exploding comfortably down on the cliffs"

Means: the sea seems safe and familiar, even when it crashes. **Why it matters:** "Exploding" is a war word, hidden next to the cosy "comfortably": a warning of what is coming. **Technique:** oxymoron (two words that contradict each other)

LINES 15–16

"spits like a tame cat / Turned savage."

Means: the friendly sea suddenly turns wild and attacks. **Why it matters:** something people thought they had tamed turns on them: nature was never under control. **Technique:** simile and enjambment (the line break makes the "turn" sudden)

LINES 16–17

"wind dives / And strafes invisibly."

Means: the wind attacks like a fighter plane they cannot see. **Why it matters:** AQA mark schemes point to the "imagery of war" in this poem; nature becomes an army. **Technique:** military verb; semantic field of war

LINES 17–18

"Space is a salvo, / We are bombarded by the empty air."

Means: the empty air itself feels like gunfire hitting them. **Why it matters:** the islanders are helpless and passive: they are "bombarded", they do nothing. **Technique:** metaphor; sibilance (repeated "s" sounds, like hissing wind)

LINE 19

"Strange, it is a huge nothing that we fear."

Means: they are terrified of something invisible. **Why it matters:** the confident "We are prepared" has become "we fear". The poem ends on fear, not safety. **Technique:** paradox (a statement that seems impossible but is true)

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: blank verse, and a voice that sounds like talking

ABOUT THE FORM

- **Blank verse** is unrhymed iambic pentameter: lines of about ten syllables in a da-DUM, da-DUM rhythm, with no rhyme. Britannica calls it “the preeminent dramatic and narrative verse form in English”. Britannica; poets.org
- Because it does not rhyme, it can sound close to real speech. Britannica describes Shakespeare's blank verse as “approximating the rhythms of speech”, and notes its range reaches a “low-keyed, conversational tone”.
Britannica
- A **dramatic monologue** is “a poem written in the form of a speech of an individual character”. The reader works out the speaker's situation from what they say.
Britannica
- Wordsworth's *Prelude* is also in blank verse, which makes it a good partner for comparing form. Britannica

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Blank verse:** 19 unrhymed lines, most with ten syllables. Line 1 is a regular da-DUM line: “*We are prepared: we build our houses squat,*”. The steady rhythm sounds controlled, like the islanders' preparations. **our check**
- **One single stanza:** there are no breaks, no gaps, nowhere to pause. Like the island, the poem has “*no natural shelter.*” **our reading**
- **The control breaks down:** lines run on (enjambment) and are cut by sudden stops (caesura). “*Turned savage.*” starts a line and ends a sentence at once, so the shock lands hard. **our reading**
- **A talking voice:** the speaker chats to a listener: “*as you see*”, “*you know what I mean*”, “*You might think*”. It reads like a dramatic monologue, but the speaker is a whole community (“we”), not one named character. **our reading**
- **Why it matters:** the chatty, ordinary voice makes the storm feel like a normal part of life. That makes the fear at the end more unsettling: even people used to storms are afraid.

A sentence you could use: Heaney writes in blank verse, whose steady, controlled rhythm mirrors the islanders' confident preparations; but as the storm builds, enjambment and sudden mid-line stops (caesuras) break that control, so the form itself shows human order giving way to nature.

War imagery

The storm is described like a military attack: “Exploding”, “strafes”, “salvo”, “bombarded”. Nature becomes an enemy army, and the islanders are civilians under fire. AQA mark schemes name the “imagery of war in ‘Storm on the Island’”.

Semantic field: a group of words linked to the same topic (here, war) spread through a text.

Something tame turns savage

You “*might think that the sea is company*”, but in a storm it “*spits like a tame cat / Turned savage.*” The comparison to a pet shows that people only thought nature was under control.

Simile: comparing one thing to another using “like” or “as”.

Talking to the reader

Phrases like “*you know what I mean*” and “*You might think*” pull us into the conversation. The collective “*We*” shows a whole community facing the storm together.

Direct address: when a poem speaks straight to “you”, the listener or reader.

A paradox to finish

The poem ends on “*a huge nothing that we fear.*” Air is “nothing”, yet it is huge and terrifying. The enemy cannot be seen, fought or prepared for, which is why the confidence of line 1 collapses.

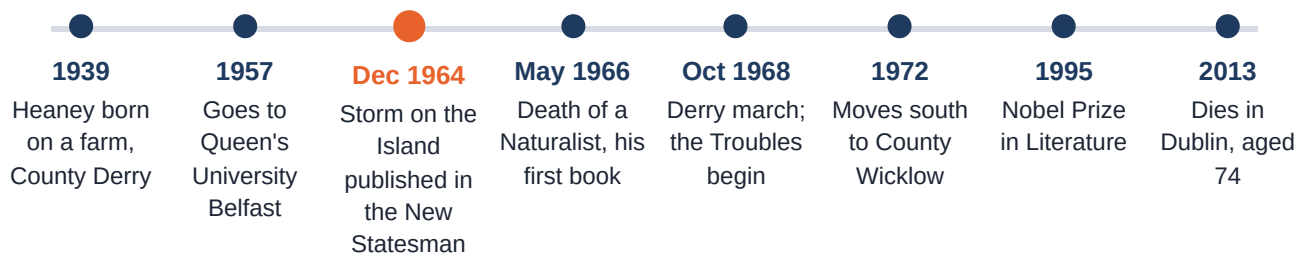
Paradox: a statement that seems to contradict itself but contains a truth.

Examiners warn: in 2021 (a question on power and control) AQA's report said “some students struggled with choices again, for example, Storm on the Island and Poppies”. In 2022 (conflict) it called Storm “arguably a little more challenging in terms of focus and comparison”. If you choose Storm, make the link to the question obvious: nature's power against human power, or conflict with nature.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO HEANEY WAS

Born on 13 April 1939 and brought up on the family farm, Mossbawn, in County Derry, Northern Ireland. He was the eldest of nine children; his father was a farmer and cattle dealer. Heaney estate; Irish Times; Britannica **nature**

Britannica: he was “Raised Roman Catholic in the predominantly Protestant North”. Britannica **conflict**

Studied English at Queen's University Belfast from 1957, then taught and lectured in Belfast and Dublin. Heaney estate; Britannica

Won the Nobel Prize in Literature in 1995, “for works of lyrical beauty and ethical depth”. He died in Dublin on 30 August 2013. Britannica; Irish Times; Heaney estate

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT

First published in the *New Statesman* magazine in December 1964, alongside “Digging” and “Scaffolding”. Irish Times (2016); National Library of Ireland

Because of those three poems, the publisher Faber wrote inviting Heaney to send a book. He later said it was “like getting a letter from God the Father”. The book became *Death of a Naturalist* (May 1966), his first. Irish Times (2016); National Library of Ireland; Heaney estate

Is the poem in that first book, *Death of a Naturalist*? Very probably, but we could not confirm it. The Irish Times says the 1964 poems led to the manuscript that “became” the book, but it does not list the book’s poems. Only a revision guide says outright that Storm is in it. AQA’s anthology credits its text “from Opened Ground”, a different Heaney book. Safest in the exam: call it an early poem, first published in 1964. Irish Times (2016); AQA anthology

likely, not confirmed

In Heaney’s early poems “the natural world was violent as well as bounteous”. The 1966 book compares frogs to “mud grenades”, so war words for nature are typical of early Heaney. The Conversation (Oxford Brookes); New York Review of Books **nature · conflict**

A critic called him “a demolisher of the Golden Treasury treatment of nature”: he refused the pretty, poetic view of nature. Blake Morrison, quoted by the English Association **nature · power**

one source

THE ISLAND

The poem never names its island. That makes it any exposed, cut-off place, which helps it speak about people in general. AQA anthology (our check)

nature · isolation

our reading

A revision guide links it to the Aran Islands, off the west coast of Ireland; we could not confirm this. Heaney did write other early island poems, such as "Lovers on Aran" and "Synge on Aran".

Shima journal (Newcastle University)

place

Aran link: unconfirmed

Britannica says the Aran Islands "do not have naturally occurring topsoil", and people "farm and fish under very difficult conditions". That fits the poem's "wizened earth" with no hay.

Britannica

nature

our reading

An academic study says the islands off the west of Ireland "have always been regarded as a sanctuary of Irish identity". Shima journal (Newcastle University)

identity

one source

NORTHERN IRELAND: GET THE DATES RIGHT

The Troubles were a "violent sectarian conflict from about 1968 to 1998 in Northern Ireland" (sectarian = between religious communities). Some 3,600 people were killed. Britannica

conflict

The poem came out in 1964 and the book in 1966, **before** the Troubles. Heaney's estate describes him "growing up Catholic in the days before the violence of the Troubles". Irish Times; Britannica; Heaney estate

conflict

Tension was already there: Catholics argued they faced discrimination in housing and jobs. A protest march in Derry on 5 October 1968 "was violently suppressed". Britannica

conflict · power

one source

You could suggest, with hindsight, that the storm hints at the violence to come. That is a reading, not a fact: never say the poem was written during the Troubles. Britannica (dates)

conflict

our reading

His Irish Times obituary says he "always felt it was impossible for him to take sides". Irish Times obituary

conflict

one source

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Heaney grew up on a farm in Northern Ireland, so he knew nature as a hard, sometimes violent force rather than a pretty view. Writing in 1964, he shows a whole community bracing itself against an invisible enemy; with hindsight, you could read this as a picture of the fear that came with the Troubles from 1968.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

A

Storm on the Island + Ozymandias

Use for: **Nature** **Power** · AQA: specimen and 2018 mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both show human power is weaker than nature: the islanders are helpless as the wind *"strafes invisibly."*; the king's empire is now *"lone and level sands"*.
- Both start confident and end humbled: *"We are prepared;"* and *"king of kings"*.

DIFFERENT

- **Speed:** in Storm nature attacks right now: *"Space is a salvo,"*. In Ozymandias nature and time win slowly, over thousands of years.
- **Voice:** Storm is spoken by a "we" living through it, so it feels close and frightening. Ozymandias is told second-hand by a traveller, so it feels distant.
- **Ending:** Heaney ends in fear (*"a huge nothing that we fear."*); Shelley ends calmly mocking (*"Nothing beside remains."*).

B

Storm on the Island + Extract from The Prelude

Use for: **Nature** **Power** **Fear** · AQA: specimen, 2018, 2021 and 2023 mark schemes (2021 and 2023: "the power of nature")

SIMILAR

- Both begin with human confidence: *"We are prepared;"* and the young Wordsworth, *"Proud of his skill"*.
- Both use the word "huge" for nature's threat: *"a huge nothing"* and *"a huge peak, black and huge"*.
- Both are in blank verse, and both end on lasting fear: *"that we fear."* and *"a trouble to my dreams."*

DIFFERENT

- **Visible or invisible:** Wordsworth's mountain is a giant shape that *"Strode after me."* Heaney's enemy is the *"empty air."*, which cannot be seen at all.
- **One or many:** The Prelude is one boy's private, guilty memory. Storm is a whole community ("we") under attack in the present.
- **What kind of attack:** Wordsworth's fear is in the mind; Heaney's storm physically *"pummels your house"*.

Storm on the Island + Exposure

C

Use for: **Conflict** **Nature** **Fear** · AQA: 2017 mark scheme ("presentation of the natural world in 'Exposure' or 'Storm on the Island'"); 2025 ("conflict with nature/the elements")

SIMILAR

- Both make the weather the real enemy, using war words: "*Space is a salvo,*" and "*Dawn massing in the east her melancholy army*".
- Both use a collective voice of people waiting helplessly: "*We just sit tight*" and "*Wearied we keep awake*".
- Both are haunted by emptiness: "*a huge nothing that we fear.*" and the refrain "*But nothing happens.*"

DIFFERENT

- Real war or imagined war:** Owen's soldiers are in a real war, and the cold kills them: "*All their eyes are ice,*". Heaney's islanders are not at war; the war is a metaphor.
- Who dies:** no one dies in Storm; the fear is of what might happen. Exposure ends with a burial party.
- Form:** Storm is one solid block of blank verse; Exposure has eight stanzas, each ending on a short, flat line.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present ideas about conflict in 'Storm on the Island' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (AQA used "ideas about conflict" in 2022 and 2025.)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Heaney and Owen present conflict with nature as more frightening than conflict with people, but Heaney's islanders are terrified by an invisible enemy, while Owen's soldiers are actually being killed by it.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets turn the weather into an enemy army. Heaney's wind "*strafes invisibly*" and "*Space is a salvo,*": military verbs and metaphors make the storm an air raid on helpless civilians. Owen goes further, describing "*Dawn massing in the east her melancholy army*", so even the sunrise attacks. Yet the threat feels different. Heaney's community can only "*sit tight*", and the poem ends on the paradox of "*a huge nothing that we fear.*" The fear is of what might happen. In Exposure the soldiers wait too, but the refrain "*But nothing happens.*" is bitterly ironic, because the cold is killing them: "*All their eyes are ice,*". Heaney presents nature's conflict as terrifying; Owen shows it as deadly.

Why it scores:

- The thesis answers the conflict question and states a clear difference in one sentence
- Short quotations from both poems, each with a named method (military verbs, metaphor, paradox, refrain)
- Compares throughout ("Both", "Owen goes further", "Yet") and ends with a sharp judgement

Extract from The Prelude

William Wordsworth (1770–1850) · begun 1798–99, published 1850

07

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Nature · AQA mark schemes: specimen, 2018, Nov 2021, 2023 (“the power of nature”)

Power · AQA specimen mark scheme (“Romantic ideas about power”); 2018 mark scheme (“effects of power on the individual”)

Time · AQA mark scheme 2018 (“power of nature / time from a Romantic perspective”)

Pride · our reading

Fear · our reading

Memory · our reading

Childhood · our reading

Guilt · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Blank verse extract (44 lines)

IN THE EXAM?

**Not yet the printed poem;
suggested as a partner in
AQA mark schemes
(specimen, 2018, 2021, 2023)**

BEST PARTNER

Storm on the Island

THE STORY IN SHORT

A boy takes a boat that isn't his and rows out on a lake at night. A huge black mountain peak seems to rise up and chase him, so he rows back, scared. For days afterwards his mind is haunted.

THE MESSAGE

Nature is far more powerful than a proud human. It can teach us through fear as well as through beauty, and that lesson stays in the mind for a long time.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Wordsworth was a Romantic poet who believed nature shaped who he became. He said he grew up “Foster'd alike by beauty and by fear”.

Britannica

THE TITLE

A “prelude” is an introduction. Wordsworth meant this long poem to introduce an even bigger one, *The Recluse*, which he never finished. Its full title is *The Prelude, or, Growth of a Poet's Mind*: it is the story of how his mind grew. “Extract from” tells you that you are reading only 44 lines from Book One, which is about his childhood and school-time. (Britannica; 1850 first edition (Advertisement), Project Gutenberg)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

An adult poet remembers one evening from his boyhood in the Lake District. Everything is in the past tense and told in his own voice, "I".

Lines 1–7

One summer evening he finds a little boat tied to a tree. He unties it and rows out without asking. He knows it is wrong: it is *"an act of stealth / And troubled pleasure"*.

Lines 8–16

The oars leave circles of moonlight on the water. Feeling *"Proud of his skill"*, he fixes his eyes on the top of a rocky ridge and rows in a straight line towards it. Above it there is only sky and stars.

Lines 17–20

He feels magical and confident. The boat is *"an elfin pinnacle"* (a small fairy boat) gliding *"like a swan"*.

Lines 21–29

Suddenly, from behind the ridge, *"a huge peak, black and huge"* appears. As he rows on, it seems to grow, to rise up like a living creature, and to stride after him.

Lines 29–34

Terrified, he turns round *"With trembling oars"*, creeps back, ties up the boat and walks home through the fields in a *"grave / And serious mood"*.

Lines 35–44

For many days his mind is troubled. He can no longer picture pleasant things like trees, sea and *"green fields"*. Instead *"huge and mighty forms"* move through his thoughts by day and trouble his dreams at night.

The turning point (lines 21–24): "When, from behind that craggy steep..." The peak *"Upreared its head"*, and the proud, happy mood flips into fear. **How it ends:** Not on the lake, but inside his mind. The mountain is gone, yet *"huge and mighty forms"* are still *"a trouble to my dreams"*. **The tone:** Starts calm, magical and proud. Becomes tense and frightening. Ends serious and unsettled, as the adult looks back on how the experience changed him.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. Your anthology prints “rocky cove”; some older

THE POEM

One summer evening (led by her) I found
A little boat tied to a willow tree
Within a rocky cove, its usual home.
Straight I unloosed her chain, and stepping in
Pushed from the shore. It was an act of stealth
And troubled pleasure, nor without the voice
Of mountain-echoes did my boat move on;

Leaving behind her still, on either side,
Small circles glittering idly in the moon,
Until they melted all into one track
Of sparkling light. But now, like one who
rows,
Proud of his skill, to reach a chosen point
With an unswerving line, I fixed my view
Upon the summit of a craggy ridge,
The horizon's utmost boundary; far above
Was nothing but the stars and the grey sky.

She was an elfin pinnacle; lustily
I dipped my oars into the silent lake,
And, as I rose upon the stroke, my boat
Went heaving through the water like a swan;

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

"her" in line 1 is Nature: the lines just before this extract talk about "Nature" and "her aim". So Nature leads him to the boat. He takes it without asking ("stealth" = sneaking). He enjoys it, but feels guilty: "troubled pleasure". Even the mountains seem to echo back at him.

Here "her" is the boat. The oars leave ripples that shine in the moonlight. He is proud of his rowing and fixes his eyes on the top of a ridge, which seems to be the edge of the world ("utmost boundary"). He thinks he is in control.

A **pinnacle** is a small boat; **elfin** means fairy-like. "**lustily**" = with lots of energy. The boat glides gracefully, like a swan. This is the high point of his confidence.

When, from behind that craggy steep till then
The horizon's bound, a huge peak, black and
huge,
As if with voluntary power instinct,
Upreared its head. I struck and struck again,
And growing still in stature the grim shape
Towered up between me and the stars, and still,
For so it seemed, with purpose of its own
And measured motion like a living thing,
Strode after me. With trembling oars I turned,

And through the silent water stole my way
Back to the covert of the willow tree;
There in her mooring-place I left my bark, –
And through the meadows homeward went, in
grave
And serious mood; but after I had seen

That spectacle, for many days, my brain
Worked with a dim and undetermined sense
Of unknown modes of being; o'er my
thoughts
There hung a darkness, call it solitude
Or blank desertion. No familiar shapes
Remained, no pleasant images of trees,
Of sea or sky, no colours of green fields;
But huge and mighty forms, that do not live
Like living men, moved slowly through the
mind
By day, and were a trouble to my dreams.

As he rows away from the shore, a bigger mountain behind the ridge comes into view. To him it looks alive: **"voluntary power instinct"** = filled with its own will and power. The harder he rows (**"struck"** the water), the taller it seems to grow, blocking out the stars. It seems to stride after him like a giant. **"For so it seemed"** admits it was his imagination.

He creeps back (**"stole my way"**: a pun, since he stole the boat too), returns the boat (**"bark"** = boat) to its hiding place (**"covert"**) and walks home, shaken and serious.

For days he can't stop thinking about it. He senses **"unknown modes of being"**: kinds of existence or power he doesn't understand. His mind feels dark, lonely and empty. His happy pictures of nature are replaced by giant, mysterious shapes that haunt him day and night.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"One summer evening (led by her) I found"

Means: Nature ("her") led him to the boat. **Why it matters:** from the first line, nature is in charge, not the boy.

LINES 5-6

"It was an act of stealth / And troubled pleasure"

Means: he knows he's doing wrong, but enjoys it. **Technique:** oxymoron: "troubled" and "pleasure" clash, showing guilt mixed with thrill.

LINE 12

"Proud of his skill"

Means: he feels confident and in control. **Why it matters:** pride comes before a fall: nature is about to humble him.

LINE 17

"She was an elfin pinnacle"

Means: the boat feels like a magical fairy boat. **Technique:** metaphor: a child's playful, romantic view, just before the fear.

LINE 22

"a huge peak, black and huge"

Means: the mountain is enormous and dark. **Technique:** repetition of "huge", as if words fail him; dark colour adds menace.

LINE 29

"Strode after me. With trembling oars I turned"

Means: the mountain seems to chase him and he flees in fear. **Technique:** personification, then a caesura (the full stop) as he turns: power swaps sides.

LINES 42-43

"huge and mighty forms, that do not live / Like living men"

Means: strange, giant shapes now fill his mind. **Why it matters:** the experience changes how he sees nature for good; ends with "a trouble to my dreams".

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: what blank verse is, and what Wordsworth does with it

ABOUT THE FORM

- **Blank verse** is “unrhymed iambic pentameter”: about ten syllables a line in a da-DUM, da-DUM rhythm, with no rhyme.

Britannica; poets.org

- In skilled hands it can sound close to real talk: Britannica says Shakespeare's blank verse is “approximating the rhythms of speech”.

Britannica

- It is the form of great serious poems, such as Milton's epic *Paradise Lost*. poets.org; Britannica
- The Prelude is an **autobiographical epic**: an epic is usually a “long narrative poem recounting heroic deeds”, but here the hero is the poet himself, and the story is how his mind grew. Britannica **epic definition: one source**

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **First person, past tense**: the adult Wordsworth looks back on a childhood memory, so we get the boy's feelings and the man's reflection.
- **No rhyme, no stanzas**: one unbroken block of 44 lines. It flows like a remembered story told aloud. **our count**
- **Enjambment** (sentences running over line ends) speeds the panic: “I struck and struck again, / And growing still in stature the grim shape / Towered up...” The mountain seems to grow across the lines. **our reading**
- **Sudden stops**: “Upreared its head.” and “Strode after me.” each finish a long sentence. They sit at the start of a line and stop dead at a full stop (a **caesura**, a pause inside a line), like sudden movements. **our reading**
- **Structure**: calm → proud → terrified → haunted. The poem doesn't end with the escape; it ends inside his mind, which is where the real effect lies.

A sentence you could use: Wordsworth uses blank verse, the flexible, speech-like form of serious epic poetry, to tell a small childhood memory, which shows how important this moment was in the growth of his mind; the run-on lines make the mountain seem to grow before our eyes.

The mountain comes alive

The peak “*Upreared its head*” and “*Strode after me*”, “*with purpose of its own*”. Nature becomes a giant that seems to punish the boy. But “*For so it seemed*” reminds us it is his guilty imagination at work.

Personification: giving human actions or feelings to something that isn't human.

Light turns to dark

At first everything shines: “*glittering*”, “*sparkling light*”, the moon. After the peak appears: “*black*”, “*grim shape*”, “*There hung a darkness*”. The light and colour drain out of his world, just as his confidence does.

Contrast: putting two opposite things close together so each stands out more.

Repetition that grows

“a huge peak, black and huge”, “I struck and struck again”, “and still”. The repeated words make the mountain seem to keep growing and the boy keep panicking, as if he is stuck in a nightmare.

Repetition: using the same word or phrase more than once for effect.

An ending inside the mind

The last ten lines are not about the lake at all. Pleasant images such as “green fields” are replaced by “huge and mighty forms”. Nature's power doesn't just scare him once; it changes the way he thinks.

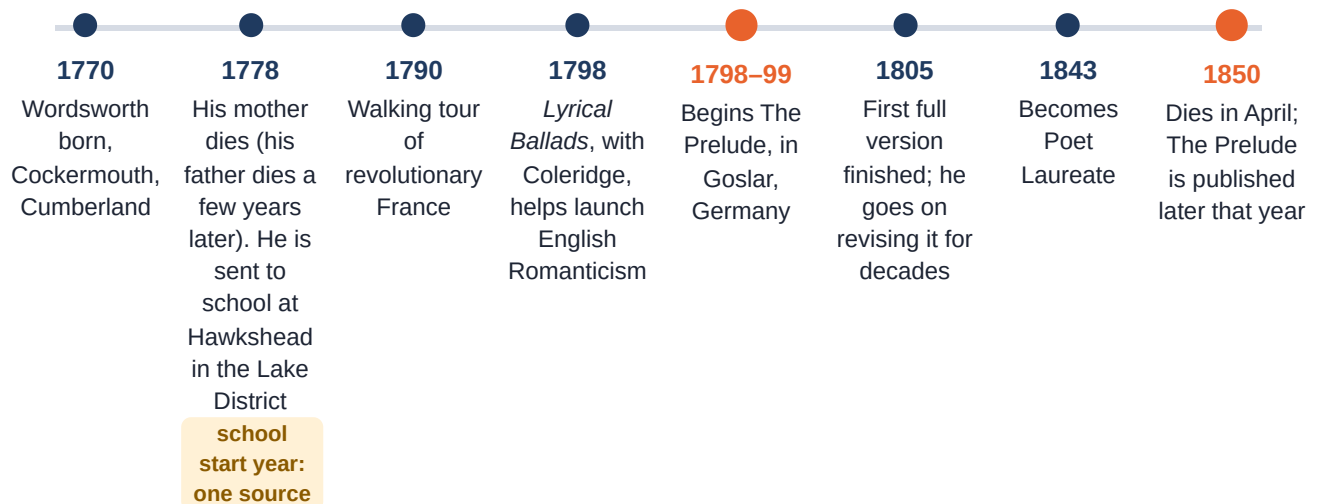
Turning point (shift): the moment a poem changes direction or mood (here, lines 21–24).

Examiners warn: “If you want to talk about structure, perhaps consider beginnings and endings of the text rather than trying to talk about particular structural features such as enjambment / caesura / rhyme schemes if you have nothing useful to say about them.” (AQA 2023 report). So only mention enjambment if you say what it does.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO WORDSWORTH WAS

Born in 1770 in Cockermouth, in the Lake District area of north-west England. [Britannica](#); [Poetry Archive](#); [Wordsworth Trust](#)

He lost his mother when he was 7 and his father when he was 13. [Britannica](#); [Poetry Archive](#)

nature as a guide or parent: “(led by her)”

the link is our reading

He went to school at Hawkshead, “a village in the heart of the Lake District”, where [Britannica](#) says the chief advantage was the chance to play outdoors. [Britannica](#); [Wordsworth Trust](#)

nature · childhood

As a student in 1790 he walked through revolutionary France and became “an ardent republican sympathizer” (he supported the revolution against the king). [Britannica](#); [Poetry Archive](#)

power

In 1843 he “reluctantly became Poet Laureate” (the official national poet). He died in 1850.

[Poetry Archive](#); [Britannica](#)

THE STORY BEHIND THE POEM

The Prelude is an “autobiographical epic poem in blank verse”: the story of his own life, told as a long, serious poem. [Britannica](#)

memory · identity

He began it in Germany in the winter of 1798–99 and kept revising it for about 40 years: there are four manuscript versions. [Wordsworth Trust](#);

[Britannica](#) **time · memory**

the first edition says it was begun in 1799

It is addressed to his friend, the poet Samuel Taylor Coleridge. The family called it “The Poem to Coleridge”. 1850 first edition; [Poetry Archive](#);

[Wordsworth Trust](#) **the personal, confiding voice**

It was only published after his death, in 1850. It was meant as the introduction to a bigger poem, *The Recluse*, which he never finished.

[Britannica](#); 1850 first edition

The extract comes from Book One, “Childhood and School-time”. Its subject is how the poet's mind and imagination grew. 1850 first edition;

[Britannica](#) **effects of power on the individual**

ROMANTICISM AND THE SUBLIME

Lyrical Ballads (1798), written with Coleridge, “helped launch the English Romantic movement”. Britannica; Wordsworth Trust

Romantic ideas about power

The Romantics valued nature, feeling and imagination: Britannica describes “an exaltation of emotion over reason”: putting feelings above logic. Britannica

nature

one source

Wordsworth called poetry “the spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings”, “recollected in tranquility”. This extract is exactly that: a strong feeling, remembered calmly years later.

Britannica

memory

link to the extract is our reading

The sublime: the philosopher Edmund Burke (1757) linked it with “awe, terror and danger”, and saw nature as the most sublime thing of all. The peak is sublime: terrifying and awe-inspiring at once. Tate; Britannica

the power of nature

applying it to this poem is our reading

AQA's own mark scheme uses the word: it contrasts “ugliness of power in ‘London’” with the “more sublime imagery of ‘extract from The Prelude’”. AQA mark scheme June 2023

power · nature

WHAT THE REST OF THE POEM TELLS US

Earlier in Book One he says he grew up “Fostered alike by beauty and by fear”: nature raised him through both. 1850 first edition; Britannica

fear · nature

The lines just before the extract say Nature sometimes teaches through “Severer interventions”, “as best might suit her aim”. That is who “her” is in “(led by her)”. 1850 first edition

the power of nature

Just before that, he remembers stealing birds from other people's traps and then hearing “Low breathings coming after me”. So the boat story is a pattern: wrongdoing, then nature seems to pursue him. 1850 first edition

guilt · conscience

the pattern is our reading

Straight after the extract he thanks the “Spirit of the universe” for teaching him through nature, not “the mean and vulgar works of man”, so that pain and fear led him to see “A grandeur in the beatings of the heart”. 1850 first edition

effects of power on the individual

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Wordsworth was a Romantic poet who believed nature shaped his mind, “Fostered alike by beauty and by fear”. By showing a proud boy terrified by a mountain, he presents nature as a sublime power, greater than any human, that teaches through fear and changes how a person thinks for ever.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Extract from The Prelude + Storm on the Island

A

Use for: **Nature** **Power** · AQA: specimen, 2018, Nov 2021 and 2023 mark schemes ("the power of nature in 'extract from The Prelude' or 'Storm on the Island'")

SIMILAR

- Both show human confidence beaten by nature: the boy is *"Proud of his skill"*; the islanders say *"We are prepared:"*. Both are proved wrong.
- Both turn nature into a living attacker: the peak *"Strode after me"*; the sea *"spits like a tame cat / Turned savage"*.
- Both end with fear of something huge and hard to name: *"huge and mighty forms"* and *"a huge nothing that we fear."*

DIFFERENT

- **Who:** one boy alone ("I") against a whole community ("We").
- **When:** Wordsworth looks back on a past memory; Heaney's storm happens in the present tense, now.
- **Seen or unseen:** the peak is all too visible, *"black and huge"*; Heaney's wind *"strafes invisibly"*.
- **What it leads to:** Wordsworth's fear changes his mind and, as a Romantic, he values it; Heaney's islanders just sit tight and endure.

Extract from The Prelude + Ozymandias

B

Use for: **Power** **Pride** **Nature** · AQA: specimen mark scheme (Ozymandias question: "comparisons between human and natural power, such as 'Extract from The Prelude'"); 2018 mark scheme ("power of nature / time from a Romantic perspective")

SIMILAR

- Both humble human pride: *"Proud of his skill"* and *"king of kings"*. In both, a greater power wins.
- Both are by Romantic poets and end on nature's vastness: *"huge and mighty forms"* and *"The lone and level sands stretch far away."*

DIFFERENT

- **Whose pride:** Shelley mocks a tyrant; Wordsworth looks honestly at his own pride as a boy.
- **Does anyone learn?** Ozymandias is long dead and his boast just looks foolish; the boy survives and is changed.
- **Time:** one evening on a lake against thousands of years in a desert.
- **Voice:** a personal first-person memory against a story told second-hand by a traveller.



Extract from The Prelude + Remains

Use for: **Memory** **Effects of conflict** **Guilt** · Our suggestion

SIMILAR

- Both speakers are haunted by a memory that won't leave: *"a trouble to my dreams"* and *"he's here in my head when I close my eyes"*.
- Both look back on something they did wrong: *"an act of stealth"* and shooting a man who was *"probably armed, possibly not"*.

DIFFERENT

- **How serious:** borrowing a boat against killing a man; the soldier's guilt is far heavier.
- **Does it end?** In the lines after the extract, Wordsworth's fear becomes a lesson that made him grow; the soldier gets no peace: *"his bloody life in my bloody hands."*
- **Language:** grand, flowing blank verse against chatty modern speech (*"End of story, except not really."*).

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present the power of nature in 'Extract from The Prelude' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'.

A strong opening (thesis): Both Wordsworth and Heaney show nature overpowering human confidence, but Wordsworth's boy is changed by a terror he comes to value, while Heaney's islanders can only endure a force they cannot even see.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present nature as a power that crushes human confidence. Wordsworth's boy rows out *"Proud of his skill"*, until *"a huge peak, black and huge"* rises up; the repetition of *"huge"* suggests words fail him. Personified, the peak *"Strode after me"*, and he flees *"With trembling oars"*. Heaney's islanders also begin confidently, insisting *"We are prepared:"*, yet the wind *"strafes invisibly"* and *"Space is a salvo"*, war imagery that makes nature an army. However, while Heaney's storm stays invisible, *"a huge nothing that we fear"*, Wordsworth's mountain leaves *"huge and mighty forms"* in his mind. As a Romantic, he presents this sublime fear as part of his growth, whereas Heaney's islanders simply endure.

Why it scores:

- Opens with a clear point that answers the question on the power of nature
- Short quotations from both poems, with methods (repetition, personification, war imagery) and their effects
- Compares throughout ("also", "However", "whereas") and brings in Romantic context briefly and relevantly

Exposure

Wilfred Owen (1893–1918) · published 1920, after Owen's death

08

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Conflict · AQA question 2025

Nature · AQA mark schemes 2017, 2022

Effects of conflict · AQA mark schemes 2017, 2024

War · AQA examiners' report 2022

Power · AQA mark schemes 2021, 2023

Difficult experiences · AQA mark scheme Nov 2020

Patriotism and duty · our reading

Place and home · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

8 five-line stanzas (40 lines),
half-rhyme

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: June 2025 (“ideas about
conflict”)

BEST PARTNER

Storm on the Island (your
anchor); Bayonet Charge
also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

Soldiers lie awake all night
in a freezing trench on the
Western Front, waiting for
an attack. Nothing
happens, but the cold
slowly kills them.

THE MESSAGE

In this war the weather is a
deadlier enemy than the
guns. The soldiers suffer
and die for nothing, and
even their faith is fading.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Owen was an officer who
lay out in the snow himself
in January 1917, when
one of his men froze to
death. Wilfred Owen Association

THE TITLE

To suffer **exposure** is to be left out in the open with no shelter, at the mercy of the weather. That is exactly what kills these men. The word can also mean revealing a hidden truth: Owen exposes what the war was really like for the soldiers. **second meaning: our reading** (Wilfred Owen Association (Merryn Williams): the men are “lying in the open under freezing conditions”)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

A group of soldiers (“we”) are in a front-line trench on a winter night in the First World War. They are on watch, expecting the enemy, and they speak to us in the present tense.

Lines 1–10

The icy wind seems to stab them. They stay awake because it is too quiet. Sentries whisper nervously. The wind tugs at the barbed wire, and guns rumble far away. They ask, “What are we doing here?”

Lines 11–20

Dawn comes, but it brings only more misery: rain, cloud and a grey sky that attacks like an army. Bullets fly past, but they are “Less deadly” than the freezing air, black with snow. Again, nothing happens.

Lines 21–25

Snowflakes touch their faces. Dazed by the cold, the men drift into dreams of warm, sunny ditches full of flowers and blackbirds. They wonder, “Is it that we are dying?”

Lines 26–30

In their minds they travel home like ghosts. The fire is burning low, crickets sing and mice have taken over the house. But the doors are shut to them, so they turn back to the trench and their dying.

Lines 31–35

They try to explain why they stay: they believe they are out here so that the fires at home can keep burning and children and fields can be safe. Yet even their love of God seems to be dying.

Lines 36–40

The last stanza looks ahead to tonight. The frost “will” freeze the mud and the men. A burying-party will stop over faces they half-know, whose eyes are ice. And still nothing happens.

The turning point (line 21): the snowflakes “come feeling for our faces”, and the poem drifts from the frozen trench into a half-dream of warmth and home. The dream ends with the doors “closed” against them. **How it ends:** In the future tense: tonight the frost “will” kill more of them. The final words, “But nothing happens.”, bring us back to the first stanza. Nothing has changed except that men have died. **The tone:** Weary, numb and bitter. The repeated questions and the flat refrain make the waiting feel endless.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. Quote the anthology wording. Watch out: when AQA printed Exposure in June 2025, a few words were different (“Nor ever suns”, “Tonight, this frost”), so if it is printed

THE POEM

Our brains ache, in the merciless iced east
winds that knife us ...

Wearied we keep awake because the night is
silent ...

Low, drooping flares confuse our memory of
the salient ...

Worried by silence, sentries whisper, curious,
nervous,

But nothing happens.

Watching, we hear the mad gusts tugging on
the wire,

Like twitching agonies of men among its
brambles.

Northward, incessantly, the flickering gunnery
rumbles,

Far off, like a dull rumour of some other war.

What are we doing here?

The poignant misery of dawn begins to grow ...

We only know war lasts, rain soaks, and
clouds sag stormy.

Dawn massing in the east her melancholy
army

Attacks once more in ranks on shivering ranks
of grey,

But nothing happens.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The wind feels like knives. The men are too tense to sleep. Flares (lights fired into the sky) droop and fade. The **salient** is a bulge in the front line that juts into enemy land, so it can be attacked from several sides. The ellipses (...) make time drag.

The barbed wire shakes in the wind like dying men caught on it. Real fighting is happening somewhere else, far away. The short last line asks what the point of it all is.

Dawn should bring hope. Instead it is an enemy army of grey clouds attacking the grey, shivering soldiers. The list of short clauses (war lasts, rain soaks...) sounds flat and hopeless.

Sudden successive flights of bullets streak the
silence.

Less deadly than the air that shudders black
with snow,

With sidelong flowing flakes that flock, pause,
and renew,

We watch them wandering up and down the
wind's nonchalance,

But nothing happens.

Pale flakes with **fingering stealth** come feeling
for our faces -

We cringe in holes, back on forgotten dreams,
and stare, snow-dazed,

Deep into grassier ditches. So we drowse, sun-
dozed,

Littered with blossoms trickling where the
blackbird fusses.

– Is it that we are dying?

Slowly our ghosts drag home: glimpsing the
sunk fires, glozed

With **crusted dark-red jewels**; crickets jingle
there;

For hours the innocent mice rejoice: the house
is theirs;

Shutters and doors, all closed: **on us the doors**
are closed, -

We turn back to our dying.

Bullets fly, but the snowy air is *more* deadly
than they are. The hissing “s” sounds copy
the bullets and the wind. **“nonchalance”** =
not caring: the wind doesn't care about them
at all.

The snow creeps up like a thief's fingers.
Numb with cold, the men slip into a dream of
summer. Drowsiness in the cold is a sign of
freezing to death, which is why they ask if
they are dying.

Their minds go home, but only as “ghosts”.
The fire is low: its embers glow like jewels but
give no warmth. Mice own the house now.
The doors are shut on *them*: there is no place
for them at home, so they go back to die.

Since we believe not otherwise can kind fires
burn;

Now ever suns smile true on child, or field, or
fruit.

For God's invincible spring our love is made
afraid;

Therefore, not loath, we lie out here; therefore
were born,

For love of God seems dying.

Tonight, His frost will fasten on this mud and
us,

Shrivelling many hands. puckering foreheads
crisp.

The burying-party, picks and shovels in their
shaking grasp,

Pause over half-known faces. All their eyes
are ice,

But nothing happens.

The hardest stanza. They tell themselves
they must stay out here so that the fires at
home keep burning and children and fields
stay safe. **"not loath"** = not unwilling. But the
last line admits their faith is fading.

A prediction: tonight God's frost will freeze
them. Soldiers sent to bury the dead will stop
over faces they half-recognise, frozen solid.
(The full stop after "hands" is how the
anthology prints it; other texts have a comma.
Don't quote that line.)

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

*"Our brains ache, in the merciless iced east
winds that knife us"*

Means: the cold wind feels like it is stabbing them.

Technique: personification: the wind is a cruel
attacker with a knife.

LINES 5, 15, 20, 40

"But nothing happens."

Means: the waiting never ends, and nothing
changes. **Technique:** refrain; a flat, short line after
long ones (anticlimax).

LINE 10

"What are we doing here?"

Means: the soldiers cannot see the point of the
war. **Technique:** rhetorical question (asked for
effect, not for an answer), showing doubt.

LINE 13

*"Dawn massing in the east her melancholy
army"*

Means: even the sunrise is an enemy attacking
them. **Technique:** metaphor and personification:
nature as an army.

LINE 17

*“Less deadly than the air that shudders black
with snow”*

Means: the weather kills more than the bullets do.

Why it matters: the real enemy is nature, not the Germans.

LINE 29

“on us the doors are closed”

Means: there is no way home for them. **Why it**

matters: repetition of “closed” shuts them out of home and safety.

LINE 39

“All their eyes are ice”

Means: the dead men are frozen solid.

Technique: metaphor; the soft half-rhyme of “eyes” and “ice”.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: half-rhyme, a refrain and a circle

ABOUT THE FORM

- **Half-rhyme** (also called slant rhyme) is when two words nearly rhyme but not quite: “two words that have only their final consonant sounds” in common. *Britannica*
- **Pararhyme** is Owen's own version: he keeps the consonants the same and changes the vowel, as in “hall” and “Hell”, or “mystery” and “mastery”. *Yale Modernism Lab*
- **Why poets use it:** a full rhyme sounds neat and finished. A half-rhyme sounds slightly wrong, so the ear is left unsatisfied. That suits a poem about unease. **our reading**
- *Britannica* notes Owen's “technical experiments in assonance” (repeated vowel sounds), which were later “particularly influential in the 1930s”. *Britannica*
- A **refrain** is a line repeated at the end of stanzas, like a chorus in a song.

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **40 lines in 8 stanzas** of five lines. *EBSCO*; **our count** Four long lines are followed by a short fifth line that hangs on its own.
- The first four lines of each stanza half-rhyme in an **ABBA** pattern: “knife us / silent / salient / nervous”, “wire / brambles / rumbles / war”. **our count**
- The Wilfred Owen Association praises the “daring half-rhymes - ‘knife us/nervous’, ‘nonchalance/happens’” and “the short, simple, hanging line at the end of each verse.” *Wilfred Owen Association*
- **Refrain:** “But nothing happens.” ends stanzas 1, 3, 4 and 8. The other short lines move closer and closer to death: “Is it that we are dying?”, “We turn back to our dying.”, “For love of God seems dying.” **our count**
- **Circular structure:** “When it ends, they are exactly where they were in the first verse.” *Wilfred Owen Association* The poem goes round in a loop, like the soldiers' endless nights.
- **Why it matters:** the rhymes never quite click and the refrain never changes, so the form itself feels stuck and uneasy, just like the men.

our reading

A sentence you could use: Owen's pararhymes, like “knife us” and “nervous”, never quite chime, so the reader is left as tense and unsatisfied as the soldiers; and because the poem ends with the same line, “But nothing happens.”, its circular structure traps them in endless, pointless waiting.

Nature as the enemy

The wind has knives ("*winds that knife us*"), dawn is a "*melancholy army*" and the frost "*will fasten*" on them. Owen gives the weather the actions of soldiers, so the real battle is against nature.

Personification: giving human actions or feelings to something that isn't human.

Hissing sounds

"*Sudden successive flights of bullets streak the silence.*" The repeated "s" sounds copy the hiss of bullets and wind. AQA's 2025 mark scheme suggests writing about "effects of sibilance".

Sibilance: repeating "s" and "sh" sounds close together.

"We", not "I"

Owen speaks for all the men ("*we keep awake*", "*our ghosts*"), in the present tense. Their suffering is shared, and we live through the night with them.

Collective voice: a speaker who talks for a whole group, using "we" and "our".

Warm home, frozen trench

The dream of "*crusted dark-red jewels*" and "*innocent mice*" is warm and gentle, set against the ice and mud. The contrast makes the trench feel even crueler.

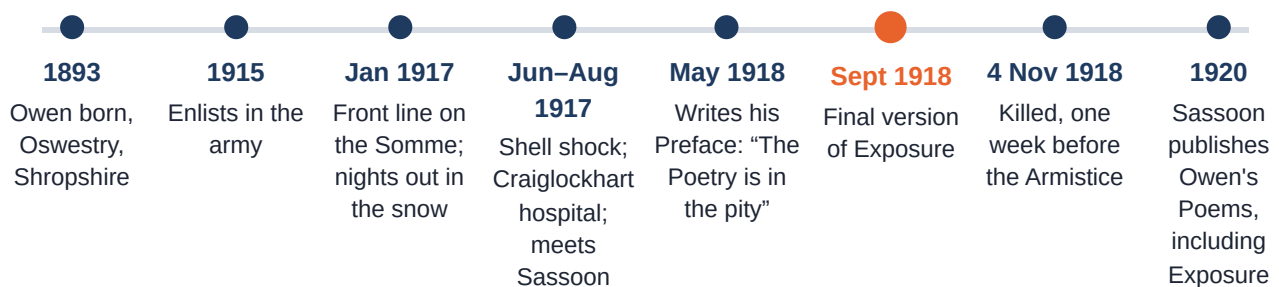
Juxtaposition: putting two very different things side by side to show the difference.

Examiners warn: AQA's June 2022 report said that "paragraphs about, for example, Owen's war experiences ... were not useful if they meant the student lost sight of the poem." Use a sentence of context, then go straight back to the words.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO OWEN WAS

Born in 1893 in Oswestry, Shropshire. He worked for a year as a vicar's assistant, then taught English in Bordeaux, France. [Britannica](#); [University of Oxford](#)

He loved the Romantic poet Keats: his early poems were “consciously modeled” on Keats's work. [Britannica](#); [Poetry Archive](#) **nature**

He enlisted in 1915 and became an officer in the Manchester Regiment, so he led men at the front. [University of Oxford](#); [poets.org](#); [Wilfred Owen Association](#) **patriotism and duty**

He won the Military Cross for bravery in October 1918, and was killed on 4 November 1918 crossing the Sambre–Oise canal, aged 25, a week before the war ended. [Britannica](#); [Poetry Archive](#); [Wilfred Owen Association](#) **effects of conflict**

Only four of his poems were published while he was alive. Most of his fame came after his death. [Wilfred Owen Association](#); [Poetry Archive](#)

THE WINTER BEHIND THE POEM

The poem is “based on Owen's experiences in the winter of 1917”, giving “a worm's-eye view of the front line”. [Wilfred Owen Association](#)

conflict · difficult experiences

In January 1917 his battalion arrived near Beaumont Hamel on the Somme. The winter of 1916–17 was extremely cold. [Wilfred Owen Association](#) **nature** **one source**

With no dugouts, the men had to “lie out in the snow in shell holes and in a bitterly piercing wind”. More were sent to hospital with frostbite than with wounds. [Wilfred Owen Association](#)

nature · effects of conflict **one source**

Owen wrote that “one of my party actually froze to death” and “we were marooned on a frozen desert”. Owen's own words, quoted by the [Wilfred Owen Association](#) **nature · conflict**

Another letter: “My feet ached until they could ache no more, and so they temporarily died.” [London Review of Books](#) (review of Owen's letters)

effects of conflict **one source**

SHELL SHOCK, SASSOON AND "THE PITY OF WAR"

In spring 1917 he was blown into the air by a shell and sent home with shell shock. At Craiglockhart hospital, Edinburgh, in summer 1917, he met the poet Siegfried Sassoon. Poetry

Archive; University of Oxford; Britannica

effects of conflict

April or May: sources differ

Sassoon encouraged him "to bring his war experiences into his poetry". Wilfred Owen

Association

In his Preface (1918) for a book of poems he planned, Owen wrote: "My subject is War, and the pity of War. The Poetry is in the pity." Wilfred

Owen Association; Durham University (manuscript)

conflict · effects of conflict

The printed Preface (1920) also says "This book is not about heroes" and "the true Poets must be truthful." Exposure tells the truth about suffering, not glory. Owen, Poems (1920), Project

Gutenberg

patriotism and duty

link to Exposure: our reading

The poet W. B. Yeats disliked Owen's work: "Passive suffering is not a theme for poetry". Exposure is entirely about passive suffering.

Wilfred Owen Association

power · powerlessness

one source

HOW THE POEM WAS MADE

Sources give different dates. The Owen Association says he began it at Abbeville in early 1917; the Poetry Archive says "written in February 1918"; Merryn Williams says "The final version of this poem belongs to September 1918". Wilfred Owen Association; Poetry Archive

sources conflict

The safe version: the poem comes from the winter of 1917, and Owen reworked it until September 1918, weeks before he was killed.

Wilfred Owen Association

"Our brains ache" echoes "My heart aches", the opening of Keats's "Ode to a Nightingale".

Owen felt his generation faced "horrors which the Romantics had not dreamed of". Wilfred Owen

Association

nature

one source

The dream of home recalls the wartime song "Keep the home fires burning", but in Owen's version "the fires are almost dead". Wilfred Owen

Association

patriotism and duty · home

one source

Stanza 7 can be read as the men being "Christ-figures, dying willingly" for others, while "Love of God seems dying" shows his old faith failing.

Wilfred Owen Association

patriotism and duty

a critic's reading

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Owen was an officer who lay out in the snow on the Somme in January 1917, when one of his own men froze to death. He wrote that "The Poetry is in the pity", and Exposure shows that pity: instead of heroic battles, it shows ordinary soldiers powerless against the cold, dying while "nothing happens".

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Exposure + Bayonet Charge

A

Use for: **Conflict** **Effects of conflict** **Nature** · AQA: 2025 mark scheme ("first-hand experience of conflict"); also 2019 and 2024 mark schemes and the Nov 2020 report

SIMILAR

- Both show the soldier's experience from the inside, at the front line, and both make the air itself dangerous: *"the merciless iced east winds that knife us"* and *"Bullets smacking the belly out of the air"*.
- Both soldiers doubt what they are fighting for: *"What are we doing here?"* and *"King, honour, human dignity, etcetera"*, which are dropped *"like luxuries"*.

DIFFERENT

- Speed:** Exposure is about endless waiting (*"But nothing happens."*); Bayonet Charge is sudden, panicked action: *"Suddenly he awoke and was running"*.
- Voice:** Owen uses "we", a whole group suffering together; Hughes uses "he", one lonely soldier.
- Nature:** in Exposure nature is the killer; in Bayonet Charge nature is another victim, the hare that *"rolled like a flame"*.

Exposure + Storm on the Island

B

Use for: **Nature** **Conflict** **Power** · AQA: 2025 mark scheme ("conflict with nature/the elements"); 2017 mark scheme ("the natural world in 'Exposure' or 'Storm on the Island'")

SIMILAR

- Both turn the weather into an army: *"Dawn massing in the east her melancholy army"* and *"Space is a salvo,"*
- Both groups ("we") are helpless and fear something empty: *"But nothing happens."* and *"a huge nothing that we fear."*

DIFFERENT

- Real war or metaphor?** Owen's men are in a real war and the cold kills them. Heaney's islanders only use war words for a storm, and they are safe indoors: *"We just sit tight"*.
- Tone:** Exposure is despairing. Storm is chatty and calm at first: *"you know what I mean"*.
- Ending:** Owen ends with death (*"All their eyes are ice,"*); Heaney ends with fear, not death.

Exposure + The Charge of the Light Brigade

C

Use for: **Patriotism and duty** **Conflict** **War** · AQA: 2025 mark scheme ("individual and collective experience of conflict"); 2017 mark scheme (soldiers and "those for whom they fought")

SIMILAR

- Both show soldiers who accept their duty and die for others: *"Theirs not to reason why,"* and *"Therefore, not loath, we lie out here,"*
- Both repeat a short line at the end of stanzas: *"Rode the six hundred."* and *"But nothing happens."*

DIFFERENT

- **Glory or pity?** Tennyson ends by praising: *"Honour the charge they made!"* Owen ends with frozen bodies: *"All their eyes are ice,"*
- **Action:** the Light Brigade charge heroically; Owen's men lie still and die of cold.
- **Questions:** Tennyson's soldiers do not ask why. Owen's soldiers do: *"What are we doing here?"*
- **Who is writing:** Tennyson, the Poet Laureate, wrote it "only a few minutes after reading an account in *The Times*" (Poetry Archive); Owen lived through the winter he describes.

7 In the exam

Compare how poets present ideas about conflict in 'Exposure' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (AQA, June 2025)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Owen and Armitage show that conflict destroys soldiers' minds as well as their bodies, but Owen's men suffer from endless waiting, while Armitage's soldier suffers from what he has done.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present conflict as something soldiers cannot escape. Owen's men are worn down by waiting; the refrain *"But nothing happens."* returns four times, so the reader shares their numb, endless watch. Their enemy is the weather, and the poem ends with a burial party over *"half-known faces"* whose *"eyes are ice"*. Armitage's soldier, by contrast, does act: *"all three of us open fire."* Yet his conflict never ends either, because the dead looter is *"here in my head when I close my eyes"*. Owen shows suffering caused by doing nothing; Armitage shows guilt caused by doing something. Both suggest that ordinary soldiers are powerless victims of conflicts far larger than themselves.

Why it scores:

- Opens with a clear point that answers the question about conflict
- Short quotations from both poems, with methods named (refrain) and explained
- Compares all the way through ("by contrast", "either", "Both") and ends on a big idea about powerlessness, which AQA's 2025 mark scheme lists for AO3

Remains

Simon Armitage (born 1963) · published 2008 (first heard in a 2007 TV film)

09

★ ANCHOR POEM: learn this one first

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Difficult experiences · AQA question November 2020

Effects of conflict · AQA mark schemes 2017 and 2024

Conflict · AQA mark schemes 2022 and 2025

War · AQA examiners' report 2022

Power · AQA mark scheme 2023 (victim of others' power)

Guilt · our reading

Memory · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Dramatic monologue: 7 four-line stanzas + a 2-line ending (30 lines)

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: November 2020

BEST PARTNER

Storm on the Island (your anchor when *Remains* is printed); **War Photographer** also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A British soldier tells how he and two others shot a looter who may not have been armed. Back home, he can't stop seeing the dead man.

THE MESSAGE

War doesn't end when the fighting stops. A few seconds of violence can haunt a soldier for the rest of his life.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Armitage wrote it for a TV film about ex-soldiers with PTSD. He turned a real soldier's account into a poem. simonarmitage.com; IDFA

THE TITLE

"Remains" has two meanings. **Human remains** are a dead body: the looter's body, "*carted off in the back of a lorry.*" And something that **remains** is something that stays. The body is taken away, but the memory and the guilt remain with the soldier. **our reading** (our reading)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

A soldier talks to us as if we were chatting. He jumps straight into the story with *"On another occasion"*, as if this was just one of many incidents. The whole poem is told in the present tense, so it feels like it's happening now.

Lines 1–4

His patrol is sent to deal with men robbing a bank. One of them runs off up the road. He might have had a gun, or might not: *"probably armed, possibly not."*

Lines 5–10

The speaker and two other soldiers all fire at once. He says he sees every bullet go through the man, so clearly that he can see daylight through the wounds.

Lines 11–16

The man has been hit about a dozen times and lies dying in agony. Another soldier casually *"tosses his guts back into his body"*. The body is thrown into a lorry and driven away.

Lines 17–19

"End of story, except not really." A bloodstain stays on the street, and he walks over it on patrol *"week after week."*

Lines 20–24

He goes home on leave, but the memory follows him. Whenever he blinks, sleeps or dreams, the shooting replays. Alcohol and drugs don't get rid of it.

Lines 25–30

The dead man now lives inside his head, like an enemy soldier hiding behind the lines. He isn't buried far away in the desert. He is *"here and now"*, and the soldier feels the man's life is in his hands.

The turning point (line 17): *"End of story, except not really."* The soldier tries to close the story with an everyday phrase, then admits it isn't over. The poem moves from the street in Iraq to the inside of his head. **How it ends:** On guilt that won't go away. The last line, *"his bloody life in my bloody hands."*, puts the man's death firmly in the speaker's own hands. **The tone:** It starts casual and matter-of-fact, almost boastful. It ends haunted, angry and full of guilt. The calm voice cracks as the poem goes on.

2 The poem, section by section

This poem is still in copyright, so we only show the key phrases here. Read the full poem in your anthology alongside these notes. Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright,

so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key words to quote.

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–4

On another occasion ... probably armed, possibly not.

LINES 5–8

myself and somebody else and somebody else ... all three of us open fire

LINES 9–12

I see every round as it rips through his life ... sort of inside out

LINES 13–16

tosses his guts back into his body ... carted off

LINES 17–19

End of story, except not really. ... His blood-shadow stays on the street

LINES 20–24

he bursts again through the doors of the bank ... won't flush him out

LINES 25–28

he's here in my head ... dug in behind enemy lines

LINES 29–30

here and now ... his bloody life in my bloody hands.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The patrol is sent to stop looters raiding a bank. One runs away. The soldier can't say for sure whether the man had a gun. **"legs it"** is slang for running away: he sounds like an ordinary bloke telling a story.

Three soldiers shoot at the same moment. He doesn't name the others, just **"somebody else"**, twice. Sharing the blame makes it feel less like his fault.

He describes the bullets (**"rounds"**) going right through the man. The man is hit about a dozen times. **"sort of inside out"** is horribly casual for such a gory sight.

The man is in agony. A mate throws his insides back in as if tidying up. The body is **"carted off"** in a lorry, like rubbish. The soldiers treat the dead man as an object.

He tries to end the story, but can't. The bloodstain is still there, and he has to walk over it on patrol, again and again.

At home on leave, every blink, sleep and dream replays the shooting. These are **flashbacks**, a key sign of PTSD. Drink and drugs can't wash the memory away.

The dead man is now like an enemy soldier hiding in a trench inside his mind. He is not safely buried in some far-off desert. The war has moved inside the soldier.

The poem ends in the present. **"bloody"** means covered in blood, and is also a swear word of anger and frustration. He takes the blame himself: **"my"** hands, not "our".

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"On another occasion"

Means: this was one incident among many, told like a casual anecdote (a short, everyday story).

Why it matters: killing has become routine. The poem starts in the middle of things, as if we're mid-conversation.

LINES 4 AND 22

"probably armed, possibly not."

Means: he will never know if the man was a real threat. **Technique:** repetition: the doubt comes back in line 22 because it keeps going round in his head.

LINE 9

"I see every round as it rips through his life"

Means: he watches every bullet hit the man.

Technique: alliteration ("round ... rips") and violent verbs; "I see" shows how vividly he relives it.

LINE 15

"tosses his guts back into his body"

Means: a soldier casually throws the man's insides back in. **Why it matters:** the careless verb "tosses" shows how soldiers become hardened to death.

LINE 17

"End of story, except not really."

Means: he wants the story to be over, but it isn't.

Technique: the turning point (volta): slang, then a blunt correction, then the poem moves into his mind.

LINE 21

"he bursts again through the doors of the bank"

Means: the shooting replays whenever he blinks.

Why it matters: this is a flashback: the past bursts into the present, just as PTSD works.

LINE 26

"dug in behind enemy lines"

Means: the memory has dug into his mind like an enemy soldier in a trench. **Technique:** military metaphor: the war hasn't ended; it's now inside him.

LINE 30

"his bloody life in my bloody hands."

Means: he is responsible for the man's death, and he can't escape it. **Why it matters:** "bloody" is both literal blood and a curse. WJEC hears an echo of Lady Macbeth trying to wash blood off her hands. [one source](#)

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a dramatic monologue that sounds like real speech

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **dramatic monologue** is “a poem written in the form of a speech of an individual character”. *Britannica*
- It packs a person's story into one vivid scene and shows us what is going on in their mind. *Britannica*
- Often the most interesting thing is what the speaker gives away about himself without meaning to. *Britannica* says the subject “is usually far less interesting than what is inadvertently revealed about the speaker himself.” *Britannica*
- Poets use it to let us hear a voice directly, with no narrator in between. So we judge the speaker for ourselves. **our reading**

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- The speaker is a soldier, talking straight to us. WJEC calls it “a dramatic monologue from the point of view of a soldier on active duty.” *WJEC*
one source
- It sounds like real speech: slang such as “*legs it*”, “*my mates*” and “*letting fly*”. That fits its origin: the poems in *The Not Dead* came from real soldiers' own accounts (their “testimonies”). *simonarmitage.com*; *WJEC*
- What he gives away: he starts off casual and sure of himself, but by the end he is falling apart. The voice shows the damage without him ever saying “I feel guilty”. **our reading**
- **Shape:** seven 4-line stanzas, then a 2-line ending (30 lines). WJEC suggests the shape may suggest “the continuous suffering of the soldier.” *our count*; *WJEC*
- **No regular rhyme or rhythm**, which WJEC says stresses “the seriousness of the situation”. Sentences run on over stanza breaks (“*I swear*” / “*I see*”; “*But I blink*” / “*and he bursts*”), like memories he can't hold back. *WJEC*; *our reading*
- **The short last stanza** breaks the pattern of fours. The poem stops rather than resolves, because his story has no ending. **our reading**

A sentence you could use: Armitage writes *Remains* as a dramatic monologue in a soldier's own slang, so the casual voice of the opening (“legs it”) slowly gives way to guilt; the speaker reveals his trauma without ever naming it, and the poem's unresolved two-line ending mirrors a memory that never ends.

A casual voice for a horrific event

Slang like “legs it” and “sort of inside out” makes the killing sound ordinary. The gap between the casual words and the horror shows how soldiers cope by switching off, until the feelings break through.

Colloquial language: everyday, informal speech, the way people actually talk.

From “we” to “I”

The first half spreads the blame: “all three of us open fire.” The second half is all “I”, “my head”, “my bloody hands.” At home there's no one to share the blame with. WJEC describes a move from “collective responsibility” to “individual feeling of guilt”.

Pronouns: words like I, we, he that stand for people. A shift in pronouns can show a shift in feeling.

Repetition that acts like a flashback

“probably armed, possibly not.” comes back in line 22, and “Sleep, and” / “Dream, and” start lines 22 and 23. The poem keeps circling back, just as his memory does.

Repetition: using the same words more than once, to stress an idea or show it won't go away.

War imagery inside his head

The memory is “dug in behind enemy lines”, military language. The enemy is no longer out on the street; it's inside his mind. The fighting has followed him home.

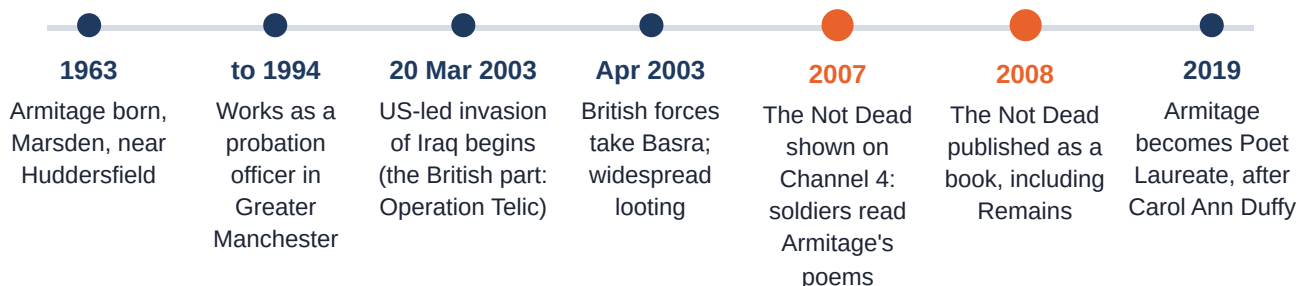
Metaphor: describing one thing as if it were another.

Examiners warn: AQA's 2022 report says “extraneous information about Guardsman Tromans” was “not useful” if students “lost sight of the poem”. Mention the real soldier in one sentence, then get back to the words of the poem.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO ARMITAGE IS

Born in 1963 in Marsden, near Huddersfield in West Yorkshire. He still lives in West Yorkshire. Britannica; simonarmitage.com

Until 1994 he worked as a probation officer, helping people after they'd been in trouble with the law. He was used to listening to people's hard stories. simonarmitage.com; Britannica

difficult experiences

the link to listening is our reading

Britannica says his poems are "attuned to modern life and vernacular language" (everyday speech). That is exactly how the soldier talks.

Britannica [voice · effects of conflict](#) [one source](#)

He became Poet Laureate in 2019, taking over from Carol Ann Duffy, who wrote War Photographer. Britannica; simonarmitage.com; WJEC

war · comparison link

THE NOT DEAD: THE FILM AND THE BOOK

Remains comes from *The Not Dead*, a Channel 4 documentary from 2007, directed by Brian Hill. simonarmitage.com; IDFA [effects of conflict](#)

[sources disagree on summer or winter 2007](#)

The film followed three ex-soldiers with PTSD, from Iraq, Bosnia and Malaya. Armitage wrote poems from their accounts, and the men read them to camera. IDFA; NZ International Film Festival; simonarmitage.com [difficult experiences · memory](#)

The young Iraq veteran in the film says: "We were prepared to go into the war, but we were not prepared to come out." IDFA

[effects of conflict](#) [one source](#)

Armitage's site says the poems "focus on the testimonies of veterans" who "have seldom been heard before." The book came out in 2008 (Pomona). simonarmitage.com; Google Books

[conflict · power \(whose voice is heard\)](#)

[one page of the official site wrongly gives 2004](#)

A Guardian review called them "poems of survivors" who "return from war in body but never, wholly, in mind." Guardian review (2008), quoted on war-poetry.com

[effects of conflict · memory](#) [second-hand copy](#)

IRAQ, 2003

A US-led force invaded Iraq on 20 March 2003. The British part was called Operation Telic.

National Army Museum; Britannica **war · conflict**

British troops took Basra, Iraq's second city, in early April 2003. They then faced "widespread looting in the city". National Army Museum; Britannica

difficult experiences

looting: one source

So soldiers trained for battle were policing chaotic streets, where it was hard to tell a thief from a gunman: "*probably armed, possibly not.*"

our reading

conflict · guilt

our reading

Remains is based on a British soldier who served in Iraq. WJEC names him as Guardsman Tromans. A bookseller's listing of the book adds that the poem was written for someone who served in Basra and shot a man looting a bank. One sentence is enough in an essay. WJEC; IDFA (the film's Iraq veteran); war-poetry.com bookseller listing

effects of conflict

Basra: one source (bookseller listing); the name: one source (WJEC)

PTSD: WHAT THE SOLDIER IS GOING THROUGH

The NHS defines PTSD (post-traumatic stress disorder) as "a mental health condition caused by very stressful, frightening or distressing events." War is one cause. NHS; Royal College of Psychiatrists

effects of conflict · difficult experiences

Key signs are "flashbacks" and "nightmares": feeling as if the event is "happening again in real time". Compare "*But I blink*" and "*Sleep, and ... Dream, and*". NHS; Royal College of

Psychiatrists

memory

People with PTSD often blame themselves, "even if you or they were not responsible."

Compare "*my bloody hands.*" Royal College of

Psychiatrists

guilt

one source

Alcohol may help for a moment, but "over time it can make you feel much worse." Compare "*the drink and the drugs won't flush him out*". Royal

College of Psychiatrists; NHS

effects of conflict

AQA's 2022 report lists "PTSD" as an "appropriate" idea for AO3. AQA examiners' report

2022

all war questions

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Remains grew out of a 2007 TV film in which real ex-soldiers with PTSD read Armitage's poems about their memories. By writing in a soldier's own slang, Armitage shows that the hardest part of war can come after it ends: a split-second decision on a street in Iraq becomes a flashback the soldier relives "here and now", years later at home.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Remains + War Photographer

A

Use for: **Difficult experiences** **Effects of conflict** **Memory** · AQA: Nov 2020 examiners' report ("used by many students"); 2024 mark scheme

SIMILAR

- Both men are back in safe Britain but haunted by one dead stranger: the looter "*bursts again through the doors of the bank*"; the photographer sees "*a half-formed ghost.*"
- Both poems leave a stain of blood behind: "*His blood-shadow stays on the street*" and "*the blood stained into foreign dust.*"
- Both show the shock arriving later: the photographer's hands "*did not tremble then*" "*though seem to now.*"; the soldier's story is "*End of story, except not really.*"

DIFFERENT

- **Doing or watching:** the soldier pulled the trigger, so his guilt is personal: "*my bloody hands.*" The photographer only recorded the deaths, so his guilt is about watching and doing nothing.
- **Voice:** Remains is first person and immediate; War Photographer is third person, calmer and more reflective. AQA's 2022 mark scheme contrasts the "immediacy" of Remains with the "more reflective stance" of War Photographer.
- **Who cares:** Duffy blames the public, who "*do not care.*" Armitage keeps the focus inside one damaged mind: "*here in my head*".

Remains + Exposure

B

Use for: **Effects of conflict** **Conflict** · AQA: 2017 mark scheme ("effects of war on the individual, such as 'Remains' or 'Exposure'"); 2022 and 2023 mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both are told by soldiers and use repetition to trap us in their minds: "*But nothing happens.*" and "*probably armed, possibly not.*"
- Both use dying and ghosts: Owen's men imagine "*Slowly our ghosts drag home:*"; Armitage's soldier brings his ghost home for real: "*he's here in my head*".
- Both question why they are there: "*What are we doing here?*" and the doubt of "*possibly not.*"

DIFFERENT

- **The enemy:** Owen's real enemy is the weather: "*merciless iced east winds that knife us*". Armitage's enemy is a memory, "*dug in behind enemy lines*" in his own head.
- **When:** Exposure is the suffering during war, in the trenches. Remains is mostly the suffering after it, at home.
- **Who:** Owen's "we" stays together to the end. Armitage's "we" breaks down into a lonely "I".
- **Action:** in Exposure, "*nothing happens*"; in Remains something terrible happens in seconds, and he can't undo it.

Remains + Storm on the Island

C

Use for: **Difficult experiences** **Fear** · AQA: Nov 2020 mark scheme ("comparisons between the ways difficult experiences affect groups/societies such as in 'London' or 'Storm on the Island'")

SIMILAR

- Both fear an enemy that cannot be seen or fought. The dead looter is *"dug in behind enemy lines"* inside the soldier's head; the islanders fear *"a huge nothing"*.
- Both use war words. Armitage uses them for a memory that attacks him; Heaney uses them for the weather: *"Space is a salvo,"* and *"We are bombarded by the empty air."*
- Both speakers talk in a chatty, everyday voice about something frightening: *"End of story, except not really."* and *"you know what I mean"*.

DIFFERENT

- **One or many:** Remains is one man's private suffering: *"his bloody life in my bloody hands."* Storm is a whole community ("we") facing it together: *"We just sit tight"*.
- **Guilt or no blame:** the soldier did the killing, so his fear is mixed with guilt. The islanders are victims of nature; nobody is to blame.
- **Real war or metaphor:** Armitage's soldier really did *"open fire"*, and the memory follows him home. Heaney's islanders are not at war; the war is only a metaphor for the storm.

7 In the exam

Compare how poets present the ways people are affected by difficult experiences in 'Remains' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (AQA, November 2020)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Armitage and Duffy show that the worst effects of war are felt later, at home, but Armitage's soldier is haunted by what he did, while Duffy's photographer is haunted by what he saw.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present a difficult experience that returns long after it is over. Armitage's soldier tries to close his story with *"End of story, except not really."*, but the correction shows he cannot. Back home, the dead man *"bursts again through the doors of the bank"*: the verb "bursts" makes the flashback violent and sudden, like PTSD. Duffy's photographer is also back in Britain, yet a face appears as *"a half-formed ghost."* His hands *"did not tremble then"* but *"seem to now"*, so the shock arrives late. However, Armitage's first-person voice makes the guilt personal, ending on *"my bloody hands."* Duffy's third person keeps a distance, and she turns the blame outwards onto readers who *"do not care."*

Why it scores:

- Thesis answers the question: it names the effect (delayed trauma) and the key difference
- Short quotations from both poems, with a word picked out and analysed ("bursts")
- Compares methods (first person against third person) and links to context (PTSD) without bolting it on

The Charge of the Light Brigade

Alfred, Lord Tennyson (1809–1892) · published 9 December 1854

10

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Conflict · AQA mark schemes 2022 and 2025

War · AQA examiners' report 2022

Power · AQA mark schemes 2021 and 2023

Effects of conflict · AQA mark schemes 2017 and 2019

Patriotism and duty · our reading

Loss · our reading

Memory · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Narrative poem in 6 numbered stanzas (55 lines)

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet the printed poem; named in many AQA mark schemes

BEST PARTNER

Remains (your anchor); Bayonet Charge also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

In 1854, about six hundred British cavalrymen are ordered to charge down a valley at Russian guns. The order is a mistake, but they obey. Many die; the poet tells us to honour them.

THE MESSAGE

The soldiers' courage and obedience deserve to be remembered for ever, even though their leaders got it badly wrong.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Tennyson was Poet Laureate. Britannica says the title is given “for poetic excellence”, and laureates from Tennyson on wrote “poems for royal and national occasions”. He wrote this poem “only a few minutes after reading an account in *The Times*”.

Britannica; Poetry Archive

THE TITLE

A **charge** is a fast attack on horseback. The **Light Brigade** was a unit of light cavalry (soldiers on horseback): Britannica lists lancers, hussars and light dragoons. In the poem they fight with “*sabres*” (curved swords). The title names a real event, the charge at Balaklava on 25 October 1854, and names the soldiers as a group, not as individuals. (National Army Museum; Britannica)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

A narrator who was not there tells the story of the charge in the third person (“they”). The six numbered stanzas follow the charge from start to finish, then turn to the reader.

Lines 1–8 (stanza 1)

The horsemen ride on and on: “Half a league onward”. An officer shouts the order to charge the guns. They ride “Into the valley of Death”.

Lines 9–17 (stanza 2)

Was any soldier frightened? No, even though they knew “Some one had blunder’d”: someone had made a terrible mistake. A soldier's job is to obey, not to ask why, and to “do and die”.

Lines 18–26 (stanza 3)

Cannons fire at them from the right, the left and the front. They still ride bravely on, into the “jaws of Death”, the “mouth of Hell”.

Lines 27–38 (stanza 4)

The longest stanza: the fighting. They reach the guns, slash at the gunners with their swords and break through the Russian line. Then they ride back, but “Not the six hundred”: many are missing.

Lines 39–49 (stanza 5)

Riding back, they are fired on from all sides again, now with “Cannon behind them”. Horses and men fall. Only “All that was left of them” return.

Lines 50–55 (stanza 6)

The poet steps out of the story and speaks to us. Their glory will never fade. He orders the reader to “Honour the Light Brigade”.

The turning point (line 37): “Then they rode back, but not / Not the six hundred.” The repeated “not” is the first time the famous number shrinks. From here, the poem counts the cost. **How it ends:** On a command to the reader: “Honour the Light Brigade, / Noble six hundred!” The poem ends as a public memorial, not on the dead. **The tone:** Fast, loud and admiring, like a song of praise. But there is one quiet note of blame: “Some one had blunder’d”.

2 The poem, with what it means

Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. Read it aloud: you will hear the gallop.

THE POEM

Half a league, half a league,

Half a league onward,

All in the valley of Death

Rode the six hundred.

‘Forward, the Light Brigade!

Charge for the guns!’ he said:

Into the valley of Death

Rode the six hundred.

‘Forward, the Light Brigade!’

Was there a man dismay’d?

Not tho’ the soldier knew

Some one had blunder’d:

Theirs not to make reply,

Theirs not to reason why,

Theirs but to do and die:

Into the valley of Death

Rode the six hundred.

Cannon to right of them,

Cannon to left of them,

Cannon in front of them

Volley’d and thunder’d;

Storm’d at with shot and shell,

Boldly they rode and well,

Into the jaws of Death,

Into the mouth of Hell

Rode the six hundred.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

We start in the middle of the action. A league is an old measure of distance. An officer gives the order. **“valley of Death”**: Death has a capital letter, as if it is waiting for them.

“dismay’d” = afraid or upset. The soldiers knew someone had **“blunder’d”** (made a big mistake), but they obeyed. Their job was not to answer back or ask why, only to act, and die.

They are surrounded by guns firing all at once (**“Volley’d”**). Death and Hell are like a monster’s mouth swallowing them. Still they ride **“Boldly”**.

Flash'd all their sabres bare,

Flash'd as they turn'd in air

Sabring the gunners there,

Charging an army, while

All the world wonder'd:

Plunged in the battery-smoke

Right thro' the line they broke;

Cossack and Russian

Reel'd from the sabre-stroke

Shatter'd and sunder'd.

Then they rode back, but not

Not the six hundred.

Cannon to right of them,

Cannon to left of them,

Cannon behind them

Volley'd and thunder'd;

Storm'd at with shot and shell,

While horse and hero fell,

They that had fought so well

Came thro' the jaws of Death

Back from the mouth of Hell,

All that was left of them,

Left of six hundred.

When can their glory fade?

O the wild charge they made!

All the world wonder'd.

Honour the charge they made!

Honour the Light Brigade,

Noble six hundred!

The fight at the guns. Swords ("**sabres**") flash. A few horsemen take on a whole army while the world watches in amazement. The enemy is "**sunder'd**" (split apart). Then they turn back, but far fewer.

Stanza 3 again, in reverse: now the cannon are "**behind them**". Horses and men fall. The survivors come back out of the monster's mouth, but only "All that was left".

The poet speaks straight to us. A question that needs no answer: their glory never can fade. Then commands: "**Honour**" them. Even after the losses, he calls them the "Noble six hundred".

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"Half a league, half a league,"

Means: they keep riding forward, on and on.

Technique: repetition and a galloping rhythm (DUM-da-da), like hooves.

LINES 7–8

"Into the valley of Death / Rode the six hundred."

Means: they ride knowingly towards death. **Why it**

matters: a refrain: it comes back again and again, like a drumbeat. "Death" is personified (treated like a person).

LINE 12

"Some one had blunder'd:"

Means: someone in charge made a terrible mistake. **Why it matters:** the only open criticism.

"Some one" is vague, so no leader is named. Tennyson said the poem was "founded on" this phrase.

LINES 14–15

"Theirs not to reason why, / Theirs but to do and die:"

Means: a soldier's job is to obey, not to think.

Technique: repetition ("Theirs") and rhyme; can be read as praise of duty, or as a quiet protest.

LINES 24–25

"Into the jaws of Death, / Into the mouth of Hell"

Means: the valley is like a monster eating them.

Technique: metaphor; reversed in stanza 5 ("Came thro' the jaws of Death") as they come back out.

LINES 48–49

"All that was left of them, / Left of six hundred."

Means: only part of the brigade survives. **Why it**

matters: the refrain changes: "Rode the six hundred" has become "Left of six hundred". The number tracks the losses.

LINE 53

"Honour the charge they made!"

Means: you, the reader, must remember them.

Technique: imperative (a command) and exclamation; the poem becomes a public memorial.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a story in six numbered stanzas, in a galloping rhythm

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **narrative poem** tells a story. Here the story is told in the **third person** ("they", "the six hundred"), by someone who was not there. AQA's mark schemes contrast this with the first person ("I") in *Remains*. AQA mark schemes 2017 and 2024
- A **dactyl** is a beat of one stressed syllable followed by two unstressed ones: DUM-da-da. Britannica calls dactylic rhythms "fairly rare in English verse". Britannica
- Tennyson himself said: "my poem is dactylic, and founded on the phrase, 'Some one had blundered.'" Tennyson's note, University of Toronto (RPO)
- Poets often drop the last unstressed syllable at the end of a dactylic line. Britannica

one source

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Hear it:** say "*Half a league, half a league*" aloud, leaning on the first word of each half: HALF a league, HALF a league = DUM-da-da, DUM-da-da. Two strong beats a line, like a horse at full gallop. our scansion
- **Numbered stanzas** of uneven length: 8, 9, 9, 12, 11 and 6 lines. The longest (stanza 4) is the fighting; the shortest (stanza 6) is the call to honour them. our count
- **Refrains that change:** "Rode the six hundred" (stanzas 1–3) becomes "Not the six hundred" (stanza 4), then "Left of six hundred" (stanza 5), then "Noble six hundred!" The structure itself counts the dead.
- **Mirroring:** stanza 5 repeats stanza 3, but "Cannon in front of them" becomes "Cannon behind them", and "Into the jaws of Death" becomes "Came thro' the jaws of Death". Going in and coming out are both a trap.
- **Rhyme on one sound:** "blunder'd", "thunder'd", "wonder'd", "sunder'd" all echo "hundred". The mistake, the noise and the dead are tied together by sound. our reading

A sentence you could use: Tennyson tells the story in the third person, so the soldiers are never individuals, only "the six hundred"; and the changing refrain ("Rode", then "Not", then "Left of six hundred") turns the poem's structure into a count of the dead.

Refrain

"*Rode the six hundred*" returns again and again, but changes as men die. The repetition drives the poem forward; the changes show the cost.

Refrain: a line or phrase repeated through a poem, often at the end of each stanza.

Personified Death

"*the valley of Death*" and "*the jaws of Death*" make death a monster with a mouth. The soldiers ride into it knowingly, which makes them seem braver.

Personification: describing a thing or idea as if it were a person or creature.

Repetition and the trap

"Cannon to right of them, / Cannon to left of them," hammers the same word at the start of each line. You feel the guns firing from every side.

Anaphora: repeating the same word or words at the start of lines.

Commands to the reader

The last stanza switches to imperatives:

"Honour the charge they made!" The poem stops telling a story and starts telling us what to feel.

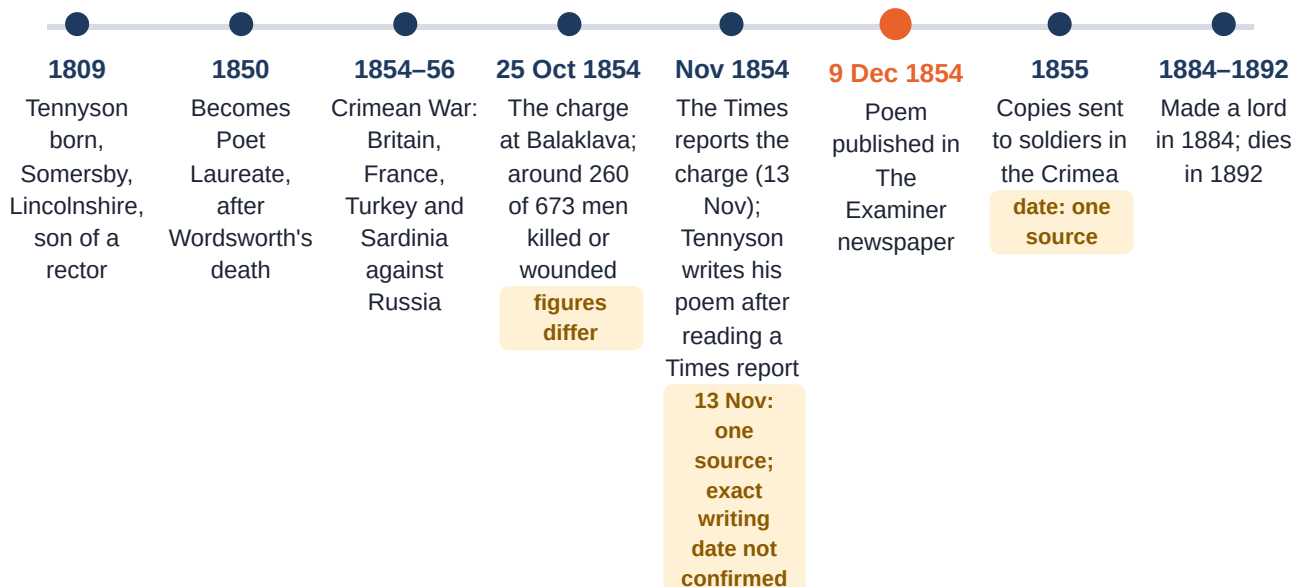
Imperative: a verb that gives an order, like "Honour" or "Look".

Examiners warn: "a mere observation of the techniques or even a vague comment about 'flow' and 'pace' will not achieve above Level 2 AO2 if it is not tied to meaning" (AQA 2022 report). So don't just say that the rhythm sounds like galloping: say what that does to the meaning (the men are carried forward, unable to stop or question).

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO TENNYSON WAS

Born in 1809 in Somersby, Lincolnshire. His father was a rector (a Church of England clergyman). [Britannica](#); [Poetry Archive](#)

Made **Poet Laureate** in 1850, after Wordsworth died, and kept the post until he died in 1892. Britannica says laureates from Tennyson on wrote “poems for royal and national occasions”: this poem is one of them, about a national event. [Poetry Archive](#); [Britannica](#) **patriotism · power**

“one of them”: our reading

Britannica calls him “the chief representative of the Victorian age in poetry”: the poet of Queen Victoria’s Britain. [Britannica](#) **patriotism**

one source

He was made a lord in 1884, which is why he is called “Lord Tennyson”. A recording of him reading this poem, made in 1890 on wax cylinders, survives. [Britannica](#); [Poetry Archive](#)

WHAT REALLY HAPPENED AT BALAKLAVA

The Crimean War (1854–56) was fought by Britain, France, Turkey and Sardinia against Russia. The charge happened at the Battle of Balaklava, 25 October 1854. [National Army Museum](#); [Britannica](#) **war · conflict**

The written order said: “Lord Raglan wishes the cavalry to advance rapidly to the front, follow the enemy & try to prevent the enemy carrying away the guns.” Raglan meant guns the Russians had just captured. [National Army Museum](#); [Britannica](#) **power · duty**

The order was carried by Captain Nolan to Lord Lucan, who told Lord Cardigan to charge. Nolan pointed the wrong way, at the main Russian guns. Cardigan thought the order was absurd but obeyed. Nolan was the first man killed.

[National Army Museum](#); [Britannica](#)

power · “Some one had blunder’d”

Nolan’s gesture: one source

The National Army Museum says around 260 of the 673 men were killed or wounded, and 475 horses were lost. Other sources give different numbers (Britannica: 113 killed, 134 wounded, 45 captured). Tennyson’s “six hundred” is a round number. [National Army Museum](#); [Britannica](#); [Poetry Archive](#) **loss · effects of conflict**

figures differ

The museum says the charge has come to “symbolize both the bravery of the British soldier and the incompetence of the Army commanders”. That is exactly the double message of the poem. [National Army Museum](#)

power · duty

link is our reading

THE FIRST WAR IN THE NEWSPAPERS

The National Army Museum says the Crimean War “was the first campaign to be reported on by a war correspondent”: William Howard Russell of *The Times*. National Army Museum; Britannica **war · effects of conflict**

Russell “sent home shocking accounts of the Army’s shortcomings. The ensuing outcry led to the fall of Lord Aberdeen’s government.” National Army Museum **power** **one source**

Tennyson wrote the poem “only a few minutes after reading an account in *The Times*”. He said the report mentioned “only 607 sabres”: hence “six hundred”. Poetry Archive; Tennyson’s note (RPO, University of Toronto) **patriotism**
link to “six hundred”: our reading

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT, AND WHAT HAPPENED NEXT

It was published in *The Examiner* newspaper on 9 December 1854, about six weeks after the battle, so ordinary readers met it in the news. Tennyson’s note (RPO); University of Victoria

Tennyson said the whole poem was “founded on the phrase, ‘Some one had blundered.’” Tennyson’s note (RPO, University of Toronto)

power · conflict

one source, but the poet’s own words

He cut the “blundered” line when the poem was reprinted in a book in 1855, then put it back. University of Victoria course site

conflict (questioning ideas)

one source

Copies were sent to the soldiers in the Crimea. Tennyson said he did this at Lady Franklin’s request; an army chaplain wrote: “It is the greatest favorite of the soldiers, half are singing it and all want to have it in black and white.”

Tennyson’s note (RPO); University of Victoria

patriotism and duty

the chaplain quote: one source

The museum says “the legend of the ‘gallant 600’ remains deeply rooted in the public mind today”, and that the charge is remembered because of Tennyson’s poem. National Army Museum **memory**

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Tennyson was Poet Laureate in the first war reported by a newspaper correspondent. He wrote within minutes of reading *The Times*, and printed the poem in a newspaper, so it speaks for the nation. It turns a military disaster, caused by a misunderstood order, into a story of glory, but keeps one line of blame: “Some one had blunder’d”.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

The Charge of the Light Brigade + Bayonet Charge

A

Use for: **Patriotism and duty**

Conflict

· AQA: June 2017 mark scheme (war changing attitudes); 2022 examiners' report

SIMILAR

- Both show soldiers charging forward under fire: the six hundred ride *"Into the valley of Death"*; Hughes's soldier is *"Stumbling across a field of clods"*.
- Both are told in the third person, so we watch from outside: "they" and "he".
- Both show ordinary soldiers as small parts of a bigger machine they don't control: *"Theirs not to reason why"* and *"cold clockwork of the stars and the nations"*.

DIFFERENT

- **Patriotism:** Tennyson ends by celebrating honour: *"Honour the Light Brigade,"*. Hughes's soldier throws those ideals away: *"King, honour, human dignity, etcetera"* *"Dropped like luxuries"*.
- **One or many:** AQA's 2022 report praised answers on how Hughes used "an anonymous individual soldier" while Tennyson "focused on the anonymity of the 'six hundred'".
- **Inside the mind:** we never hear a single soldier's thoughts in Tennyson (*"Was there a man dismay'd?"* is answered for them). Hughes takes us inside one man's terror: *"His terror's touchy dynamite."*

The Charge of the Light Brigade + Remains

B

Use for: **Effects of conflict**

Conflict

· AQA: 2017 and 2024 mark schemes ("first person in 'Remains', third person in 'the Charge of the Light Brigade'")

SIMILAR

- Both show soldiers following orders as a group: the six hundred obey *"Charge for the guns!"*; in Remains *"all three of us open fire."*
- Both hint that something went wrong: *"Some one had blunder'd:"*, and the looter was *"probably armed, possibly not."*

DIFFERENT

- **Person:** Tennyson's third person keeps us at a distance and turns the men into heroes. Armitage's first person ("I") puts us inside one soldier's guilt.
- **Ending:** Tennyson ends in public glory: *"When can their glory fade?"* Armitage ends in private guilt that will not fade: *"his bloody life in my bloody hands."*
- **Time:** Tennyson's story ends when the charge ends. Remains is about what happens after: *"End of story, except not really."*

The Charge of the Light Brigade + Exposure

C

Use for: **Patriotism and duty** **Conflict** · AQA: 2017 mark scheme ("the relationship between the individual soldiers and those for whom they fought")

SIMILAR

- Both show soldiers suffering and dying for their country, as a group ("they", "we"), not as named people.
- Both use repeated lines that return like a refrain: "*Rode the six hundred.*" and "*But nothing happens.*"

DIFFERENT

- **Asking why:** Tennyson's soldiers do not question: "*Theirs not to reason why,*". Owen's soldiers do: "*What are we doing here?*"
- **Action vs waiting:** Tennyson's men gallop into a fast, famous battle. Owen's men freeze slowly while "*nothing happens*"; the weather is the enemy.
- **Those at home:** Tennyson tells the people at home to "*Honour the Light Brigade*". Owen's soldiers feel shut out by home: "*on us the doors are closed*".

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present ideas about conflict in 'The Charge of the Light Brigade' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (AQA's 2022 focus, "ideas about conflict")

A strong opening (thesis): Both Tennyson and Hughes show soldiers carried into battle by forces bigger than themselves, but Tennyson celebrates their obedience as glorious, while Hughes shows that ideas like honour collapse in the terror of real fighting.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets present soldiers who are swept into battle by others' decisions. Tennyson admits that "*Some one had blunder'd*", yet insists "*Theirs not to reason why*": the repeated "*Theirs*" makes obedience sound like a noble duty. His third-person narrator turns the men into "*the six hundred*", a heroic group, and ends with the command "*Honour the Light Brigade*". Hughes also uses the third person, but follows one nameless soldier who wonders where he fits in the "*cold clockwork of the stars and the nations*". Where Tennyson's soldiers keep their honour, Hughes's soldier drops "*King, honour, human dignity, etcetera*" as worthless "*luxuries*". Tennyson was Poet Laureate, writing for a proud nation; Hughes rejects that patriotic view of war.

Why it scores:

- The thesis answers the question in one sentence and sets up a clear difference
- Short quotations from both poems, each one explained, with a method named (repetition, third person, command)
- Compares all the way through ("also", "Where...") and links context (Poet Laureate) to meaning

Bayonet Charge

Ted Hughes (1930–1998) · published 1957

11

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

War · AQA June 2017 question (“the effects of war”)

Effects of conflict · AQA June 2017 question; 2020 and 2022 examiners' reports (“inner conflict and PTSD”)

Conflict · AQA June 2022 question (“ideas about conflict”); 2025 mark scheme

Patriotism and duty · AQA June 2022 examiners' report (“patriotic tear”, “Patriotism”)

Nature · AQA mark schemes 2019 and 2025; June 2022 examiners' report

Difficult experiences · AQA Nov 2020 mark scheme

Power · AQA specimen mark scheme (“effects of individual / state power”)

Fear · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Three stanzas (8, 7, 8 lines),
no regular rhyme or metre

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: June 2017 and June
2022

BEST PARTNER

Remains (your anchor);
Exposure also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A soldier suddenly finds himself running across a field towards an enemy hedge, under fire. For a moment he almost stops and wonders why he is there. A wounded hare jolts him, and he charges on in pure terror.

THE MESSAGE

In real battle, big ideas like king, honour and patriotism disappear. All that is left is one frightened man trying to survive.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Hughes's father fought as a frontline soldier in the First World War, and Hughes drew on those experiences for some of his finest war poems. Ted Hughes Society

THE TITLE

A **bayonet** is a blade fixed to the end of a rifle. A **bayonet charge** is an attack where soldiers run at the enemy with these blades fixed, ready to fight hand to hand. The title sounds like a heroic action from a war story. The poem does the opposite: it shows the charge from inside one man's panicking head. The soldier is never named, so he could be any soldier. **our reading** (Britannica

(bayonet); National Army Museum)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

One unnamed soldier ("he") is told about in the third person. The poem starts in the middle of the action: there is no build-up and no explanation of which war or which battle.

Lines 1–2

"Suddenly" he wakes up to find he is already running. He is "raw": inexperienced and hurting. His rough, hot uniform rubs his skin and he is sweating heavily.

Lines 3–5

He stumbles across a ploughed field of lumpy earth ("clods") towards a green hedge. The hedge flashes with enemy rifle fire, and bullets rip through the air around him.

Lines 6–8

He drags his rifle along; it feels as dead and useless as a smashed arm. The "patriotic tear" he once felt for his country has turned into hot, painful sweat pouring from his chest.

Lines 9–11

Confused, he almost stops. He asks himself what huge, cold machine of fate and governments ("the stars and the nations") has put him here, at this exact second.

Lines 11–15

He keeps running, like a man who jumps up in the dark without knowing why. Time seems to freeze: his foot hangs in mid-air like a statue.

Lines 15–18

The bullet-torn furrows throw up a yellow hare. It rolls like a flame and crawls in circles, its mouth open but silent, its eyes bulging. It is dying in agony.

Lines 19–23

He plunges past the hare with his bayonet towards the hedge. King, honour and human dignity are dropped like unneeded luxuries. Only terror drives him now, ready to explode like dynamite.

The turning point (line 9): "*he almost stopped –*" The rush of stanza 1 halts. For a few lines the soldier thinks instead of acts, and time seems to stand still. Then the hare breaks the spell and the charge starts again. **How it ends:** not with a victory or a death, but with the soldier still charging, driven only by "*His terror's touchy dynamite.*" We never find out what happens to him. **The tone:** urgent, confused and frightened. There is no glory and no cheering. The only patriotic feeling in the poem is a tear that turns to sweat.

2 The poem, section by section

This poem is still in copyright, so only short key phrases are shown here. Read the full poem in your anthology alongside this guide. Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1-2

Suddenly he awoke and was running ... raw-seamed hot khaki,

LINES 3-5

Stumbling across a field of clods ... Bullets smacking the belly out of the air

LINES 6-8

He lugged a rifle numb as a smashed arm; ... Sweating like molten iron

LINES 9-11

he almost stopped – ... cold clockwork of the stars and the nations

LINES 11-15

Listening between his footfalls for the reason ... his foot hung like / Statuary in mid-stride.

LINES 15-18

shot-slashed furrows ... a yellow hare that rolled like a flame

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

We are dropped straight into the action (in media res: “in the middle of things”). He “awoke”: perhaps he was asleep, or perhaps he has only now woken up to what war really is. “Raw” is repeated: he is new and unready, and his thick uniform is rubbing his skin raw.

He stumbles over lumps of ploughed earth towards a green hedge, which flashes with rifle fire. The bullets hit the air so hard it is as if they punch the stomach (“belly”) out of it, as if the air itself is being hurt.

He “lugged” (dragged heavily) his rifle. The simile makes the rifle feel like a dead part of his own body. The “patriotic tear” he had felt for his country has become sweat “like molten iron” from his chest: the heart, where patriotism is supposed to live.

In confusion he nearly stops. He wonders what huge machine has put him here. “Clockwork” makes him a tiny moving part, like a clock hand pointing at one second. Fate (“the stars”) and governments (“the nations”) control him.

He runs like someone who has jumped up in the dark, trying to hear a reason for running. Then time freezes: his foot hangs in the air like a statue (“statuary”). The poem slows right down, just as his mind does.

Furrows are lines ploughed in a field for crops; here they are “shot-slashed”, torn up by bullets. A hare is thrown up, rolling “like a flame”, crawling in circles with its mouth open in a silent scream. An innocent animal suffers because of the war.

LINES 19–23

King, honour, human dignity, etcetera ... His terror's touchy dynamite.

He plunges on with his bayonet. The big ideas he fought for are “Dropped like luxuries”: things you can live without. “Etcetera” dismisses them. The poem ends on terror, which is “touchy dynamite”: unstable and ready to explode.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

“Suddenly he awoke and was running – raw”

Means: he is in the battle before he knows it, and he is new and unprotected. **Why it matters:** AQA's 2022 report says “in media res” and “suddenly” were “productive avenues” for students. “Raw” suggests he is inexperienced, and raw like an open wound. **Technique:** in media res opening; adverb; repetition of “raw”

LINE 6

“He lugged a rifle numb as a smashed arm;”

Means: his rifle feels heavy, lifeless and part of his injured body. **Why it matters:** AQA's 2022 report praised readings where the rifle is “so much a part of him that it had replaced his arm”: the man is becoming a weapon. **Technique:** simile; violent adjective “smashed”

LINE 7

“The patriotic tear that had brimmed in his eye”

Means: the love of his country that once moved him to tears. **Why it matters:** it is in the past tense (“had brimmed”): his patriotism belongs to before the battle. In line 8 it becomes painful sweat “from the centre of his chest”. **Technique:** metaphor; past perfect tense

LINE 10

“In what cold clockwork of the stars and the nations”

Means: what huge, uncaring machine of fate and governments has put him here? **Why it matters:** he is a tiny, powerless part of a vast system. AQA's 2022 report says strong answers saw him “becoming a robotic, unthinking weapon of war”. **Technique:** metaphor; alliteration (hard “c” sounds); rhetorical question

LINE 16

“Threw up a yellow hare that rolled like a flame”

Means: a hare is thrown out of the torn field, writhing in pain. **Why it matters:** the hare suffers as he does: war hurts nature and the innocent too. Its silent, wide-open mouth may mirror his own terror. **Technique:** simile; symbolism; colour imagery

LINE 20

“King, honour, human dignity, etcetera”

Means: the noble reasons for fighting. **Why it matters:** the list ends on “etcetera”, as if the ideals are not worth finishing. In line 21 they are dropped “like luxuries”: in battle, they are useless. **Technique:** list; bathos (a grand list that ends on something flat)

LINE 23

"His terror's touchy dynamite."

Means: his fear is unstable and ready to explode.

Why it matters: the poem ends on terror, not glory. He is no longer a person with beliefs, but a bundle of fear that could go off at any moment.

Technique: metaphor; alliteration; short final line

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: one moment, three stanzas, no regular pattern

ABOUT THE FORM

- **Third person:** the poem is told about "he", not by "I". One AQA mark scheme (2020) calls it "first person"; that is a slip. Check the text: it is always "he". *AQA anthology (our check)*
- **Narrative:** it tells a story, but only a few seconds of one. It starts in the middle of the action (in media res) and ends before we know what happens to him.
- **No regular rhyme or metre:** the lines are different lengths and there is no fixed rhyme scheme. AQA's 2022 report warns that pointing out a rhyme scheme "is best avoided". *AQA 2022 examiners' report*

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Fast, slow, fast:** stanza 1 (lines 1–8) is one long rush of action, linked by dashes and run-on lines. Stanza 2 (lines 9–15) slows down as he thinks: *"he almost stopped –"*. Stanza 3 (lines 16–23) snaps back into action with the hare. The shape of the poem follows the shape of the charge. *our reading*
- **Time freezes in the middle:** stanza 2 ends with his foot hanging *"like / Statuary in mid-stride."* The line break leaves his foot hanging in the air too.
- **No hero, no name:** using "he" and never a name makes him an everyman: an ordinary man who could be anyone. AQA's 2022 report praised answers comparing Hughes's "anonymous individual soldier" with Tennyson's "six hundred". *AQA 2022 examiners' report*
- **Why it matters:** examiners want structure tied to meaning. Don't just say there is enjambment; say what it shows (his panic, his loss of control).

A sentence you could use: Hughes opens in media res with "Suddenly", so the reader, like the soldier, is thrown into the charge without warning; the slower middle stanza, where he "almost stopped", shows thought briefly breaking through before terror takes over again.

Starting in the middle

The first word, “*Suddenly*”, throws us into the charge with no build-up. We are as confused as the soldier. AQA's 2022 report says the vast majority of students began with “in media res” and “suddenly”, and these were productive for at least Level 3 AO2.

In media res: Latin for “in the middle of things”: a story that starts partway through the action.

Man and machine

His rifle is “*numb as a smashed arm*”, and he is one hand on a “*cold clockwork*” clock of the stars and the nations. The soldier is becoming a part in a war machine, with no control over where it points him.

Dehumanisation: showing a person as less than human, for example as a tool, machine or animal.

Nature under attack

Bullets smack “*the belly out of the air*”, the furrows are “*shot-slashed*” and the hare dies in a “*threshing circle*”. A field meant for growing food is wrecked. AQA's 2022 report says strong answers saw the difference between ploughed furrows and fields “savaged by the bullets”.

Personification: giving human qualities to something that isn't human (the air has a “belly”).

Ideals dropped

The “*patriotic tear*” of the past turns into sweat, and “*King, honour, human dignity, etcetera*” are “*Dropped like luxuries*”. The word “etcetera” mocks the big words that send men to war.

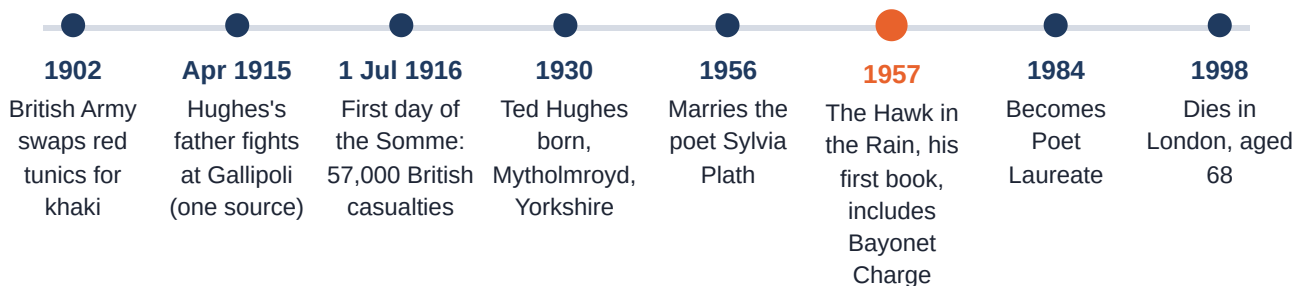
Bathos: a sudden drop from something grand to something ordinary or silly, often for effect.

Examiners warn: in 2022 AQA's report said “a mere observation of the techniques or even a vague comment about ‘flow’ and ‘pace’ will not achieve above Level 2 AO2 if it is not tied to meaning.” It also said paragraphs about “Hughes’ father as a soldier” were “not useful if they meant the student lost sight of the poem.” Keep context to a sentence, tied to the poem.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO HUGHES WAS

Born on 17 August 1930 in Mytholmroyd, West Yorkshire. Aged seven he moved to Mexborough, where his father ran a shop.

Britannica; Ted Hughes Society

He did national service in the RAF, as a radio mechanic in Yorkshire, then went to Pembroke College, Cambridge. He did not fight in a war himself, so he imagines the charge. Britannica;

Ted Hughes Society

war · effects of conflict

our reading (last sentence)

Britannica says his most typical poetry is “without sentimentality, emphasizing the cunning and savagery of animal life in harsh, sometimes disjunctive lines.” That fits the hare and the jerky, broken lines here. Britannica

nature · conflict

one source

He was Poet Laureate from 1984 until his death in 1998. Britannica; Ted Hughes Society

HOW THE POEM CAME ABOUT

Bayonet Charge appeared in *The Hawk in the Rain* (Faber, 1957), Hughes's first book of poems. Ted Hughes Society (Heather Clark); Britannica (book and date)

one source names the book

The Ted Hughes Society says several poems in that book show his “ongoing obsession with the First World War, in which his own father had fought.” It says Bayonet Charge speaks “to man's violent nature”. Ted Hughes Society

war · conflict

one source

Hughes “drew upon his father's experiences as a frontline soldier during the First World War to inform some of his finest war-verse”. Ted Hughes Society

effects of conflict

one source (INFLIBNET confirms his father served)

One university text says his father fought at Gallipoli in April 1915, was one of seventeen survivors in his battalion, was seriously wounded, and told the family stories of the fighting. INFLIBNET (university e-text)

effects of conflict

one source

So the poem was written about 40 years after the First World War, by a man who heard about it at home. Use this in one sentence only: AQA warns against long paragraphs on Hughes's father. dates above; AQA 2022 examiners' report

our reading

CHARGING INTO GUNFIRE

A bayonet is a “short, sharp-edged, sometimes pointed weapon, designed for attachment to the muzzle of a firearm”. On the British rifle it gave “a one-metre reach in hand-to-hand combat.”

Britannica; National Army Museum **war**

Britannica: “The development of repeating firearms greatly reduced the combat value of the bayonet.” A charge with blades against modern rifle fire is close, desperate and old-fashioned fighting. Britannica **war · power**

our reading (second sentence)

“Rifles were by far the most commonly used weapon of the war.” A fixed bayonet “could prove unwieldy” (awkward) in a trench, which fits the soldier who “lugged” his rifle. National

Army Museum **war** **one source**

On the first day of the Somme, 1 July 1916, the British Army had “57,000 casualties, the bloodiest day in its history.” The infantry “were met by a storm of machine-gun, rifle and artillery fire.” Most were “inexperienced volunteers”, like the “raw” soldier. The poem does not name the Somme, so use this only as background. National Army Museum

war · effects of conflict

link to the poem: our reading

The army switched to khaki in 1902. The uniform was “thick wool, effective in the cold winter but stifling in the summer – not to mention itchy!” That explains “*raw-seamed hot khaki*”. National Army Museum **war** **one source**

READING THE POEM CAREFULLY

The poem never names the war. It is usually read as the First World War: the Ted Hughes Society groups it with his poems about that war, and “*King*” fits a British soldier. But khaki, rifles and bayonets were used in other wars too, so present this as a reading. Ted Hughes Society; AQA anthology (our check) **war** **our reading**

It is in the third person (“he”). One AQA mark scheme (Nov 2020) calls it “first person”; that is a slip. Don't copy it. AQA Nov 2020 mark scheme; AQA anthology

AQA's 2022 report: “Patriotism, violence, death, inner conflict and PTSD amongst others were appropriate considerations for AO3”. AQA 2022 examiners' report

patriotism · conflict · effects of conflict

AQA's 2017 mark scheme suggests AO3 points on “the realisation of the horror / reality of war” and “the relationship between the individual soldiers and those for whom they fought”. AQA June 2017 mark scheme **war · patriotism and duty**

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Hughes, writing in 1957, grew up hearing about his father's First World War service, and the poem strips away the patriotic ideas that sent young men to war. By the end, “*King, honour, human dignity, etcetera*” are dropped, showing the reality of war is terror, not glory.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Bayonet Charge + Exposure

A

Use for: **Conflict** **Nature** **Effects of conflict** · AQA: 2017, 2024 and 2025 mark schemes; June 2022 report ("worked well")

SIMILAR

- Both show soldiers under fire in a hostile natural world: *"Bullets smacking the belly out of the air"* and *"Sudden successive flights of bullets streak the silence."*
- Both soldiers question why they are there: *"Was he the hand pointing that second?"* and *"What are we doing here?"*
- Both doubt the big ideas behind the war: *"King, honour, human dignity, etcetera"* and *"For love of God seems dying."*

DIFFERENT

- Action or waiting:** Hughes's soldier is charging in a few frantic seconds (*"He was running"*). Owen's men wait for days and the refrain is *"But nothing happens."*
- One or many:** Hughes follows one unnamed "he". Owen speaks for a group ("we"): *"Wearied we keep awake"*.
- Nature's role:** in Exposure nature is the enemy that kills. In Bayonet Charge nature is a victim: the *"shot-slashed furrows"* and the dying hare. AQA's 2022 report said students were "less confident" with this side of the link, so make it carefully.

Bayonet Charge + The Charge of the Light Brigade

B

Use for: **Patriotism and duty** **Conflict** **War** · AQA: June 2017 mark scheme; June 2022 report (Hughes's "anonymous individual soldier" vs Tennyson's "six hundred")

SIMILAR

- Both show soldiers charging straight into gunfire: *"dazzled with rifle fire"* and *"Storm'd at with shot and shell,"*
- Both show men as parts of a larger machine they don't control: *"cold clockwork of the stars and the nations"* and *"Theirs not to reason why,"*

DIFFERENT

- Honour:** Tennyson ends *"Honour the Light Brigade,"*. Hughes drops honour *"like luxuries"*.
- One or many:** Tennyson celebrates the group, the *"Noble six hundred!"*. Hughes zooms in on one frightened, unnamed man.
- Thinking:** Tennyson's soldiers do not question orders. Hughes's soldier *"almost stopped"* to ask why he is there.
- Sound:** Tennyson's strong, regular rhythm sounds like galloping horses. Hughes's broken, uneven lines sound like stumbling.

Bayonet Charge + Remains

C

Use for: **Effects of conflict** **Conflict** **Difficult experiences** · AQA: 2017, 2022 and 2025 mark schemes ("first-hand experience of conflict on the individual, such as 'Bayonet Charge', or 'Remains'")

SIMILAR

- Both focus on one soldier and a sudden, violent moment: *"Suddenly he awoke and was running"* and *"all three of us open fire."*
- Both show the body torn by bullets with shocking images: the hare *"rolled like a flame"*; the looter is *"sort of inside out,"*

DIFFERENT

- **During or after:** Bayonet Charge is a few seconds of battle. Remains is mostly about afterwards: the memory stays, *"End of story, except not really."*
- **Person:** Hughes uses third person ("he"), which keeps some distance. Armitage uses first person, in a soldier's chatty voice: *"I see every round as it rips through his life"*.
- **Fear or guilt:** Hughes's soldier feels terror for himself. Armitage's soldier feels guilt for the man he killed: *"his bloody life in my bloody hands."*

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present the effects of war in 'Bayonet Charge' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (AQA's exact wording in June 2017.)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Hughes and Tennyson show soldiers charging into gunfire, but Tennyson presents war as a glorious group sacrifice, while Hughes shows its real effect on one man: terror that strips away every patriotic ideal.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets show soldiers who cannot control their fate. Tennyson's cavalry accept it: *"Theirs not to reason why,"*, and the repeated *"six hundred"* turns them into one heroic group. Hughes, by contrast, follows one unnamed soldier, who *"almost stopped"* to ask why he is in the *"cold clockwork of the stars and the nations"*. The metaphor makes him a tiny, powerless part of a machine run by governments. The effect of war is to empty him of ideals: *"King, honour, human dignity, etcetera"* are dropped, and "etcetera" mocks them. Tennyson ends by commanding us to *"Honour the Light Brigade,"*; Hughes ends with *"His terror's touchy dynamite."* For Tennyson, war creates heroes; for Hughes, it reduces a man to fear.

Why it scores:

- The thesis answers "effects of war" directly and sets up a clear difference in one sentence
- Short quotations from both poems, each with a method (repetition, metaphor, the dismissive "etcetera", endings)
- Uses AQA's own 2022 point: Hughes's anonymous soldier against Tennyson's "six hundred", and compares the two endings

War Photographer

Carol Ann Duffy (born 1955) · published 1985 (in *Standing Female Nude*)

12

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

War · AQA question June 2019

Effects of conflict · AQA question June 2019; mark schemes 2017 and 2024

Difficult experiences · AQA mark scheme and examiners' report November 2020

Conflict · AQA mark schemes 2022 and 2025

Memory · our reading

Guilt · our reading

Place and home · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Third-person poem: 4 six-line stanzas, each ending in a rhyming couplet (24 lines)

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: June 2019

BEST PARTNER

Remains

THE STORY IN SHORT

A war photographer is back in England, developing his films alone in his darkroom. As a dead man's face appears on the paper, the memories come back.

THE MESSAGE

War photographers carry other people's suffering home with them. The comfortable public glances at the pictures, feels sad for a moment, and forgets.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Duffy was friends with real war photographers. WJEC names Don McCullin and Philip Jones Griffiths; McCullin spent years shooting wars for a Sunday newspaper's magazine. WJEC; Oak National Academy; Tate Britain

THE TITLE

The title names a job, not a person. He is never given a name, only “*he*” and “*his*”. WJEC says this “creates a distancing effect”. It also makes him stand for every war photographer, not just one man. **the last point is our reading** (WJEC; our reading)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

The poem is told in the third person: a narrator describes the photographer from outside. We are with him in his darkroom in England, where he develops (prints) the photos he took in war zones. Memories of the wars break into the quiet room.

Lines 1–5

He is “*finally alone*” in his darkroom. His films are laid out in neat rows. The only light is red, so the room feels like a church and he is like a priest about to say Mass, a service for the dead.

Line 6

A list of war zones he has worked in: “*Belfast. Beirut. Phnom Penh.*” Then a line from the Bible: “*All flesh is grass.*” All human life is short and easily destroyed.

Lines 7–12

He gets on with the job. Chemicals slop in trays. His hands shake now, though they were steady at the scene. In “*Rural England*” pain is ordinary and good weather can cure it. Here the fields don't explode under children's feet.

Lines 13–18

A photo starts to develop. A stranger's face slowly appears, like “*a half-formed ghost.*” He remembers the man's wife crying, and how he silently sought approval (perhaps from her) to take the picture, and how the man's blood soaked into the dust.

Lines 19–22

He has “*A hundred agonies*” on film, but his editor will choose only five or six for the Sunday paper's magazine. Readers will tear up for a moment, between their bath and a beer before lunch.

Lines 23–24

On a plane, he looks down without showing any feeling at the place where he earns his living. The poem ends: “*they do not care.*”

The turning point (line 13): “*Something is happening.*” The calm routine stops as a face appears in the developing tray. The photo coming to life is also the memory coming back.

How it ends: On indifference. The cold word “*impassively*” and the flat last line, “*they do not care.*”, leave us with readers who don't care, and a man who has had to stop showing that he does. **The tone:** Quiet, solemn and controlled at the start, like a church service. Haunted in the middle. Bitter and sarcastic about the comfortable readers at the end.

2 The poem, section by section

This poem is still in copyright, so we only show the key phrases here. Read the full poem in your anthology alongside these notes. Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright,

so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key words to quote.

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1-3

finally alone ... spools of suffering set out in ordered rows.

LINES 3-5

as though this were a church ... a priest preparing to intone a Mass.

LINES 6

Belfast. Beirut. Phnom Penh. All flesh is grass.

LINES 7-9

He has a job to do. ... which did not tremble then ... though seem to now.

LINES 9-12

Rural England. ... ordinary pain which simple weather can dispel ... running children in a nightmare heat.

LINES 13-15

Something is happening. ... a half-formed ghost.

LINES 15-18

He remembers the cries ... the blood stained into foreign dust.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

He is alone at last, after the crowds and noise of war. His rolls of film ("**spools**") are full of other people's pain. The neat "**ordered rows**" could make us think of rows of war graves.

The red safelight makes the darkroom feel like a church. He is like a priest about to chant ("**intone**") a Mass, a church service. His work is serious, almost holy: he is honouring the dead.

Three real cities hit by war. The full stops make it sound like a roll-call. "**All flesh is grass**" comes from the Bible (Isaiah 40:6): people are like grass, which soon withers and dies.

A short, blunt sentence: he tells himself to get on with it. His hands were steady while he was taking the pictures, but they seem to shake now. The shock has caught up with him at home.

In the English countryside, troubles are small enough for a sunny day to chase away ("**dispel**"). Fields here don't blow up under children's feet, as they do in the war zones he has seen.

As the picture develops, a stranger's face slowly appears and seems to twist. He is only half there on the paper, like a ghost. We realise the man in the photo is dead.

He remembers the man's wife screaming. Without words, he asked for approval (perhaps from her) to take the picture, because someone has to record it. The man's blood soaked into the ground of a foreign country.

LINES 19–21

A hundred agonies in black-and-white ... five or six ... Sunday's supplement.

Each photo is an “**agony**”: real pain. Out of a hundred, the editor will print five or six in the Sunday newspaper's magazine (the “**supplement**”). Most of the suffering will never be seen.

LINES 21–22

The reader's eyeballs prick ... between the bath and pre-lunch beers.

Readers' eyes sting with tears, but only for a moment, squeezed in between a bath and a drink. The rhyme makes their sympathy sound shallow.

LINES 23–24

he stares impassively ... they do not care.

From a plane he looks down without showing feeling (“**impassively**”) at where he earns his living. “**they**” could mean the readers, or the world in general. The poem ends on not caring.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 2

“spools of suffering set out in ordered rows.”

Means: his rolls of film are full of other people's pain, laid out neatly. **Technique:** sibilance (repeated “s” sounds) makes it hushed; “ordered rows” may suggest rows of graves.

LINE 5

“a priest preparing to intone a Mass.”

Means: he treats developing his photos like a holy service for the dead. **Why it matters:** religious imagery: his job is a duty to the dead, not just work. WJEC notes a priest and a war photographer both “witness death, pain and suffering”.

LINE 6

“Belfast. Beirut. Phnom Penh. All flesh is grass.”

Means: war is everywhere, and human life is short and fragile. **Technique:** caesura (full stops breaking up the line) like a roll-call; a Bible quotation from Isaiah 40:6.

LINES 8–9

“which did not tremble then / though seem to now.”

Means: his hands were steady at the scene but shake now he is home. **Why it matters:** the shock is delayed: being back in safety lets the trauma catch up with him.

LINE 15

“a half-formed ghost.”

Means: the dead man's face is only half developed on the photo paper. **Technique:** metaphor: the photo is a ghost, and so is the memory that haunts him.

LINE 19

“A hundred agonies in black-and-white”

Means: each photo shows someone's real pain. **Why it matters:** Duffy calls the photos “agonies”, not pictures, so we can't forget they are people. Only “five or six” will be printed.

LINES 21-22

*“eyeballs prick / with tears between the bath
and pre-lunch beers.”*

Means: readers feel sad for a moment, then get back to their comfortable Sunday. **Technique:** bathos (a sudden drop from serious to trivial) and the rhyme “tears ... beers” mock their shallow sympathy.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a tightly ordered poem about chaos

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **stanza** is a group of lines, like a paragraph in a poem. A **rhyming couplet** is two lines in a row that rhyme.
- **Third person** means the poem is told by a narrator about "he", not by the man himself ("I"). It lets us watch him from outside.
- A strict, regular shape can hold in feelings that might get out of control, so the form itself can show a struggle for control. **our reading**

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Four stanzas of six lines** (24 lines). WJEC says this suggests "regularity and the routine nature of his job." **our count**; WJEC
- **Every stanza ends in a rhyming couplet:** "Mass ... grass", "feet ... heat", "must ... dust", "where ... care". Each stanza clicks shut, like a neat, finished print. **our count**
- WJEC: "The strict, controlled structure contrasts the chaos, confusion and lack of structure in war." Just as he puts his films in "ordered rows", the poem puts horror into neat stanzas. WJEC
- **Third person:** WJEC says it reflects "the detachment a war photographer must feel when doing the job." We watch him the way he watches the people he photographs. WJEC
- **Small cracks:** some rhymes are only half-rhymes ("then" / "again", "six" / "prick"), and sentences run on across line ends. The control is not quite perfect, like his hands that "seem to" tremble. **our reading**
- **Each stanza is a stage:** the darkroom, home vs. war, the photo developing, the newspaper and the plane. WJEC: "Each stanza focuses on a different aspect of the war photographer's job." WJEC

A sentence you could use: Duffy orders the poem into four six-line stanzas, each closed by a rhyming couplet, so the form mirrors the photographer's controlled routine of "ordered rows"; yet half-rhymes and hands that "seem to" tremble show the horror he has witnessed pressing against that control.

Religious imagery

The darkroom is “a church”, he is “a priest”, and the Bible’s “All flesh is grass” follows. It makes his work a solemn duty: a funeral rite for people the world will forget. WJEC calls it a “semantic field of religion”.

Semantic field: a group of words linked to the same topic (here: church, priest, Mass).

Contrast: England against the war zones

In “Rural England”, pain is “ordinary” and weather can fix it. Elsewhere, fields “explode beneath the feet / of running children”. The contrast shows how safe, and how unaware, people at home are.

Juxtaposition: putting two very different things side by side to make the difference stand out.

The photo develops like a memory

“Something is happening.” As the face appears in the tray, the memory of the dying man appears in his mind. The present tense makes it happen in front of us, so we relive it with him.

Extended metaphor: a comparison that is carried on over several lines (here: developing a photo = remembering).

Bathos and satire

The readers' tears come “between the bath and pre-lunch beers.” The drop from tears to beer makes their sympathy look tiny. Duffy is mocking the comfortable reader, which might be us.

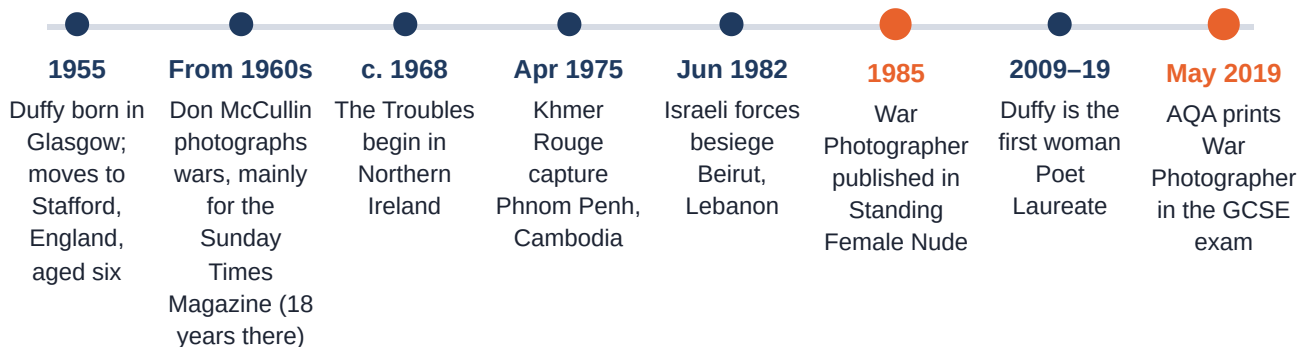
Bathos: a sudden drop from something serious to something trivial, often to mock.

Examiners warn: AQA's November 2020 report said formula-driven paragraphs “tended to encourage bolted-on context rather than focusing on ideas.” Mention Duffy's photographer friends in a sentence, then use it to explain an idea in the poem, such as bearing witness.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO DUFFY IS

Born in Glasgow in 1955. Her family moved to Stafford, England, when she was six. She studied philosophy at Liverpool University.

Britannica; poets.org

From 2009 to 2019 she was the first woman Poet Laureate, the poet chosen to write for the nation. Simon Armitage, who wrote *Remains*, took over from her. Britannica; poets.org; WJEC

comparison link with *Remains*

Her early poems are known for “Dramatic characters and narratives, voiced with a sharp edge of wit and social critique”. *War Photographer* criticises comfortable readers in just this way. poets.org

effects of conflict · power

one source; the link to this poem is our reading

War Photographer comes from her 1985 collection *Standing Female Nude*. Britannica; WJEC; Scottish Poetry Library

THE REAL WAR PHOTOGRAPHERS BEHIND THE POEM

WJEC says Duffy was inspired by “her friendships with the war photographers Don McCullin and Phillip Jones Griffiths”. Oak National Academy says the photographer “may be based on Duffy's friend, Don McCullin”. WJEC fact sheet; Oak National Academy lesson

bearing witness · effects of conflict

Jones Griffiths: one source

Tate Britain calls McCullin “probably the UK's foremost war photographer”, working mainly for the *Sunday Times Magazine*. His photos include Northern Ireland, and Tate Liverpool's exhibition guide covers his work in Beirut and Cambodia too: the three places in line 6. Tate Britain; Tate Liverpool

war

the link to line 6 is our reading

His exhibition prints: Tate Britain says they were “all printed by McCullin himself in his own darkroom”, just like the man in the poem. Tate Britain

memory

one source

McCullin, on photographing dying children in Biafra in 1969: “It was a gut-wrenching, guilt-ridden experience to put that camera to my eye.” Compare the silent asking for “approval”. Tate Etc. (Tate's magazine), issue 45, 2019: interview by Simon Grant

guilt · difficult experiences

one source

Philip Jones Griffiths was a Welsh photographer (1936–2008) famous for his book *Vietnam Inc.* about the Vietnam War. Dictionary of Welsh Biography

background only

BELFAST. BEIRUT. PHNOM PENH.

Belfast: the Troubles, a violent conflict in Northern Ireland from about 1968 to 1998 in which about 3,600 people were killed. This war was inside the UK itself, not far from “*Rural England*”. Britannica; WJEC **war · place and home**
the point about the UK is our reading

Beirut: capital of Lebanon. Its civil war (1975–90) killed more than 100,000 people. In June 1982 Israeli forces besieged the city. Britannica; WJEC **war · conflict**

Phnom Penh: capital of Cambodia. The Khmer Rouge took it in April 1975. Under their rule (1975–79), an estimated 1.5 to 3 million Cambodians died. Britannica; WJEC **effects of conflict**
death tolls vary between sources

All three were recent or still going on when the poem came out in 1985. “*All flesh is grass*” (Isaiah 40:6) then turns the list into a lament: so many lives cut down like grass. Britannica; BibleGateway; Project Gutenberg **war · loss**
the reading of the line is ours

SUNDAY PAPERS AND READERS WHO DON'T CARE

Newspapers like the *Sunday Times* came with a magazine, the “*supplement*”. McCullin worked for the *Sunday Times Magazine* for eighteen years. Tate Liverpool exhibition guide **power · effects of conflict**

McCullin said he wanted to “make life uncomfortable on a Sunday morning” for readers. Duffy's readers are only uncomfortable for a moment, “*between the bath and pre-lunch beers.*” Tate Etc. (Tate's magazine), issue 45, 2019: interview by Simon Grant **effects of conflict · indifference** **one source**

WJEC: war photographers “risk their lives to take photographs of armed conflicts and their consequences, so people at home can be made aware of these situations.” WJEC **bearing witness** **one source**

Oak National Academy reads the poem as one that “seems to criticise our increasing indifference to the victims of conflict.” Oak National Academy lesson **effects of conflict**
one source

AQA's 2019 mark scheme suggests “ideas about bearing witness” and “the impact/influence of experiences on the individual/collective conscience”. AQA mark scheme June 2019 **all war questions**

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Duffy knew war photographers such as Don McCullin, who worked for years for a Sunday newspaper's magazine and wanted to make readers' Sunday mornings “uncomfortable”. The poem shows the cost of bearing witness: the photographer carries the dead of Belfast, Beirut and Phnom Penh home with him, while readers forget them “between the bath and pre-lunch beers.”

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

War Photographer + Remains

A

Use for: **Effects of conflict** **Difficult experiences** **Memory** · AQA: June 2019 mark scheme ("a different perspective, such as ... 'Remains'"); Nov 2020 examiners' report

SIMILAR

- Both men are safe in Britain but haunted by one dead stranger: *"a half-formed ghost."* and *"he's here in my head when I close my eyes"*.
- Both leave a stain of blood behind: *"the blood stained into foreign dust."* and *"His blood-shadow stays on the street"*.
- Both show delayed shock at home: hands that *"did not tremble then"* and *"Then I'm home on leave. But I blink"*.

DIFFERENT

- **Watching or doing:** the photographer only recorded the death; the soldier fired the shots: *"all three of us open fire."*
- **Voice:** Duffy's third person is calm and distant; Armitage's first person is raw and immediate. AQA's 2022 mark scheme contrasts the "immediacy" of Remains with the "more reflective stance of 'War Photographer'".
- **Who is blamed:** Duffy turns outwards to readers who *"do not care."* Armitage turns inwards: *"my bloody hands."*

War Photographer + Poppies

B

Use for: **Effects of conflict** **Memory** **Place and home** · AQA: June 2019 mark scheme ("people indirectly affected by war, such as in 'Poppies'"); 2022 and 2024 mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both are about people who never fight but are still marked by war, at home in Britain: the photographer in *"Rural England"*; the mother at her *"front door"*.
- Both use religious places and remembrance: *"as though this were a church"* and *"skirting the church yard walls"* to *"the war memorial"*.
- Both are reflective and quiet, not action-packed. AQA's 2022 mark scheme groups them for their "more reflective stance".

DIFFERENT

- **Feeling:** Weir's mother is full of private love and grief: *"steeled the softening / of my face."* Duffy's photographer has to hide feeling: *"impassively"*.
- **Public or private:** Duffy attacks the public who *"do not care."* Weir stays inside one family's loss.
- **Language:** Duffy's images are brutal, *"A hundred agonies"*; Weir's are soft and domestic, from sewing: *"tucks, darts, pleats"*.

War Photographer + Bayonet Charge

C

Use for: **War** **Effects of conflict** **Conflict** · AQA: June 2019 mark scheme ("a different perspective, such as 'Bayonet Charge'")

SIMILAR

- Both use third person ("he") for an unnamed man, so he stands for many.
- Both question the big ideas behind war: "All flesh is grass." and "King, honour, human dignity, etcetera".
- Both show suffering in a field: "fields which don't explode beneath the feet" in England, against "the shot-slashed furrows" of battle.

DIFFERENT

- **When:** Hughes puts us in the middle of the charge: "Suddenly he awoke and was running". Duffy looks back afterwards, in a quiet darkroom.
- **Who:** a soldier fighting for his life, against a civilian who records others' deaths.
- **Form:** Hughes's lines are rough and breathless, full of dashes; Duffy's stanzas are neat and controlled, each closing on a rhyming couplet.

7 In the exam

Compare how poets present the ways that people are affected by war in 'War Photographer' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (AQA, June 2019)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Duffy and Hughes show that war changes how people see the ideals and comforts they once trusted, but Hughes's soldier is shattered in a moment of terror, while Duffy's photographer is worn down slowly by what he has seen.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets show war stripping away comforting beliefs. Hughes's soldier drops "King, honour, human dignity, etcetera": the dismissive "etcetera" shows patriotic ideals becoming meaningless under fire. Duffy's photographer remembers "Belfast. Beirut. Phnom Penh.", and the Bible phrase "All flesh is grass." reduces all those lives to something that withers. However, Hughes presents the effect as instant and physical, as he "awoke and was running" in the middle of battle. Duffy shows a slower effect: hands that "did not tremble then" now shake at home. Her third-person narrator and neat couplets suggest a man forcing control on chaos. Unlike Hughes, Duffy also shows war affecting the comfortable public, who feel nothing much beyond a brief "prick" of tears.

Why it scores:

- Thesis answers the question in one sentence and sets up the key difference (instant shock against slow damage)
- Short quotations from both poems, with single words analysed ("etcetera", "grass")
- Compares methods (form, third person, Bible echo) and links to the question's focus all the way through, without bolting on context

Poppies

Jane Weir (born 1963) · published 2009 (Guardian “Exit Wounds” war poems)

13

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Effects of conflict · AQA mark schemes 2017, 2019, 2024 (2024: “the effects of conflict on those not immediately involved”)

Difficult experiences · AQA mark scheme November 2020

Conflict · AQA mark scheme 2025

Nature · AQA mark scheme 2017 (“use of the natural world”)

Power · AQA specimen mark scheme only (a weak link: avoid for power questions)

Memory · our reading

Loss · our reading

Place and home · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Dramatic monologue in free verse: 4 stanzas of 6, 11, 12 and 6 lines (35 lines)

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet the printed poem, but named in AQA mark schemes 2017–2025

BEST PARTNER

Remains (your anchor); Kamikaze also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A mother talks to her son. She remembers pinning a poppy on him before he left home. Then she follows a dove up the hill to the war memorial and listens for his voice.

THE MESSAGE

War hurts the people left at home, not just the soldiers. A mother's love and fear can be as painful as any wound, even if she has to hide it.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Weir wrote it in 2009, when Carol Ann Duffy asked poets for new war poems about Afghanistan and Iraq. Weir, a textile designer, told the story from a mother's side.

Pearson Edexcel mark scheme;

Oak National Academy; Wilfred

Owen Association

THE TITLE

A **poppy** is the red flower people wear to remember those killed in war. The title is plural: the poem opens with poppies “*on individual war graves*”, so this is one family's story among many. Oak National Academy suggests the title could point to “remembrance, the many grieving mothers of war or the outward display of deeper grief.” **one source** (Royal British Legion; Oak National Academy)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

A mother speaks to her son as “you”. He never answers. She mixes three times together: the present, the morning he left, and his childhood. So the poem jumps about, the way memory does.

Lines 1–6

It is “Three days before Armistice Sunday”, when the dead of all wars are remembered. Before her son leaves, she pins a paper poppy on the lapel of his blazer.

Lines 7–17

She fusses over him: she uses Sellotape to pick cat hairs off his clothes and smooths his collar. She wants to rub noses like they did when he was little, and to stroke his hair, but she holds back. She can't find the words.

Lines 18–22

She bravely walks him to the front door. Outside, the world is full of excitement, like a treasure chest. In a split second he is gone, “intoxicated” (thrilled, almost drunk) with it.

Lines 23–29

She goes into his empty bedroom and lets a song bird out of its cage. Later a dove leads her out past the churchyard walls. She has rushed out without a coat, scarf or gloves, and her stomach is in knots.

Lines 30–35

At the top of the hill she traces the names carved on the war memorial and leans on it. The dove flies off into the sky. She listens, hoping to hear his childhood voice on the wind.

The turning point (lines 21–23): “A split second / and you were away”. Up to here she is with her son. After “After you’d gone” she is alone, and the poem moves from the house out to the war memorial. **How it ends:** On the mother listening for a voice she cannot hear. We never learn whether the son has died. The poem leaves him somewhere between a boy leaving home and a name on a memorial. **The tone:** Tender, quiet and sad. AQA calls it “reflective”. Under the calm there is fear and grief that she works hard to hide.

2 The poem, section by section

This poem is still in copyright, so we only show the key phrases here. Read the full poem in your anthology alongside these notes. Highlighted words are the ones worth quoting in the exam. The poem is still in copyright,

so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key words to quote.

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–6

Three days before Armistice Sunday ... spasms of paper red

LINES 7–11

Sellotape bandaged around my hand ... steeled the softening

LINES 11–16

play at being Eskimos ... gelled blackthorns of your hair

LINES 16–18

All my words flattened, rolled, turned into felt, ... slowly melting

LINES 18–22

I was brave ... the world overflowing like a treasure chest

LINES 23–26

released a song bird from its cage. ... this is where it has led me,

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The setting is just before Remembrance Sunday. Poppies are already on the war graves. She pins one on her son's blazer. The petals are **“crimped”** (pinched into folds), and the red paper twitches in **“spasms”**, like a body in pain. The poppy **“disrupting a blockade”** of yellow trim is a war word sneaking into a home scene.

She wraps Sellotape round her hand to pick up cat hairs from his clothes. **“bandaged”** makes an everyday job sound like treating a wound. She smooths his collar and forces her face to stay hard (**“steeled”**) so she won't cry.

She longs to rub noses with him, a game from his childhood. She also wants to run her fingers through his hair. She resists both. His spiky gelled hair is like **“blackthorns”**, a prickly hedge: he is grown up now, and harder to touch.

Her words fail her. Felt is a cloth made by pressing and rolling wool, so her words are squashed into something soft and silent. The sentence runs over the stanza break, as if her feelings spill out.

Her bravery is not fighting but letting him go. She opens the door on an exciting world full of treasure for a young man. Then he is gone in **“A split second”**, **“intoxicated”** (giddy with excitement).

In his bedroom she frees a bird. It could stand for letting her son go, or for his spirit leaving. A **“single dove”**, a symbol of peace, leads her outside. **“this is where it has led me”** jumps into the present: she is speaking from the hill now.

LINES 27–29

making tucks, darts, pleats ... without a winter coat

Her nervous stomach is described in sewing words: tucks, darts and pleats are folds stitched into cloth. She has gone out unprotected, with no “**reinforcements**” (another army word) of scarf or gloves.

LINES 30–32

On reaching the top of the hill ... leaned against it like a wishbone.

She traces the carved names on the war memorial with her finger. She leans on it like a **wishbone**, the forked chicken bone people snap to make a wish. It suggests she is fragile, and still wishing he is safe.

LINES 33–35

an ornamental stitch ... your playground voice catching on the wind.

The dove is a tiny stitch against the sky. She listens for her son's voice, but only as a child in a playground. The poem ends with her waiting, with no answer.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 5

“spasms of paper red”

Means: the paper poppy's petals twitch like a body in pain. **Technique:** metaphor and colour imagery: red is the poppy, but also blood. A symbol of remembrance already hints at injury.

LINES 10–11

“steemed the softening of my face”

Means: she forces her face to stay hard so her son won't see her cry. **Why it matters:** “steemed” is armour, “softening” is her love. The clash shows her hidden struggle: she must be as brave as a soldier.

LINES 13–14

“being Eskimos like we did when you were little”

Means: she wants to rub noses with him, a game from his childhood. **Why it matters:** memory takes her back to when he was small and safe. The gap between the little boy and the young man leaving is the source of her grief.

LINES 16–17

“All my words flattened, rolled, turned into felt,”

Means: her words are squashed into silence. **Technique:** textile metaphor and a list of three verbs: words become soft cloth. Weir is a textile designer. Pearson Edexcel; Oak

LINE 24

“released a song bird from its cage.”

Means: she lets a bird go free from his room. **Technique:** symbol: freeing her son to leave, or his soul leaving his body. Oak National Academy suggests birds show her “letting go of her son”.

one source

LINE 32

“leaned against it like a wishbone.”

Means: she leans on the war memorial, thin and fragile. **Technique:** simile: a wishbone is snapped to make a wish. She is wishing he is safe, but she could break.

LINE 35

“your playground voice catching on the wind.”

Means: she listens for her son's voice as it sounded when he was a child. **Why it matters:** the poem ends in uncertainty and longing. She can only reach him in memory; the present gives her silence.

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a mother's dramatic monologue in free verse

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **dramatic monologue** is “a poem written in the form of a speech of an individual character”. *Britannica*
- We hear only one voice, so we see only what the speaker feels and remembers. There is no narrator to explain things.
- **Free verse** is “poetry organized to the cadences of speech and image patterns rather than according to a regular metrical scheme”. In other words: no regular rhyme or beat, more like natural speech. *Britannica*
- Pearson Edexcel (a different exam board, not AQA, which also sets this poem) calls it “a mother’s dramatic monologue directly addressed to her son”, “written in four stanzas of unequal length and is in free verse”. *Pearson Edexcel mark scheme, Nov 2020*

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Talking to “you”:** the whole poem is spoken to her son, but he never replies. His silence makes him feel absent, maybe lost for good.
our reading
- **Shape:** 6, 11, 12 and 6 lines. Oak National Academy says the “Two sestets either side of two longer stanzas may suggest the mother trying hard to contain her emotions”. A **sestet** is a six-line stanza. *our count; Oak* *one source*
- **Time jumps about:** Pearson Edexcel’s mark scheme (not AQA) notes “Three different times”, “the present, the specific moment and the past”, and calls the poem “non-chronological”. The present (“*this is where it has led me*”) and his childhood (“*when / you were little*”) break into the story of his leaving.
Pearson Edexcel *one source*
- **Breaks and run-ons:** full stops land in the middle of lines (“*war graves. Before you left,*”), like a voice catching. The sentence “*turned into felt,*” runs on into the next stanza: “*slowly melting.*” Her feelings spill over the edges.
Pearson Edexcel; our reading
- **Free verse** fits a private, wandering voice. There is no drumbeat of marching, unlike older war poems such as *The Charge of the Light Brigade*. *our reading*

A sentence you could use: Weir writes *Poppies* as a dramatic monologue to a son who never answers, and its free verse moves between past and present like memory, so the reader feels the mother's grief through what she cannot say.

Textile imagery

Weir fills the poem with sewing words: “*bias binding*”, “*felt*”, “*tucks, darts, pleats*”, “*an ornamental stitch*”. They show a mother who makes and mends, using what she knows to cope. But cloth cannot protect a soldier. Weir trained in textile design, and Examiners for Pearson Edexcel (a different exam board, not AQA) praised students who made this link.

Semantic field: a group of words from the same topic (here, sewing) spread through a text.

War words in a home

Everyday things are described in military terms: a poppy “*disrupting a blockade*”, Sellotape “*bandaged*”, “*reinforcements of scarf, gloves*”. War has crept into the family home before the son has even gone. AQA's 2017 mark scheme points to Weir's “metaphor to present effects of war”.

Juxtaposition: placing two very different things side by side so we notice the contrast.

Birds as symbols

She frees a “*song bird*” in his room, then follows a “*single dove*”, the bird of peace. At the end the dove “*pulled freely against the sky*”. The birds may stand for the son flying the nest, his spirit, or the peace she longs for. The meaning is left open.

Symbol: an object that stands for a bigger idea, like a dove for peace.

Love she can't show

She keeps stopping herself: “*I resisted the impulse*”; she “*steeled the softening*” of her face. The poem is full of touches that never happen. Her bravery is holding back, not fighting. AQA's Nov 2020 mark scheme points to “the reflective quality of ‘Poppies’”.

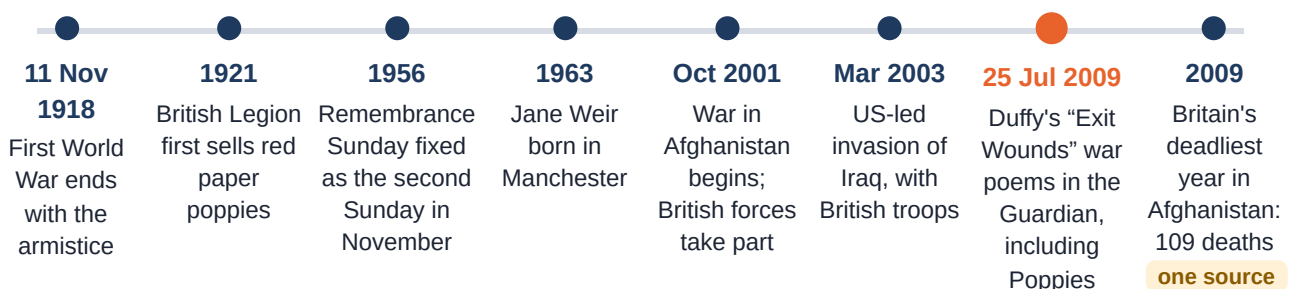
Restraint: holding back feelings; in poetry, saying less so the reader feels more.

Examiners warn: in November 2021, for a question on power and control, AQA's report said “some students struggled with choices again, for example, Storm on the Island and Poppies”. Use Poppies for questions on the effects of conflict or difficult experiences, not power.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



one source

WHO JANE WEIR IS

Born in Manchester in 1963, with an English mother and an Italian father. The Poetry Archive calls her “an Anglo-Italian writer and designer.”

Writing East Midlands; Poetry Archive

She has a background in textile design, fashion and costume. That's where the sewing words come from. Writing East Midlands; Pearson Edexcel;

Oak National Academy

effects of conflict (how the mother copes)

Her books are published by Templar Poetry, which also gave AQA permission to print Poppies. Poetry Archive; AQA anthology

The Poetry Archive says her work shows “humane concern for lost lives”, “principally those of women”. Poppies gives a voice to a woman whom war stories often leave out. Poetry

Archive difficult experiences · conflict

one source; the link to Poppies is our reading

EXIT WOUNDS: THE 2009 COMMISSION

In July 2009, “With the conflict in Afghanistan escalating and the Iraq inquiry pending, poet laureate Carol Ann Duffy commissions war poetry for today” (the Guardian, 25 July 2009).

Wilfred Owen Association, quoting the Guardian

effects of conflict · conflict

Poppies was one of these poems, published under the title “Exit Wounds”. Pearson Edexcel mark scheme, Nov 2020; Oak National Academy

effects of conflict

Guardian page itself blocked

Magma Poetry described the Exit Wounds poems as “attempts to write on war by poets with no direct experience of it.” Weir writes from home, not the front line. Magma Poetry

effects of conflict on those not immediately involved

one source

Duffy had just become “the first woman poet laureate of Great Britain” (2009–19). She also wrote War Photographer, another poem in your anthology. Britannica; AQA anthology

comparison link

Oak National Academy says the poem “struck a nerve with many mothers who had lost their children during conflict”. Oak National Academy

difficult experiences · effects of conflict

one source

THE POPPY AND REMEMBRANCE

Poppies flowered on the churned-up battlefields of Belgium and northern France in the First World War. John McCrae's 1915 poem "In Flanders Fields" made them famous. Britannica; Royal British Legion; National Army Museum

conflict · nature

In 1921 the British Legion "began selling red paper poppies for Armistice Day". That's the "paper red" poppy the mother pins on. Britannica; Royal British Legion

effects of conflict

The Royal British Legion says the poppy "remembers the sacrifices of those who have served" and "represents hope for a peaceful future." Royal British Legion

conflict · memory

Armistice Day began on 11 November 1919. After the Second World War it became Remembrance Sunday, honouring the dead of both wars and later ones, with a two-minute silence at 11 am. Britannica; Pearson Edexcel

memory · loss

Pearson Edexcel's examiners (not AQA) noted that "Few explored the reference to 'Armistice Sunday' in the first line". Mentioning it is an easy AO3 point. Pearson Edexcel examiners' report, Nov 2020

all questions

a different exam board, not AQA

AFGHANISTAN AND IRAQ IN 2009

Britain joined the war in Afghanistan in October 2001, after the 9/11 attacks in America. From 2006 British troops fought mainly in Helmand province. Britannica; National Army Museum

conflict

Helmand: one source

The National Army Museum says "2009 would be Britain's bloodiest year in Afghanistan, with 109 deaths." That was the year Weir wrote Poppies. National Army Museum

effects of conflict · loss

one source

British troops had also fought in Iraq since the 2003 invasion. In 2009 an inquiry into that war was about to begin. National Army Museum; Britannica; Wilfred Owen Association

conflict

The poem never names a war or a place. So it speaks for any family, in any war. Oak warns that Poppies "is not a WW1 poem", even though the poppy comes from the First World War. Oak

National Academy

effects of conflict

one source (Oak); the first two sentences are our reading

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Weir wrote Poppies in 2009, for Carol Ann Duffy's "Exit Wounds" poems, at the height of the war in Afghanistan. Instead of the soldier, she shows the mother at home, and she uses the Remembrance poppy and the war memorial to link one family's fear to every family that has lost someone in war.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Poppies + Kamikaze

A

Use for: **Effects of conflict** **Difficult experiences** **Memory** · AQA: 2017 mark scheme ("the effects of war on others, such as 'Poppies' or 'Kamikaze'"); Nov 2020 mark scheme

SIMILAR

- Both show war through a family member, not the fighter: a mother speaks to her son; a daughter tells her children about her father.
- Both begin with a departure: the son is "away, intoxicated"; the pilot "embarked at sunrise".
- Both use silence to show pain: "All my words / flattened" and "my mother never spoke again".
- Both look back to a happy childhood: "when / you were little" and "only we children still chattered and laughed".

DIFFERENT

- **Absence or return:** Weir's mother suffers because her son has gone. Garland's family suffers because the father came back, and they "live as though he had never returned".
- **Love or shame:** the mother's love is tender and hidden. The pilot's family is cold because he broke his duty.
- **Voice:** Poppies is first person to "you", private and close. Kamikaze is mostly third person, a story retold ("she said"), so it feels more distant.

Poppies + War Photographer

B

Use for: **Effects of conflict** **Conflict** **Memory** · AQA: 2024 mark scheme ("those not immediately involved, such as 'Poppies' or 'War Photographer'"); 2022 and 2025 mark schemes

SIMILAR

- Both show people affected by war who are not soldiers: a mother at home and a photographer back in England.
- Both are written in the shadow of remembrance and religion: the war memorial by the "church yard walls"; a darkroom "as though this were a church".
- Both show feelings held back and then leaking out: she "stealed the softening"; his hands "did not tremble then" "though seem to now."

DIFFERENT

- **Who they mourn:** she grieves for her own son; he remembers strangers, such as "the cries / of this man's wife".
- **Ending:** Oak describes Poppies ending with "a sombre but peaceful tone" and War Photographer with "a caustic and restless tone" (caustic = bitter). Weir listens hopefully; Duffy blames readers who "do not care." **one source**
- **Form:** Weir's free verse wanders like memory. Duffy uses regular six-line stanzas with rhyme, like the "ordered rows" of his photos.

Poppies + Remains

C

Use for: **Effects of conflict** **Memory** **Difficult experiences** · AQA: 2017 mark scheme (“brutal description in ‘Remains’, or lyrical imagery in ‘Poppies’”); 2022 mark scheme (immediacy against “reflective stance”)

SIMILAR

- Both are first-person voices haunted by one person they cannot let go of: “*your playground voice*” and “*he’s here in my head*”.
- Both end unresolved, with the past alive in the present: “*hoping to hear*” and “*here and now*”.
- Both use everyday, chatty language for something painful: “*play at / being Eskimos*” and “*legs it*”.

DIFFERENT

- **Language:** AQA contrasts Armitage’s “brutal description” with Weir’s “lyrical imagery”: “*tosses his guts back into his body*” against “*spasms of paper red*”.
- **Feeling:** his feeling is guilt for a man he killed; hers is love and fear for a son she lost.
- **Pace:** AQA’s 2022 mark scheme contrasts the “immediacy” of Remains with the “more reflective stance” of Poppies.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present the ways people are affected by conflict in ‘Poppies’ and in one other poem from ‘Power and conflict’. (AQA used this wording in 2024; its mark scheme names Poppies for “the effects of conflict on those not immediately involved”.)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Weir and Garland show war wounding the people at home who never fight, but Weir’s mother is hurt by her son’s absence, while Garland’s family is hurt by a father’s return.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets show that conflict damages people at home who never see a battle. Weir’s mother hides her fear: she “*stealed the softening*” of her face. The verb “stealed” turns her face into armour, as if she must be a soldier too. Her grief escapes only in metaphor, as her words are “*turned into felt*”: soft, pressed flat and silent. Garland’s family is also silenced, but by shame: “*my mother never spoke again*”. However, Weir’s mother loses a son who has gone, while Garland’s children learn “*to live as though he had never returned*”, losing a father who is still alive. Writing in 2009, during the war in Afghanistan, Weir gives a mother’s view that war stories often leave out.

Why it scores:

- Thesis answers the question in one sentence and names the key difference (absence against return)
- Short quotations from both poems, with one word picked out and analysed (“stealed”)
- Context (2009, a mother’s view) is tied to the point, not bolted on

The Emigrée

Carol Rumens (1944–2026) · collected 1993

14

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Effects of conflict · AQA mark schemes June 2017, June 2019 and June 2024

Identity · AQA mark scheme June 2024 ("sense of identity")

Place and home · AQA mark scheme Nov 2021 ("use of places as representation of people")

Difficult experiences · AQA mark scheme Nov 2020 ("a change in circumstances")

Conflict · AQA mark scheme June 2022 ("conflict of beliefs")

Power · AQA mark scheme June 2018 ("those in power contrasted with those without")

Memory · our reading

Loss · our reading

Isolation · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Free verse: three stanzas (8, 8 and 9 lines), 25 lines

IN THE EXAM?

Not yet the printed poem; named in AQA mark schemes (2017, 2018, 2019, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2024)

BEST PARTNER

Remains (your anchor); Tissue also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A woman left her home country as a child and can never go back. She hears it may now be at war and ruled by tyrants, but her memory of its city stays bright with sunlight. In her new city, people surround her and threaten her.

THE MESSAGE

Memories of home, and the language you grew up with, are part of who you are. War, borders and governments cannot take them away, even when they take away the place itself.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Rumens was born in London, so the speaker is an imagined voice. She had a strong interest in Central and Eastern Europe, translated Russian poets, and the book this poem comes from is full of "loss and exile". Poetry Archive; Bloodaxe; Thinking of Skins publisher's description

THE TITLE

An **émigré** is someone who has left their country, especially “for political reasons”. The word is French, and the extra “e” on the end (*émigrée*) makes it feminine, so the speaker is a woman. The first émigrés were people who fled France after the French Revolution of 1789. So the title already suggests someone forced out by politics, not someone who chose to move. The poem itself never names the country. (Merriam-Webster; Britannica; Larousse)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

A first-person speaker ("I") talks about the country and city she left as a child. She never names them. She lives somewhere else now and cannot go back.

Lines 1–4

She begins like a fairy tale: *"There once was a country..."*. She left as a child, and her memory is *"sunlight-clear"*. She never saw the city in *"that November"*, the dark, cold time she has been told comes even to the mildest city. So her picture of it holds only good weather.

Lines 5–8

Even the worst news cannot break her first picture of the city, which is sealed like *"the bright, filled paperweight"*. The country may be at war or ruled by tyrants, but the sunlight is burned into her.

Lines 9–11

The white streets and gentle slopes of the city glow even brighter in her mind as time passes. Time is pictured as tanks rolling in, and borders rise up between her and the city like waves.

Lines 12–16

The child's words she brought with her keep opening up inside her, like a hollow doll. Her home language may now be *"banned by the state"*, but she cannot get it off her tongue: *"It tastes of sunlight."*

Lines 17–20

She has *"no passport"* and no way back. Instead the city comes to her, in her imagination, in its own white plane. It lies down in front of her like a child or a pet, and she combs its hair.

Lines 21–25

Her city takes her dancing through the *"city / of walls"* where she lives now. People there, called only "They", accuse her of absence and of being dark, and circle her. Her city hides behind her. They mutter death, and her shadow becomes proof of the sunlight.

The turning point: line 17, *"I have no passport, there's no way back at all"*. The first two stanzas are about memory. The third moves into the present, where the remembered city visits her and she is under threat. **How it ends:** The poem ends on the same word as every stanza: *"my shadow falls as evidence of sunlight."* Even her darkness, the thing the hostile people attack, proves the bright memory is still alive in her. **The tone:** Loving, nostalgic (longing for the past) and stubborn at first, then tense and threatening in the last stanza. The speaker never gives in: she holds on to her memory against bad news, borders, the state and the people around her.

2 The poem, section by section

The *Emigrée* is still in copyright, so the full poem is not printed here. Read it in your anthology alongside these notes. (Your anthology spells it “The Émigrée” and prints “Carole”; use “The Emigrée” and “Carol Rumens”, as the exam paper does.) Highlighted words are the short phrases worth learning for the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so read the full text in your anthology, or in [AQA's free anthology PDF](#). Below, each section is explained in plain English, with the key words to quote.

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–4

*There once was a country... ... sunlight-clear ...
in that November*

LINES 5–8

*the bright, filled paperweight ... sick with tyrants
... branded by an impression of sunlight*

LINES 9–11

*as time rolls its tanks ... the frontiers rise
between us, close like waves*

LINES 12–16

*like a hollow doll, opens and spills a grammar ...
banned by the state ... It tastes of sunlight.*

LINES 17–20

*I have no passport ... docile as paper ... I comb
its hair*

LINES 21–25

*the city / of walls ... They accuse me of being
dark in their free city. ... evidence of sunlight*

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

The fairy-tale opening and the ellipsis (...) make the country feel like a story from long ago, perhaps half lost. She left as a child. She remembers it only in bright light, because she never saw it in its dark months.

Bad news cannot break her first view of the city: it is sealed like a glass paperweight. She admits the country may be at war or ruled by cruel leaders, but the sunlight is burned into her like a brand.

The city's white streets glow even brighter in her memory. Time is like an army moving in, and borders rise between her and home like waves closing over her.

The words she learned as a child keep opening up, like a set of dolls inside each other. The government may have banned her language, but it is still in her mouth, and it tastes of sunlight.

She cannot travel home. So the city comes to her in her mind, in its own white plane. It lies down, gentle and helpless, and she cares for it like a mother with a child. The roles are reversed: now she protects her home.

In her new city, a place of walls, unnamed people (“They”) accuse her, surround her and mutter death. “Free” sounds bitter here. Her city hides behind her. Her shadow, her darkness, becomes proof of the sunlight she carries.

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINE 1

"There once was a country..."

Means: she begins like a fairy tale about a home she left as a child. **Technique:** fairy-tale opening and ellipsis: the country feels like a story, distant and maybe lost.

LINE 6

"the bright, filled paperweight"

Means: her memory is sealed and perfect, like a scene in glass. **Why it matters:** beautiful, but frozen: it cannot change, and it cannot be real any more.

LINE 7

"it may be sick with tyrants"

Means: the country may now be at war and ruled by cruel leaders. **Technique:** repetition of "It may" (the line opens "It may be at war") and personification: the country is pictured as ill.

LINE 10

"as time rolls its tanks"

Means: time moves on like an invading army. **Technique:** metaphor: conflict imagery invades even her memory.

LINE 13

"like a hollow doll, opens and spills a grammar."

Means: her childhood language keeps opening up inside her. **Why it matters:** language is part of her identity, and it keeps growing in her.

LINE 19

"It lies down in front of me, docile as paper;"

Means: the city lies down, gentle and helpless, like a child. **Technique:** personification and simile: the place becomes a person she protects.

LINE 25

"my shadow falls as evidence of sunlight."

Means: even her darkness proves the bright memory is still there. **Technique:** paradox and the repeated stanza ending "sunlight".

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: free verse in three stanzas that all end in “sunlight”

ABOUT THE FORM

- **Free verse** is poetry “organized to the cadences of speech”, not to “a regular metrical scheme”. In plain English: no fixed rhythm and no rhyme pattern. *Britannica*
- Because it follows the rhythms of speech, free verse can sound like a real person talking or thinking. Here it lets the speaker's memories and fears come out in her own voice.
our reading
- **Enjambment** is “the continuation of the sense of a phrase” beyond the end of a line. *Britannica*

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Shape:** 25 long lines in three stanzas of 8, 8 and 9 lines. No rhyme scheme and no regular rhythm. *our count*
- **The sunlight ending:** every stanza ends on the word “sunlight” (lines 8, 16 and 25). Whatever threat each stanza brings, war, tyrants, a banned language, accusing voices, the memory comes back at the end.
our reading
- **From past to present:** stanza 1 looks back (“*I left it as a child*”); by stanza 3 it is all present tense (“*I have no passport*”). The memory is not finished: it is still happening to her. *our reading*
- **The last stanza breaks up:** short, sharp sentences pile up: “*They accuse me of absence, they circle me.*” The full stops and repeated “They” make the threat close in, and the enjambment on “*the city / of walls*” makes the walls arrive with a jolt.

A sentence you could use: Rumens writes in free verse, like a real voice remembering, but ends each of the three stanzas on “sunlight”; however much conflict each stanza brings, the bright memory always returns, which shows that her identity cannot be taken from her.

Light and sunlight as a motif

Light runs through the poem: “*sunlight-clear*”, “*bright*”, “*glow even clearer*”, “*shining eyes*”, and “sunlight” at the end of every stanza. Light stands for her happy, hopeful memory of home. Against it are darker words: war, tyrants, tanks, walls, dark, death.

Motif: an image or idea that keeps coming back in a text.

The city as a person

In the last stanza the city “*lies down in front of me*”, and she combs “*its hair*”. Then “*My city hides behind me.*” The place has become someone she loves and protects. AQA's mark scheme names the “use of places as representation of people”, giving Tissue and The Emigrée as examples.

Personification: describing a thing as if it were a person.

Conflict creeping into the memory

War words appear inside lovely images: time “*rolls its tanks*”, “*the frontiers rise*”, the language is “*banned by the state*”. Conflict is never shown directly, but it is always pressing in on her memories.

Semantic field: a group of words linked by the same topic (here, war and state control).

An unnamed “I” and an unnamed “They”

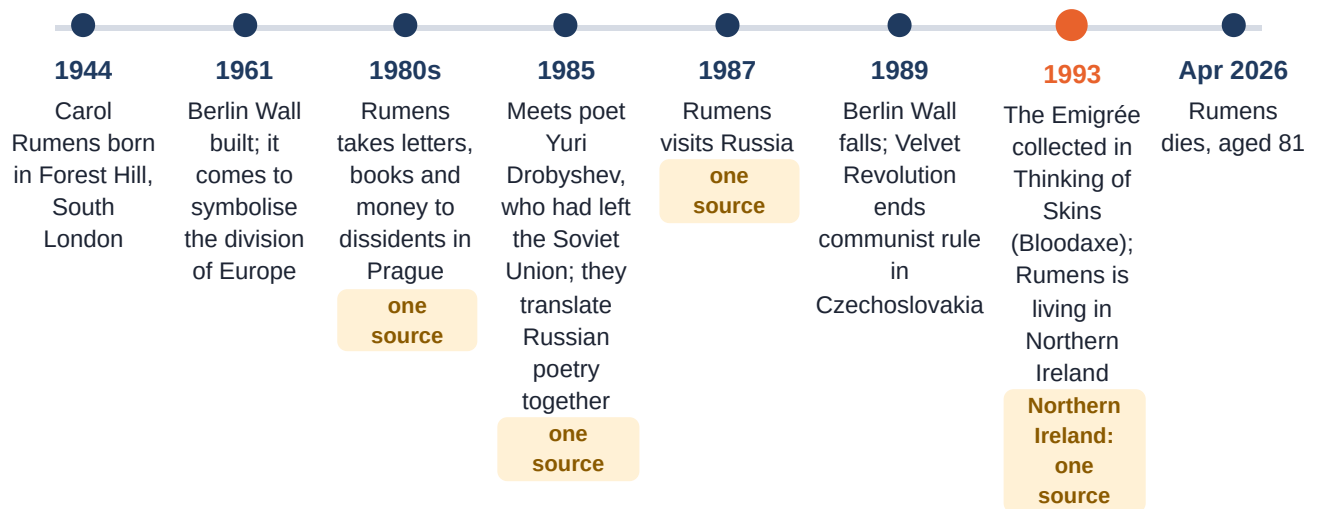
We never learn her name, her country or who “They” are. That makes her story fit many people who have been forced from home. The repeated “*They accuse me*” sounds like a crowd ganging up on one person.

Persona: a voice or character a poet speaks through, who is not the poet.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO RUMENS WAS

Born Carol Lumley in 1944 in Forest Hill, South London. She did not leave her country as a child, so the speaker is an imagined voice, not Rumens herself. Poetry Archive; Carcanet; The

Telegraph **identity · voice**

imagined voice: our reading

She had “a particular interest in the literary cultures” of Central and Eastern Europe, and translated many Russian poets. Poetry Archive;

Bloodaxe **conflict · identity**

Her partner, the poet Yuri Drobyshev, “had left the Soviet Union in 1978”. Together they translated Russian poetry. The Telegraph; Bloodaxe

place and home · identity **1978 date: one source**

In the 1980s she took “letters, books and money” to dissidents (people who opposed the government) in communist Prague, at risk to herself. The Telegraph (obituary, 2026)

power · conflict **one source**

She taught creative writing “most extensively in Belfast and Bangor”, wrote the Guardian's “Poem of the Week”, and died in April 2026, aged 81. Poetry Archive; Bloodaxe; Carcanet; The Telegraph

THE BOOK IT COMES FROM

AQA's anthology credits the poem to *Thinking of Skins*, a “new & selected” collection published by Bloodaxe in 1993. The poem may first have appeared a little earlier. AQA anthology; Open Library; Google Books

The publisher says Rumens “confronts the personal with the political” and shows “engagement with other lives”. The Emigrée does this: one woman's memories, shaped by war and the state. Open Library; Google Books

conflict · identity **link to this poem: our reading**

The poems are “Often set against the background of Eastern Europe, Russia” or her home in Northern Ireland, and “filled with a powerful sense of loss and exile.” Google Books (publisher's description) **place and home · loss**

one source

Northern Ireland was then in the Troubles (about 1968–1998), when “peace walls physically divided communities”. It is tempting to link this to the “city / of walls”, but the poem never says so. Britannica **conflict** **our reading**

ÉMIGRÉS, REFUGEES AND BORDERS

An émigré is a person “forced to leave a country for political reasons”. The feminine form is émigrée. Britannica Dictionary; Merriam-Webster;

Larousse identity · power

The first émigrés were French people, “at first mostly aristocrats, who fled France” after the Revolution of 1789. The word has always carried the idea of escape from political danger.

Britannica; Larousse power · conflict

Britannica defines a refugee as someone who “has crossed a frontier” and no longer has “the protection of his or her former government.” Compare “the frontiers rise between us” and “I have no passport”. Britannica effects of conflict

link to the poem: our reading

When Rumens was writing, Europe was split by the Iron Curtain, a barrier built by the Soviet Union to seal off eastern Europe from the West. It “largely ceased to exist in 1989–90”. Britannica

conflict · power

background only: the poem names no country

The poem never names a country, a war or a government. That lets it speak for anyone forced from home. Don't write that it is “about” one real country. the poem identity · place

our reading

ANOTHER WAY TO READ IT

The Telegraph's obituary says the poem “seems to explore the exile's nostalgia” for the culture she has left. The Telegraph (obituary, 2026)

memory · place

one source

It adds that Rumens “on one occasion said” she used the poem's “statelessness and a precious, sunlit past” as “a metaphor for a forbidden relationship.” This is the paper's report, not her own words. The Telegraph (obituary, 2026)

identity · loss

reported, one source

That reading fits the love language of the last stanza: she combs its hair, loves its “shining eyes”, and goes dancing. The lost city can stand for anything, or anyone, you are not allowed to return to. our reading

loss · memory

our reading

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Rumens was born in London but was deeply involved with Central and Eastern Europe in the last years of the Iron Curtain, supporting dissidents and translating Russian poets. The Emigrée gives a voice to someone forced out by politics, but it deliberately names no country, so it speaks for any exile. The title word means someone who left for political reasons. Rumens shows that the state can ban a language and close a border, but cannot take away memory or identity.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

The Emigrée + Remains

A

Use for: **Memory** **Effects of conflict** · AQA: Nov 2020 mark scheme for the Remains question ("a change in circumstances in 'The Emigrée'")

SIMILAR

- Both speakers are haunted by a memory that keeps coming back uninvited: *"my city comes to me in its own white plane"* and *"he bursts again through the doors of the bank."* Hers is sunlit and loved; his is violent and guilty.
- Both use "I" and show the memory lodged inside the body: *"I can't get it off my tongue"* and *"he's here in my head when I close my eyes"*.
- Both use the language of war inside the mind: *"time rolls its tanks"* and *"dug in behind enemy lines"*.

DIFFERENT

- Feeling:** she wants to keep her memory (*"I comb its hair and love its shining eyes"*); he wants to be rid of his, but *"the drink and the drugs won't flush him out"*.
- Light:** for Rumens sunlight means a safe, innocent past (*"sunlight-clear"*); in Remains daylight shows through a wound: *"I see broad daylight on the other side."*
- Ending:** Rumens ends in defiance, her shadow *"evidence of sunlight"*; Armitage ends in guilt: *"his bloody life in my bloody hands."*

The Emigrée + Tissue

B

Use for: **Identity** **Place and home** **Effects of conflict** · AQA: Nov 2021 mark scheme ("use of places as representation of people", naming Tissue and The Emigrée) and June 2024 ("sense of identity")

SIMILAR

- Both use light as a sign of hope: Rumens's memory is *"sunlight-clear"*; Dharker's paper *"lets the light / shine through"*.
- Both turn places into people: the city lies *"docile as paper"*; Dharker's paper ends as *"your skin."*
- Both show borders shaping lives: *"the frontiers rise between us"* and *"their borderlines"*.

DIFFERENT

- Borders:** Rumens's speaker is trapped by them (*"I have no passport"*); Dharker imagines *"The sun shines through"* them.
- Ending:** The Emigrée ends under threat (*"They mutter death"*), though her *"evidence of sunlight"* survives; Tissue ends gently and hopefully.
- Voice:** Rumens's speaker tells her own painful story; Dharker's speaker thinks about everyone, then turns to "you".

The Emigrée + Checking Out Me History

C

Use for: **Identity** **Power** **Conflict** · AQA: June 2022 mark scheme ("conflict of beliefs in 'The Emigrée'" and "ideology/identity in 'Checking Out Me History'")

SIMILAR

- Both show the powerful trying to control identity. Rumens's language is *"banned by the state"*; Agard's teachers *"Blind me to me own identity"*.
- Both speakers fight back in the first person: *"I can't get it off my tongue"* and *"I carving out me identity"*.
- Both use repetition to show pressure from outside: *"They accuse me"* and *"Dem tell me"*.

DIFFERENT

- Language:** Agard writes in Caribbean dialect to show his identity on the page; Rumens's speaker only tells us her language *"tastes of sunlight"*.
- Tone:** Agard is angry and defiant; Rumens is loving and nostalgic, then afraid.
- Who controls:** in Agard it is the education system ("Dem"); in Rumens a state, tyrants and a hostile crowd ("They").

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present the ways people are affected by conflict in 'The Emigrée' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (June 2024 focus, adapted: the printed poem that year was Kamikaze)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Rumens and Garland show conflict cutting people off from home, but Rumens's speaker holds on defiantly to a bright memory, while Garland's pilot is silenced and left with doubt.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets show that conflict can leave people as outsiders, cut off from the place they belong. Rumens's speaker can never return: *"I have no passport, there's no way back at all"*. In her new city she is attacked by an unnamed crowd, and the repetition in *"They accuse me of absence, they circle me"* makes the threat close in. Garland's pilot is also shut out, but by his own family and neighbours, who treat him *"as though he no longer existed"*. Both poets use bright memories of home against this: the émigrée's city is *"sunlight-clear"*, and the pilot remembers fish that *"swivelled towards the sun"*. However, Rumens ends in defiance, with *"evidence of sunlight"*, whereas Garland ends in doubt about *"the better way to die."*

Why it scores:

- Opens with a clear comparative point that answers the question about the effects of conflict
- Short, exact quotations from both poems, with methods named (repetition, light imagery)
- Keeps comparing all the way through ("Both", "also", "However", "whereas") and ends on a judgement about the endings

Kamikaze

Beatrice Garland (born 1938) · published 2013

15

THEMES (solid = linked by AQA · dashed = our reading)

Effects of conflict · AQA question June 2024; mark schemes 2017 and 2019

Conflict · AQA mark schemes June 2022 and 2025

War · AQA examiners' report June 2022

Nature · AQA mark schemes 2019 and June 2022

Power · AQA mark schemes Nov 2021 (reactions to being controlled) and 2023 (victim of others' power)

Difficult experiences · AQA mark scheme Nov 2020

Patriotism and duty · our reading

Memory · our reading

Isolation · our reading

TYPE OF POEM

Narrative poem: seven six-line stanzas (42 lines), only three sentences

IN THE EXAM?

Yes: June 2024 (the printed poem)

BEST PARTNER

Remains (your anchor); Poppies also works well

THE STORY IN SHORT

A Japanese pilot sets off on a suicide mission in the Second World War. Halfway there, the sea below reminds him of his childhood, and he turns back. At home, his wife, his neighbours and in the end his own children treat him as if he no longer exists.

THE MESSAGE

War does not only harm people on the battlefield. A culture of duty and honour can turn a family against a man for choosing to live, so he suffers a different kind of death.

WHY IT WAS WRITTEN

Kamikaze pilots deliberately crashed their planes into enemy ships, mostly from October 1944 to the end of the war. Garland, a poet who also worked as an NHS clinician, tells the story through the pilot's daughter. *Britannica; Templar Poetry; WJEC*

THE TITLE

"Kamikaze" means "divine wind". It recalls a typhoon that scattered a Mongol invasion fleet threatening Japan in 1281. In the Second World War it became the name for Japanese pilots who made suicide attacks on enemy ships. The title names what the father was meant to become, and never does. **last sentence: our reading** There is an irony too: in 1281 nature saved Japan; in the poem, nature saves one man, but his country cannot forgive him. **our reading** (*Britannica; National WWII Museum; our reading*)

1 What happens, step by step

Follow along in the poem. The line numbers match the AQA anthology.

The setup

A pilot's daughter, now a mother herself, tells her children what happened to their grandfather. At first a narrator reports her story ("she thought"); later she speaks in her own words ("my mother"). The pilot himself never speaks.

Lines 1–6

Her father sets off at sunrise on his mission. He has a flask of water, a samurai sword, a shaved head full of "powerful incantations", and only enough fuel for a "one-way / journey into history".

Lines 7–12

Halfway there, the daughter imagines, he must have looked down at the tiny fishing boats, "strung out like bunting" on a clear blue-green sea.

Lines 13–18

Under the boats, huge shoals of fish swirl in a figure of eight like a waving flag, their silver bellies flashing in the sun.

Lines 19–24

This makes him remember his childhood: he and his brothers on the beach, building piles of pebbles ("cairns") against the waves while they waited for their father's fishing boat to come home safe.

Lines 25–30

The daughter breaks in to explain to her children that this was "grandfather's boat". It came home full of fish: mackerel, crabs, prawns, whitebait, and once a great tuna, "the dark prince". The first sentence of the poem ends here, after 30 lines.

Lines 31–36

Now we learn he came back. His wife never spoke to him again or looked him in the eye. The neighbours treated him "as though he no longer existed". Only the children still chatted and laughed with him.

Lines 37–42

Slowly the children learned to be silent too, and to live as if he had never come home and was "no longer the father we loved." The daughter says that he must sometimes have wondered which was "the better way to die."

The turning point: line 31, "And though he came back". After 30 lines of flowing, colourful memory in one long sentence, the poem jumps to his return and the language goes bare and cold. The voice also changes: the daughter now speaks as "my mother" and "we children".

How it ends: "which had been the better way to die." He chose life, but his family's silence was a kind of death too. The poem does not answer the question; it leaves the reader to judge.

The tone: Calm and gentle while describing the sea, then flat, sad and regretful once he

returns. The daughter does not attack anyone; she quietly admits that she joined in the silence.

2 The poem, section by section

Kamikaze is still in copyright, so the full poem is not printed here. Read it in your anthology alongside these notes. Highlighted words are the short phrases worth learning for the exam. The poem is still in copyright, so

KEY WORDS TO QUOTE

LINES 1–6

Her father embarked at sunrise ... a samurai sword ... full of powerful incantations ... journey into history

LINES 7–12

she thought, / recounting it later to her children ... strung out like bunting ... green-blue translucent sea

LINES 13–18

like a huge flag waved ... the dark shoals of fishes / flashing silver

LINES 19–24

his brothers waiting on the shore ... bringing their father's boat safe

LINES 25–30

yes, grandfather's boat – safe ... salt-sodden, awash ... a tuna, the dark prince, muscular, dangerous.

WHAT IT MEANS, IN PLAIN ENGLISH

He sets off at dawn: Japan is often called the Land of the Rising Sun (WJEC). The sword links him to the old samurai warriors and their code of honour. His shaved head is filled with chanted words, perhaps prayers or the ideas he has been taught. He carries only enough fuel to get there, not back. “History” sounds glorious, but it also means he will soon be dead and in the past.

We learn this is a story the daughter tells her children, and that she is imagining what he saw (“he must have”). The fishing boats look like party bunting: a homely, happy image of ordinary life, the opposite of his mission. “Translucent” means clear enough to let light through.

A shoal of fish swirls like a flag. A flag might suggest his country, but this one is made of living nature. The figure of eight looks like the symbol for infinity, so nature goes on and on while his life is about to end (our reading).

The sea makes him remember being a boy, playing with his brothers as they waited for their father to come home from fishing. A cairn is a pile of stones, sometimes used as a memorial. The memory is about a father coming home safe: exactly what he can now choose to do.

The daughter's voice breaks in, explaining to her children who is who: the story is being passed down. Then a long list of fish: nature is rich and full of life. The powerful tuna, a “prince” of the sea, may suggest the strength and danger of nature. The first, 30-line sentence ends here.

LINES 31–36

And though he came back ... my mother never spoke again ... as though he no longer existed ... chattered and laughed

The decision itself is never shown: we just learn he came back. Now the daughter speaks for herself (“my mother”). His wife will not speak to him or meet his eyes, and the whole community acts as if he were dead. Only the children still talk and laugh.

LINES 37–42

we too learned / to be silent ... no longer the father we loved. ... the better way to die.

In the end the children copy the adults and shut him out. She admits it plainly. The final lines return to her reported words (“she said”) and imagine his thought: was it better to die in the attack, or to live like this, treated as dead?

3 Key quotations to learn

Learn these word for word. Short quotations score better than long ones.

LINES 3–4

“a shaven head / full of powerful incantations”

Means: his head is shaved and filled with chanted words or teachings. **Why it matters:** suggests he has been filled with ideas of duty by others, not thinking for himself. **Technique:** metaphor

LINES 5–6

“a one-way / journey into history”

Means: he has fuel to get there but not back; he will die and become part of history. **Why it matters:** his death is planned from the start; “history” makes it sound glorious, but it also means he will be gone. **Technique:** enjambment: the line breaks on “one-way”, so we feel the journey cut off.

LINES 10–11

“little fishing boats / strung out like bunting”

Means: the boats look like a string of party flags. **Why it matters:** a cheerful, homely image of ordinary life, which pulls him back. **Technique:** simile

LINES 16–17

“the dark shoals of fishes / flashing silver”

Means: huge groups of fish glinting in the sunlight. **Why it matters:** nature is beautiful and alive, the opposite of his deadly mission. **Technique:** sibilance and alliteration (“shoals”, “fishes”, “flashing silver”)

LINE 32

“my mother never spoke again”

Means: his wife never spoke to him again. **Why it matters:** the shift to “my” shows the daughter speaking for herself; silence is the family's punishment. **Technique:** shift from third to first person

LINES 34–35

“they treated him / as though he no longer existed”

Means: the neighbours acted as if he were dead. **Why it matters:** his community's rejection is a kind of social death. **Technique:** enjambment

LINE 42

"which had been the better way to die."

Means: was it better to die in the attack or to live, rejected, as if dead? **Why it matters:** a bitter, unanswered question that ends the poem.

Technique: irony

4 How the poet writes it (methods)

This is AO2: how the poet's choices create meaning.

The form: a story passed down, in tight stanzas and long sentences

ABOUT THE FORM

- A **narrative poem** tells a story. WJEC calls Kamikaze "a narrative poem" told mostly "through the reported speech of the pilot's daughter." WJEC **one source**
- There is "no set rhythm or rhyme", so it sounds like someone telling a story aloud. WJEC
- **Enjambment** is when the sense of a phrase carries on "beyond the end of a line of verse." Kamikaze uses it almost everywhere. Britannica

WHAT THIS POEM DOES WITH IT

- **Shape:** seven stanzas of exactly six lines (42 lines). The neat, regular shape could suggest the order and discipline expected of the pilot, while the sentences pour freely through it. **our count; our reading**
- **Only three sentences.** WJEC notes there are "only three sentences in the poem", each marking a key moment. Sentence 1 (lines 1–30) is the flight and his memories, all in one breath, like a mind drifting. Sentence 2 (lines 31–40) is his return and rejection. Sentence 3 (lines 41–42) is his question. WJEC; **our count**
- **Shifting voice:** a narrator reports what "*she thought*"; the daughter breaks in with "*yes, grandfather's boat*"; from line 32 she speaks herself ("*my mother*"); line 41 goes back to "*she said*". The pilot never speaks. His thoughts are only guessed: "*he must have*". **our reading**
- **Enjambment acts out the meaning:** "*a one-way / journey*" breaks off like the journey itself, and "*we too learned / to be silent*" lets the silence spill over the line. **our reading**

A sentence you could use: Garland tells Kamikaze second-hand, through a daughter's memories, so the pilot never speaks for himself; the form itself silences him, just as his family does after he returns.

Beautiful nature against a deadly mission

The sea is full of colour, movement and life: “green-blue translucent sea”, fish “flashing silver”. Nature reminds him that life is worth living. AQA's 2019 mark scheme names the “description of the natural world in ‘Kamikaze’”.

Sibilance: repeating “s” and “sh” sounds, here giving a soft, shimmering feel like the sea.

A story told second-hand

The story is reported (“she thought, / recounting it later to her children”) and the pilot's thoughts are guessed (“he must have”). We never hear him. This shows how far he has been shut out, and how the story is passed down through three generations.

Narrative perspective: the point of view a story is told from, such as first person (“I”) or third person (“he”).

Rich lists, then bare silence

Stanza 5 overflows with a list of the catch: mackerel, crabs, prawns, whitebait, tuna. After line 31 the language becomes plain and simple. The richness of life before his return is set against the emptiness after it.

Listing: a run of items one after another, often to show abundance or build up a picture.

An ironic last line

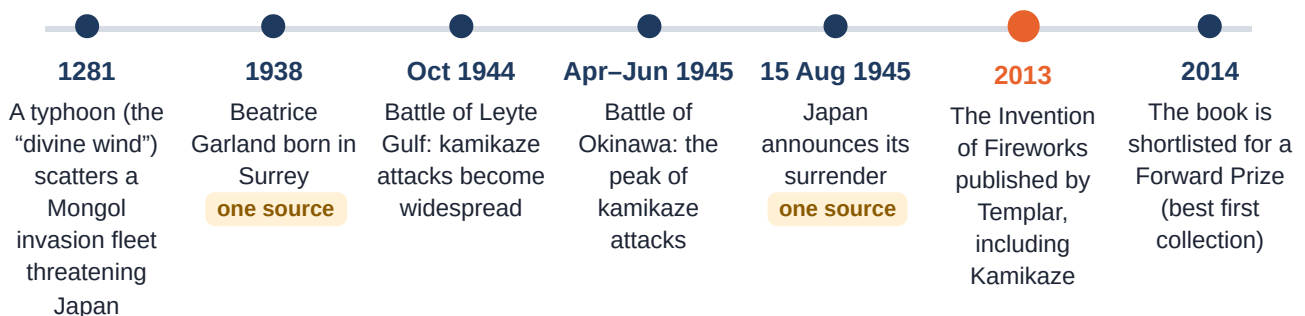
He survives, yet the family behaves as if he is dead. The poem ends on “the better way to die”: either way, he dies. AQA's 2022 mark scheme names “the internal conflict of beliefs and attitudes towards conflict” in Kamikaze.

Irony: when the result is the opposite of what someone meant or expected.

5 Context (AO3): the background you can use

Green labels show which kind of question each fact helps with. Context only earns marks when you link it to the poem's ideas.

TIMELINE



WHO GARLAND IS

An English poet, born in Surrey in 1938. WJEC

one source

After an English degree she worked as an NHS clinician, teacher and researcher in psychological medicine (the study of the mind and mental health). Templar Poetry; WJEC

effects of conflict · difficult experiences

She has said she spends much of her day “listening to other people’s worlds”. Kamikaze tells a story from a culture outside her own experience. WJEC

effects of conflict

one source, quoted second-hand

She has won the National Poetry Competition, one of the UK’s biggest poetry prizes (WJEC dates this to 2001), and the Stokestoun International Poetry Prize. Templar Poetry; WJEC

year: one source

Both her publisher and WJEC say her poems explore life and death in the natural world. That fits Kamikaze, where the sea pulls a man back to life. Templar Poetry; WJEC

nature

link to the poem: our reading

THE BOOK KAMIKAZE COMES FROM

Kamikaze is from *The Invention of Fireworks*, Garland's first collection, published by Templar Poetry in 2013. AQA anthology; Templar Poetry; WJEC

The book was shortlisted in the 2014 Forward Prizes for the Felix Dennis Prize for Best First Collection. (The winner was Liz Berry's *Black Country*.) Templar Poetry; Forward Arts Foundation

Templar says the book was “the winning submission to the 2013 Straid Collection Awards”, Templar's own prize. Templar Poetry

one source

No reliable source says the poem Kamikaze itself won a prize, and no reliable interview explains why she wrote it. Don't claim either.

our research gap

KAMIKAZE PILOTS

Kamikaze pilots were Japanese pilots who in the Second World War “made deliberate suicidal crashes into enemy targets, usually ships.” Britannica; WJEC **war · conflict**

Britannica says the attacks were most common from the Battle of Leyte Gulf (“October 1944”) “to the end of the war.” They peaked at Okinawa (April–June 1945). Britannica **war**

Most planes were ordinary fighters or light bombers loaded with bombs and extra fuel tanks. The poem’s fuel for a “one-way” trip fits this. Britannica **war · power**

link to the poem: our reading

Thousands of pilots died: the Guardian says “more than 3 800” by the end of the war.

Guardian (2015); WJEC **effects of conflict**

exact figure: one source

Don’t write that kamikaze pilots attacked Pearl Harbor (1941). Some revision notes say so, but Britannica does not: it says the attacks were most common from October 1944, and that the first US ship sunk by one was at Leyte Gulf that month. Britannica **accuracy**

HONOUR, DUTY AND COMING HOME (BACKGROUND, NOT FACTS FROM THE POEM)

Bushidō was the samurai warriors’ code. Britannica says the samurai’s “supreme obligation” was to his lord, even if this hurt his own parents. Britannica

patriotism and duty · power

In the war this code “revered self-sacrifice” and fighting “to the bitter end for emperor and country”, and surrender “was seen as dishonourable”. National WWII Museum; Britannica

patriotism and duty · conflict

“dishonourable”: one source

One surviving pilot told the Guardian: “we were commanded not to return.” He knew his superiors would be angry if he came back alive.

Guardian (2015) **effects of conflict · power**

one witness, one source

Another said he “just wanted to protect the father and mother I loved”, and that they were all scared. Like Garland’s pilot, he thought of family, not glory. Guardian (2015)

identity · effects of conflict

link to the poem: our reading

The samurai sword in the cockpit ties the pilot to this warrior tradition; samurai wore swords as a sign of their rank. No reliable source says families shunned pilots who turned back, so treat the family’s silence as the poem’s story, not a historical rule. Britannica; our reading

patriotism and duty

our reading

Putting it into an answer (AO3): Kamikaze pilots were sent on suicide missions in the last year of the Second World War. Japan’s warrior code, bushidō, praised self-sacrifice, and surrender was seen as dishonourable. Garland, who worked as an NHS clinician and speaks of “listening to other people’s worlds”, imagines one pilot who chooses life. His punishment is silence from his own family, which shows that the effects of conflict reach far beyond the battlefield.

6 Comparing it: the best partner poems

Pick the partner that fits the question's theme.

Kamikaze + Remains

A

Use for: **Effects of conflict** **Power** **Difficult experiences** · AQA: June 2024 mark scheme ("the impact of conflict on the individual, eg 'Remains'"); 2023 ("victim of the power of others, eg 'Kamikaze' or 'Remains'")

SIMILAR

- Both men survive but are changed for ever by one moment in a war.
- Both show a kind of living death: the looter is "here in my head"; the pilot lives as though he "had never returned".
- Both are victims of others' power: soldiers following orders, and a pilot sent on a "one-way / journey".

DIFFERENT

- **Choice:** Armitage's soldier did kill and is haunted by guilt; Garland's pilot turns back without attacking and is punished by others.
- **Voice:** Remains is a soldier's own voice, in slang ("legs it"); in Kamikaze the pilot never speaks: "he must have".
- **Where the suffering is:** inside his mind ("his bloody life in my bloody hands") against outside, in his family's silence.

Kamikaze + Poppies

B

Use for: **Effects of conflict** **Difficult experiences** **Memory** · AQA: 2017 mark scheme ("the effects of war on others", naming both); Nov 2020 ("difficult experiences on others", naming both); June 2024 mark scheme names Poppies

SIMILAR

- Both show war hurting a family at home, told by a family member, not a soldier.
- Both families fall silent: Weir's mother says "All my words / flattened"; Garland's children "learned / to be silent".
- Both turn to childhood memories: the son "when / you were little"; the pilot and "his brothers waiting on the shore".

DIFFERENT

- **Who is lost:** Weir's son leaves and may never return; Garland's pilot comes home but is treated "as though he no longer existed".
- **Feeling:** Poppies is full of love and fear; Kamikaze shows shame and rejection, and the daughter's regret.
- **Ending:** Weir ends in hope and longing, "hoping to hear" his voice; Garland ends on a bitter question about "the better way to die."

Kamikaze + The Charge of the Light Brigade

C

Use for: **Patriotism and duty** **Conflict** **Effects of conflict** · AQA: 2019 mark scheme ("the effects of war on attitudes", naming Charge and Kamikaze); June 2022 ("questioning of accepted ideologies"); 2025

SIMILAR

- Both show men sent to almost certain death by those in charge: *"Theirs but to do and die"* and fuel for a *"one-way / journey"*.
- Both link death in battle with glory: *"When can their glory fade?"* and a *"journey into history"*.

DIFFERENT

- **Attitude to duty:** Tennyson praises obedience (*"Honour the Light Brigade"*); Garland shows a man who turns back, and questions whether dying for duty is right.
- **Honour:** the riders win honour by riding into death; the pilot meets shame by choosing life.
- **Form and voice:** Tennyson's driving rhythm and refrain celebrate the *"six hundred"* together; Garland's quiet, unrhymed story focuses on one man and his family.

7 In the exam

A likely question: Compare how poets present the ways people are affected by conflict in 'Kamikaze' and in one other poem from 'Power and conflict'. (AQA's June 2024 wording)

A strong opening (thesis): Both Garland and Weir show conflict wounding families at home, but where Weir's mother is silenced by love and fear, Garland's family chooses silence as a punishment, so the pilot who survived is treated as if he had died.

A model comparison paragraph:

Both poets show conflict damaging a family far from the fighting, and both show it through silence. Garland's daughter remembers that her mother *"never spoke again / in his presence"*, and that the children *"too learned / to be silent"*. The enjambment carries the silence over the line break, as if it spreads through the whole family. Weir's mother is silenced too: *"All my words / flattened, rolled, turned into felt"*, a sewing metaphor that makes her words soft and useless. However, the causes are opposite. Weir's silence comes from love and fear as her son leaves; Garland's comes from shame, because the father came home. Ironically, the man who survived is treated *"as though he no longer existed"*, so Garland suggests that a culture of duty can kill a person socially even when he lives.

Why it scores:

- Opens with a clear comparative point about how people are affected, answering the question directly
- Short, exact quotations from both poems, with methods named and explained (enjambment, metaphor, irony)
- Compares the causes of each family's silence (love against shame), which links to context and to AQA's "internal conflict"

PRACTICE

Model answers

Three full answers to real AQA questions, one for each anchor poem and each type of question: power, difficult experiences and conflict. Beside every paragraph, a panel explains exactly what earns the marks, using AQA's own words.

These answers were written to AQA's top-level (Level 6) descriptors. They have not been marked by AQA, and nobody outside AQA can guarantee a mark.

Ozymandias and My Last Duchess

“Compare how poets present ideas about power in ‘Ozymandias’ and in one other poem from ‘Power and conflict’.” [30 marks]

AQA, June 2018, Question 26

This answer was written to match AQA's Level 6 descriptors. It has not been marked by AQA, and no one can guarantee a mark, but every part is designed to hit a top-level requirement. About 700 words: a realistic length for 45 minutes.

Where the 30 marks come from

AO1 · IDEAS AND ARGUMENT

12

A clear argument that answers the question, compares the two poems, and uses well-chosen short quotations.

AO2 · HOW THE POETS WRITE

12

Close analysis of words, structure and form, and the *effect* each choice creates.

AO3 · CONTEXT

6

The ideas and times behind the poems, linked to the question, not a history lesson.

Step 1: the 5-minute plan

- **Pick the partner:** the question is about power, so choose *My Last Duchess*: another arrogant ruler. AQA's specimen mark scheme suggests this pairing.
- **Big idea (thesis):** both rulers think their power will last and give themselves away through their own words. Shelley's tyrant has already been destroyed by time; Browning's is still alive and dangerous.
- **Three comparison points:** 1. the rulers' pride and words; 2. power as giving orders (“command”); 3. art and who controls it. Then form, context and a judgement.

Step 2: the answer, with what earns the marks

INTRODUCTION

Both Shelley and Browning present power as something arrogant men abuse and wrongly believe will last forever, and both poets let the powerful condemn themselves through their own words. However, while Shelley shows a tyrant whose power has already been destroyed by time, Browning shows a tyrant whose power is still alive, which makes *My Last Duchess* the more disturbing warning.

AO1

- **Answers the question in the first sentence**, using its key word, “power”.
- Sets up a **similarity and a difference**, so the whole essay is a comparison.
- Ends with a **judgement** (“more disturbing”) to prove later.

Mark scheme, Level 6: “It takes a conceptualised approach to the full task”. **Examiners (2020):** students who began with “a thesis statement ... tended to be more successful with AO1.”

PARAGRAPH 1 · PRIDE IN THEIR OWN WORDS

Ozymandias's pride is clearest in the words carved on his statue: “*king of kings*”. The title places him above every other ruler, and the imperative “*Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!*” commands rival kings to feel hopeless before his greatness. Yet Shelley follows it at once with the blunt, short sentence “*Nothing beside remains.*” The boast is cut dead, and the command turns against him: rulers should despair, but only because their works will crumble too. Browning's Duke shows the same pride in status when he complains that his wife ranked “*My gift of a nine-hundred-years-old name*” with anybody else's gift. Calling his family name a “gift” reveals that he sees his status as a favour he hands down to others, and the long hyphenated phrase makes his ancestry sound heavy and self-important.

AO1

AO2

- **Short, precise quotations**, built into sentences.
- **Zooms in on single words** (“despair”, “gift”) and explains what they suggest.
- Uses terms (**imperative**) only where they help, then **explains the effect**.
- Moves between the poems in the same paragraph.

Level 6: “Judicious use of precise references” and “a fine-grained and insightful analysis of methods”.

Examiners (2023): “A well-selected word or phrase ... is often much more effective than a long direct quotation.”

PARAGRAPH 2 · POWER MEANS GIVING ORDERS

For both rulers, power means giving orders, and both poets use the same word to show it. Shelley's sculptor captured the king's "*sneer of cold command*": the harsh, repeated "c" sounds make his rule sound cruel and unfeeling. Browning's Duke uses the word himself: "*I gave commands; / Then all smiles stopped together.*" The semicolon creates a sharp pause, and the plain words hide a murder inside a single calm sentence. This is more chilling than Shelley's sneer, because the Duke never admits what he did; his polite understatement shows how easily absolute power ends a life.

AO1

AO2

- **An original link:** both poems use the word "command". Spotting connections like this makes the comparison **exploratory**.
- Analyses **sound** ("c" sounds) and **punctuation** (semicolon), each tied to meaning.
- **Evaluates** which is more chilling, and says why.

Level 6: "Critical, exploratory comparison" and "Exploration of effects of writer's methods".

Examiners (2022): naming techniques "will not achieve above Level 2 AO2 if it is not tied to meaning."

PARAGRAPH 3 · ART AND WHO CONTROLS IT

Both poems present a work of art that outlives the person it shows, but they disagree about who controls it. In *Ozymandias*, the artist has the final word: "*The hand that mock'd them*" suggests the sculptor both copied the king's passions and made fun of them, so art judges the tyrant. In *My Last Duchess*, the tyrant owns the art. The Duke keeps his wife's portrait behind "*The curtain I have drawn for you*", so even after her death he decides who may look at her. He ends by pointing out another possession: "*Notice Neptune, though, / Taming a sea-horse,*". The image of a god "taming" a creature mirrors how he tamed his wife.

AO1

AO2

- A **less obvious idea** (art and power) shows independent thinking.
- Explains a word with **two meanings** ("mock'd"): the kind of detail top answers notice.
- Uses a **symbol** (the curtain, Neptune), which the 2023 examiners praised.

Examiners (2023): "highly-effective discussion of the impact of 'the curtain', the image of the statue of Neptune".

PARAGRAPH 4 · FORM AND STRUCTURE

The poets' choices of voice support these ideas. Shelley never lets *Ozymandias* speak directly: the poem is a story within a story, beginning “*I met a traveller from an antique land*”, so the king reaches us second-hand, pushed far into the past, and the poem ends not on him but on “*The lone and level sands*”. Time and nature have the last word. Browning does the opposite. As a dramatic monologue, the poem gives the Duke every word, and his silent listener never replies. The Duke controls the conversation just as he controlled his wife, and the tight rhyming couplets reflect that control, even while his words reveal more than he intends.

AO2

- Structure through **openings and endings**, as the examiners recommend.
- Form (**dramatic monologue**) is linked to the idea of control, not just named.
- **No rhyme-scheme spotting** and no “sonnets are love poems”.

Examiners (2023): helpful structure points are “openings/endings”. They praised “Browning's use of dramatic monologue to depict megalomania” and using perspective “to indicate the passage of time”.

PARAGRAPH 5 · CONTEXT LINKED TO IDEAS

The poets' attitudes to power reflect their own beliefs. Shelley was a radical who, in Britannica's words, “rejected the monarchy, religion, war, and commerce”, and he published *Ozymandias* in 1818, when the editors of the newspaper that printed it had been jailed for attacking the Prince Regent. His poem reassures readers that no ruler lasts forever. Browning, a Victorian poet famous for the dramatic monologue, takes us inside the mind of a tyrant instead. By letting the Duke speak, he exposes how power used purely for personal pride destroys the people under it, which is a warning about the responsibility that comes with power.

AO3

- Context explains **why the poets think as they do**, and links straight to the question.
- **No history lesson**: one or two facts, then back to the idea.
- Ends on **responsibility and abuse of power**, which the examiners rewarded.

Level 6: “specific, detailed links between context/text/task”.

Examiners (2023): answers on “the responsibilities / abuse of power, fared much better” than those that stayed in the story.

CONCLUSION · THE JUDGEMENT

Both poets present power as arrogant, controlling and ultimately self-defeating, because both rulers condemn themselves with their own words. But Shelley offers hope: time has already turned Ozymandias's empire into empty sand. Browning offers none. The Duke is still in power, already arranging his next marriage, so the danger has not ended. That is why *My Last Duchess* is the more frightening presentation of power: Shelley's tyrant is history, but Browning's could strike again.

AO1

- **Returns to the thesis** from the introduction.
- Makes a clear **evaluative judgement** and gives a reason for it.
- Short: the conclusion pulls ideas together and adds no new quotations.

AQA's example answer

commentary: "By the end, this comparison becomes evaluative as there is a judgement made as to which poem demonstrates the effects of power more strongly."

Checklist: why this reaches the top level

- ✓ **One big idea** (a thesis) stated at the start and proved all the way through.
- ✓ **Both poems** in almost every paragraph, so it is a comparison throughout.
- ✓ **Short quotations**, with individual words explained.
- ✓ Every technique **linked to its effect** and to the question about power.
- ✓ Structure through **openings, endings and voice**, not rhyme schemes.
- ✓ **Context used to explain ideas**, briefly, never as a history lesson.
- ✓ A clear **judgement** at the end.

Remember: you don't need to write this much to do well. AQA says comparison can also be done by introducing the link, writing about each poem in turn, then drawing them together at the end. What matters most is a clear argument, close analysis of words, and context tied to the question.

Quotations: AQA anthology, Poems Past and Present. Mark-scheme and examiners' report wording: AQA specimen, 2018, 2020, 2022, 2023 and 2025 documents. Context: Britannica. Written to the AQA mark scheme; not an official AQA exemplar and not marked by AQA.

Remains and War Photographer

“Compare how poets present the ways people are affected by difficult experiences in ‘Remains’ and in one other poem from ‘Power and conflict’.” [30 marks]

AQA, November 2020 (the June 2020 paper), Question 26

This answer was written to match AQA's Level 6 descriptors. It has not been marked by AQA, and no one can guarantee a mark, but every part is designed to hit a top-level requirement. Remains is printed on the exam paper; War Photographer is written from memory, so its quotations are kept short. About 700 words: a realistic length for 45 minutes.

Step 1: the 5-minute plan

- **Pick the partner:** the question is about how people are affected, so choose War Photographer: another man who brings a violent death home with him. AQA's mark scheme for this question names it, and the examiners said it “was used by many students”.
- **Big idea (thesis):** both poems show a difficult experience that does not stay in the past, and a man who has no power to escape it. Armitage's soldier is haunted by a death he caused; Duffy's photographer by deaths he could only record, and by a public that does not care.
- **Three comparison points:** 1. the violence itself; 2. how the experience comes back later; 3. who else is affected (or not). Then voice and endings, context, and a judgement.

Step 2: the answer, with what earns the marks

INTRODUCTION

Both Armitage and Duffy present difficult experiences as wounds that do not stay in the past: each man carries a violent death home with him, and neither has the power to escape it. However, Armitage's soldier is haunted by guilt for a death he caused, while Duffy's photographer is haunted by deaths he could only record, and by a public that does not care. *Remains* shows the deeper personal damage, but *War Photographer* spreads the blame wider, to us.

AO1

- **Answers the question in the first sentence**, using its key words: “difficult experiences” and how people are affected.
- Sets up a **similarity and a difference**, so the whole essay is a comparison.
- Ends with a **judgement** to prove later.

Mark scheme, Level 6: “It takes a conceptualised approach to the full task”. **Examiners (Nov 2020):** “students who spent time thinking about the focus of the question performed better than those who provided a response just to the text rather than to the text through the lens of the task.”

PARAGRAPH 1 · THE VIOLENCE ITSELF

Both poets confront the reader with brutal images of violence. Armitage's speaker says “*I see every round as it rips through his life*”: the harsh alliteration of “round” and “rips” sounds like tearing, and “his life”, not “his body”, shows that a whole person is destroyed. The vague phrase “*sort of inside out*” suggests he has no proper words for what he saw. Duffy's violence is quieter but just as disturbing. The photographer remembers “*the cries / of this man's wife*” and “*how the blood stained into foreign dust.*” “Foreign” shows the distance between where the suffering happens and the safe England where it becomes pictures.

AO1

AO2

- **Short, precise quotations**, built into sentences.
- **Zooms in on single words** (“life”, “foreign”) and explains what they suggest.
- Names a technique (**alliteration**) only to **explain its effect**.
- Moves between the poems in the same paragraph.

Mark scheme (Nov 2020), AO2: “use of brutal, vivid imagery such as ‘War Photographer’ or ‘Exposure’”. **AO3:** “any treatment of the effects of experiencing violence”.

PARAGRAPH 2 · THE EXPERIENCE COMES BACK

In both poems the experience returns long after it is over. Armitage's blunt line *"End of story, except not really."* is the turning point: the soldier tries to close the story, then admits he cannot. Back home, the looter *"bursts again through the doors of the bank"*, and the verb "bursts" makes the memory as sudden and violent as the event. The military metaphor *"dug in behind enemy lines"* suggests the dead man is now the enemy, occupying the soldier's mind like a trench. Duffy shows the same delayed effect through the photographer's body: his hands *"did not tremble then / though seem to now."* "Then" and "now" show the shock arriving only once he is safe. As the photograph develops, *"a half-formed ghost"* appears, so the image rising on the paper mirrors the memory rising in his mind.

AO1

AO2

- Spots the **turning point** in Remains and explains it, not just quotes it.
- Explains a **metaphor** ("dug in") and the contrast of two small words ("then", "now"): fine-grained analysis.
- Finds a **shared idea** (delayed trauma) shown through different methods.

Mark scheme (Nov 2020), AO1: "any valid comparison of the effects of the first-hand experience of difficult experiences on the individual, such as 'Bayonet Charge' or 'Exposure' or 'War Photographer'". **Level 6:** "a fine-grained and insightful analysis".

PARAGRAPH 3 · WHO ELSE IS AFFECTED

The poets differ in who shares the burden. Armitage's soldier is completely alone: *"the drink and the drugs won't flush him out"*, and "flush" suggests he is trying, and failing, to wash the memory away. Duffy goes further and shows the people at home who are hardly affected at all. From *"A hundred agonies in black-and-white"* the editor will choose only *"five or six"*, and the reader's *"eyeballs prick / with tears between the bath and pre-lunch beers."* Their sympathy is squeezed between two comforts. So both men are powerless in different ways: the soldier cannot control his own mind, and the photographer cannot make anyone care.

AO1

AO2

- Widens the question to **people not directly involved**: a less obvious, more exploratory idea.
- Uses the idea of **powerlessness**, which the Nov 2020 examiners singled out in the best answers.
- Every quotation is **tied to the question**, not left to speak for itself.

Examiners (Nov 2020): "some of the best responses took a wider approach to the task focus and wrote very effectively about how two poets explore ideas about the lack of individual power as their interpretation of 'difficult experiences'."

PARAGRAPH 4 · VOICE AND ENDINGS

The poets' choices of voice match these experiences.

Armitage writes in the first person, in a soldier's everyday speech (“*legs it*”, “*my mates*”), so we hear the trauma from the inside. Duffy uses the third person, keeping the same distance from the photographer that his job forces him to keep from his subjects. Her regular stanzas echo his “*spools of suffering set out in ordered rows*”: an attempt to put chaos in order. The endings show the difference. *Remains* closes on a short two-line final stanza, “*his bloody life in my bloody hands.*” “Bloody” is both literal and a swear word, and the guilt has no end. *War Photographer* ends instead on the public: “*they do not care.*”

PARAGRAPH 5 · CONTEXT LINKED TO IDEAS

The poets' purposes explain these differences. Armitage wrote *Remains* for *The Not Dead*, poems based on the testimonies of real ex-soldiers, men whom his website describes as having “seldom been heard before”. That is why the poem sounds like a spoken confession. Duffy was a friend of war photographers and was interested in people who must record horror without being able to help. Her poem is therefore about more than one man: it criticises a comfortable society that looks at suffering in a Sunday magazine and then forgets it.

AO2

- **Person** (first vs third) is linked to closeness and distance, not just named.
- Structure through **endings**, as the examiners recommend.
- Explains a word with **two meanings** (“bloody”), and **no rhyme-scheme spotting**.

Mark scheme (Nov 2020), AO2:

“comparison of use of person to create a sense of

immediacy/distance”. **Examiners**

(2022): structure “can achieve highly, for instance, the effects of openings and last lines. However, the observation of a rhyme scheme [ABAB] is best avoided.”

AO3

- Context explains **why the poets write as they do**, and links straight back to the question.
- **No history lesson**: one fact per poet, and no extra detail about the real soldier.
- Moves from the individual to **society**, a wider idea.

Level 6: “specific, detailed links between context/text/task”.

Examiners (2022): “extraneous information about Guardsman Tromans were not useful if they meant the student lost sight of the poem.”

CONCLUSION · THE JUDGEMENT

Both poets show that difficult experiences change people permanently and leave them powerless. Armitage's soldier suffers the deeper wound: his guilt is inside him, and the poem ends with no way out. But Duffy's poem is the more accusing. It suggests that the real difficult experience is not only what the photographer saw, but that nobody else wants to see it, and that makes the reader part of the problem.

AO1

- **Returns to the thesis** from the introduction.
- Makes a clear **evaluative judgement** and gives a reason for it.
- Short: the conclusion pulls ideas together and adds no new quotations.

Examiners (Nov 2020): "Students who began their answer with a thesis statement that they could develop / explain / illustrate during their response, and perhaps return to at the end, tended to be more successful with AO1."

Checklist: why this reaches the top level

- ✓ **One big idea** (a thesis) stated at the start and proved all the way through.
- ✓ **Both poems** in almost every paragraph, so it is a comparison throughout.
- ✓ **Short quotations**, with individual words explained.
- ✓ Every technique **linked to its effect** and to the question about difficult experiences.
- ✓ Voice and **endings** used for structure, not rhyme schemes.
- ✓ **Context used to explain ideas**, briefly, never as a history lesson.
- ✓ A clear **judgement** at the end.

Remember: you don't need to write this much to do well. AQA says comparison can also be done by introducing the link, writing about each poem in turn, then drawing them together at the end. What matters most is a clear argument, close analysis of words, and context tied to the question.

Quotations: AQA anthology, Poems Past and Present. Mark-scheme and examiners' report wording: AQA November 2020 (June 2020 paper), specimen and 2022 documents. Context: Simon Armitage's official website (The Not Dead) and WJEC GCSE fact sheets on Remains and War Photographer. Written to the AQA mark scheme; not an official AQA exemplar and not marked by AQA.

Exposure and Storm on the Island

“Compare how poets present ideas about conflict in ‘Exposure’ and in one other poem from ‘Power and conflict’.” [30 marks]

AQA, June 2025, Question 26

This answer was written to match AQA's Level 6 descriptors. It has not been marked by AQA, and no one can guarantee a mark, but every part is designed to hit a top-level requirement. About 700 words: a realistic length for 45 minutes. It shows how to use your nature poem for a conflict question.

Where the 30 marks come from

AO1 · IDEAS AND ARGUMENT

12

A clear argument that answers the question, compares the two poems, and uses well-chosen short quotations.

AO2 · HOW THE POETS WRITE

12

Close analysis of words, structure and form, and the *effect* each choice creates.

AO3 · CONTEXT

6

The ideas and times behind the poems, linked to the question, not a history lesson.

Step 1: the 5-minute plan

- **Pick the partner:** the question is about conflict, and in Exposure the soldiers' worst enemy is the weather. So choose Storm on the Island: a community under attack from a storm. The June 2025 mark scheme suggests exactly this: “possible consideration of conflict with nature/the elements such as ‘Storm on the Island’”.
- **Be careful:** in 2022 the examiners said Storm on the Island was “arguably a little more challenging in terms of focus and comparison” for a conflict question. So say the word “conflict” in every paragraph and keep showing that the storm is described as a war.
- **Big idea (thesis):** both poets present nature as an enemy that attacks people who can only sit and wait. Heaney's islanders are left alive but facing “nothing”; Owen's soldiers are killed by it while “nothing happens”.
- **Three comparison points:** 1. nature as a weapon; 2. powerless waiting and the word “nothing”; 3. comfort that turns hostile. Then openings and endings, context and a judgement.

Step 2: the answer, with what earns the marks

INTRODUCTION

Both Owen and Heaney present conflict as a war between people and nature, in which the weather is the real enemy and humans can do nothing but wait. However, Heaney's islanders are ready for the attack and nobody dies, while Owen's soldiers are already fighting one war and are slowly killed by a second. This makes *Exposure* the darker presentation of conflict, because nature finishes what the war started.

AO1

- **Answers the question in the first sentence**, using its key word, "conflict".
- Explains straight away **why a storm poem fits a conflict question**: it is a war with nature.
- Sets up a **similarity, a difference and a judgement** ("darker") to prove later.

Mark scheme, Level 6 (2025): "It takes a conceptualised approach to the full task". **Examiners (2020):** students who began with "a thesis statement ... tended to be more successful with AO1."

PARAGRAPH 1 · NATURE AS A WEAPON

Both poets turn the weather into a weapon. Owen opens with "*the merciless iced east winds that knife us*": "merciless" gives the wind a cruel human will, and the verb "knife" turns it into a soldier stabbing the men. He then says the bullets are "*Less deadly than the air that shudders black with snow*", so the natural enemy is more dangerous than the human one. Heaney uses military words for a storm: the wind "*strafes invisibly*", "*Space is a salvo,*" and "*We are bombarded by the empty air.*" These are words for attacks by aircraft and guns, so an ordinary storm becomes an air raid. The difference is that Heaney's war is a metaphor, while Owen's men face a real war and nature joins in against them.

AO1

AO2

- **Short, precise quotations** from both poems, built into sentences.
- **Zooms in on single words** ("merciless", "knife", "strafes") and explains what they suggest.
- Groups Heaney's **war words** together, then explains their effect instead of just naming a "semantic field".

Mark scheme (2025): "relevant treatment of the use of natural imagery to present ideas about conflict, such as 'Storm on the Island', or 'Bayonet Charge'". **Level 6:** "Judicious use of precise references to support interpretation(s)".

PARAGRAPH 2 · POWERLESS WAITING AND “NOTHING”

In both poems, the people in the conflict cannot fight back. Owen's refrain “*But nothing happens.*” is repeated at the end of four stanzas, so the poem itself seems stuck, like the soldiers waiting for an attack that never comes. The blunt question “*What are we doing here?*” shows they no longer understand why they are fighting. Heaney's islanders are just as passive: “*We just sit tight while wind dives*”. Strikingly, both poets use the word “nothing”. Heaney ends with “*Strange, it is a huge nothing that we fear.*” The enemy is invisible air, and the oxymoron “huge nothing” makes it impossible to fight. For Owen, “nothing” is worse: nothing happens, yet men are dying anyway.

AO1

AO2

- **An original link:** both poems use the word “nothing”. Spotting connections like this makes the comparison **exploratory**.
- Explains **repetition** (the refrain) by its effect: the poem feels stuck, like the men.
- Uses one term (**oxymoron**) only because it helps explain the idea.

Mark scheme (2025): “use and effect of particular features to create meanings, such as effects of sibilance, or repetition, or imagery” and “ideas about power/powerlessness”. **Level 6:** “Critical, exploratory comparison”.

PARAGRAPH 3 · COMFORT THAT TURNS HOSTILE

Both poets show that, in conflict, even comforting things turn against people. Heaney admits “*You might think that the sea is company,*” but it “*spits like a tame cat / Turned savage.*” The simile makes something cosy and domestic attack, so nothing on the island is safe. Owen's soldiers dream of home: “*Slowly our ghosts drag home*”, but they find “*on us the doors are closed*”. Calling themselves “ghosts” suggests they already feel dead, and the closed doors show they are shut out from the life they are fighting for. Owen then takes the conflict deeper, into their faith: “*For love of God seems dying.*” Heaney's conflict stays outside the house; Owen's reaches the soldiers' minds and beliefs.

AO1

AO2

- A **less obvious idea** (comfort turning hostile) shows independent thinking.
- Explains **why** the simile and the word “ghosts” matter, not just that they are there.
- Shows conflict can be **internal** as well as physical.

Level 6 (2025): “a fine-grained and insightful analysis of methods” and “Exploration of effects of writer's methods to create meanings”.

PARAGRAPH 4 · OPENINGS AND ENDINGS

The poems' openings and endings show how the conflicts end. Heaney begins confidently: “*We are prepared:*”. The colon introduces a list of defences, and the chatty “*you know what I mean*” sounds calm. Yet the poem ends on the word “fear”: his confidence has collapsed. Owen starts in pain, “*Our brains ache*”, and ends with a burial party finding frozen men: “*All their eyes are ice,*”. It then closes on the refrain once more. Heaney's islanders are frightened but alive; Owen's ending treats death as if it were nothing at all, which is his bitterest point.

AO2

- Structure through **openings and endings**, as the examiners recommend.
- Tracks a **change in tone** (confident to fearful) and links it to the idea of conflict.
- **No rhyme-scheme spotting** and no list of caesura and enjambment.

Examiners (2023): helpful structure points are “openings/endings, plot development, changes of pace / scene”. **Examiners (2022):** naming techniques “will not achieve above Level 2 AO2 if it is not tied to meaning.”

PARAGRAPH 5 · CONTEXT LINKED TO IDEAS

These differences come from the poets' experiences. Owen wrote from the front line: at the end of January 1917 his platoon spent two days and nights without shelter in a snowstorm, and the Wilfred Owen Association says that in *Exposure* “passive suffering is what it is all about.” That is why his soldiers never fight: Owen shows ordinary men left powerless in a war decided by others, and he was himself killed a week before it ended. Heaney's war is imagined. A 1976 review of his first collection noticed that he often describes nature through weapons, comparing bullfrogs to “mud grenades”. In *Storm on the Island* this habit shows how small any community is in conflict with the elements.

AO3

- Context explains **why the poets present conflict as they do**, and links straight to the question.
- **No history lesson:** one or two facts for each poet, then back to the idea.
- Ends on **powerlessness**, an idea the 2025 mark scheme lists for AO3.

Mark scheme (2025): “ideas about conflict with the natural world” and “possible exploration of ideas about the ways individuals are affected by wider conflict”. **Examiners (2022):** paragraphs about “Owen's war experiences” were “not useful if they meant the student lost sight of the poem.”

CONCLUSION · THE JUDGEMENT

Both poets present conflict as a struggle with nature in which humans are powerless against an enemy they cannot fight. But Heaney's conflict ends in fear, not death: his community is prepared, and nobody dies. Owen's ends with frozen bodies and the flat words "nothing happens". That is why *Exposure* is the more disturbing presentation of conflict: for Heaney nature is a frightening enemy, but for Owen it is one more enemy for men who were already losing a war.

AO1

- **Returns to the thesis** from the introduction.
- Makes a clear **evaluative judgement** and gives a reason for it.
- Short: the conclusion pulls ideas together and adds no new evidence.

AQA's example answer

commentary: "By the end, this comparison becomes evaluative as there is a judgement made as to which poem demonstrates the effects of power more strongly." The same move works for conflict.

Checklist: why this reaches the top level

- ✓ **One big idea** (a thesis) stated at the start and proved all the way through.
- ✓ A **nature poem made to fit a conflict question**: every paragraph says how nature is presented as an enemy.
- ✓ **Both poems** in every paragraph, so it is a comparison throughout.
- ✓ **Short quotations**, with individual words explained.
- ✓ Every technique **linked to its effect** and to the question about conflict.
- ✓ Structure through **openings, endings and repetition**, not rhyme schemes.
- ✓ **Context used to explain ideas**, briefly, never as a history lesson.
- ✓ A clear **judgement** at the end.

Remember: Storm on the Island is not a war poem, so it only works for a conflict question if you keep showing that Heaney describes the storm as a war. If the question is about the effects of war on soldiers, a war poem such as Remains or Bayonet Charge may be a safer partner.

Quotations: AQA anthology, Poems Past and Present. Mark-scheme and examiners' report wording: AQA 2020, 2022, 2023 and 2025 documents and AQA's example answer commentary. Context: Wilfred Owen Association (Merryn Williams), London Review of Books (Mark Ford), Poetry Archive, New York Review of Books (Richard Murphy, 1976). Written to the AQA mark scheme; not an official AQA exemplar and not marked by AQA.

★ AQA's own example answer

AQA has published one example answer to a Power and Conflict question, with an examiner's comments. It answers the specimen question on Ozymandias, paired with My Last Duchess.

How it opens: “Both Ozymandias and My Last Duchess show the effects of power and how it corrupts. Shelley describes Ozymandias’ ‘sneer of cold command’ as if to suggest that he is a cruel and heartless leader, only concerned with his own power and the immortality it will bring.”

The examiner's summary: “A thoughtful comparison which becomes exploratory as it develops. The student holds both poems together which enables a considered comparison to be made as to the extent to which both poems deal with ideas about power. By the end, this comparison becomes evaluative as there is a judgement made as to which poem demonstrates the effects of power more strongly.”

What to copy: answer the question for both poems in your first sentence; keep both poems in play; end with a judgement about which poem shows the idea more strongly, and why.

Source: AQA, “GCSE English Literature Assessment” guide (AQA-8702-EX-COMMENTARY). AQA calls it an “Exemplar response” and gives no mark.

Glossary: the terms in this guide

You only need a term if it helps you explain an effect. Examiners reward the effect, not the label.

Term	What it means	Example from the poems
Alliteration	Words close together starting with the same sound	“sneer of cold command” (Ozymandias)
Sibilance	Repeated “s” sounds, often hissing or soft	“Sudden successive flights of bullets streak the silence” (Exposure)
Metaphor	Describing one thing as if it were another	“Space is a salvo,” (Storm on the Island)
Simile	A comparison using “like” or “as”	“spits like a tame cat” (Storm on the Island)
Personification	Giving something non-human human actions or feelings	the mountain “Strode after me.” (The Prelude)
Imperative	A command	“Look on my works, ye Mighty, and despair!” (Ozymandias)
Oxymoron / paradox	Two opposite ideas put together	“marriage hearse” (London); “a huge nothing” (Storm on the Island)
Irony	When the result is the opposite of what someone meant or expected	the boast followed by “Nothing beside remains.” (Ozymandias)
Enjambment	A sentence running on over a line break	“a one-way / journey into history” (Kamikaze)
Caesura	A pause or full stop in the middle of a line	“Belfast. Beirut. Phnom Penh.” (War Photographer)
Refrain	A line repeated through a poem	“But nothing happens.” (Exposure)
Volta	The “turn” in a poem, where the thought changes direction	“End of story, except not really.” (Remains)
Sonnet	A 14-line poem, usually in iambic pentameter with a set rhyme pattern	Ozymandias

Blank verse	Unrhymed lines of about ten syllables with a regular beat	Extract from The Prelude
Dramatic monologue	A poem spoken by one character who is not the poet, often to a silent listener	My Last Duchess
Free verse	Poetry with no regular rhyme or rhythm	Poppies
Dialect	The way a language is spoken in a particular place or community	“Dem tell me” (Checking Out Me History)
Romantic poets	A group of poets around 1800, including Wordsworth and Shelley. Britannica says Lyrical Ballads (1798) “helped launch the English Romantic movement”.	Ozymandias, The Prelude

Sources

Every poem quotation was checked word for word against AQA's anthology text. Context facts name their source beside the fact; "one source" and "our reading" labels show where to take care.

- **The poems:** [AQA anthology](#), [Poems Past and Present \(sample text\)](#).
- **Specification:** [AQA GCSE English Literature 8702](#)
- **Question papers and mark schemes:** specimen ([paper](#), [mark scheme](#)); Nov 2020 ([paper](#), [mark scheme](#)); Nov 2021 ([paper](#), [mark scheme](#)); June 2022 ([paper](#), [mark scheme](#)); June 2023 ([paper](#), [mark scheme](#)). June 2017, 2018, 2019, 2024 and 2025 are not on AQA's public site; copies are on Physics & Maths Tutor, e.g. [June 2025 paper](#) and [mark scheme](#).
- **Examiners' reports:** [Nov 2020](#), [Nov 2021](#), [June 2022](#), [June 2023](#)
- **AQA example answer:** [GCSE English Literature Assessment guide](#)
- **Background:** named beside each fact on the poem pages: Britannica, the British Museum, the British Library, the National Army Museum, the Poetry Archive, the Wilfred Owen Association, the Seamus Heaney estate, Simon Armitage's official site, universities (Oxford, Toronto, Chicago, Manchester, Iowa), Gale's Poetry for Students, EBSCO Research Starters, publishers (Bloodaxe), and the exam boards WJEC and Pearson.

This guide was written to the AQA mark scheme. It is not an official AQA document.